

# Restoration



of the Orthodox Churches  
Monuments in Albania

*Published with the blessing of His Beatitude,  
Archbishop of Tirana, Durrës and Albania  
Professor Doctor Anastasios*



THE ORTHODOX AUTOCEPHALOUS CHURCH OF ALBANIA

**RESTORATION  
OF THE ORTHODOX CHURCH  
MONUMENTS IN ALBANIA**

TIRANA, 2005



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## FOREWORD



When I arrived in Albania in 1991 as the Patriarchal Exarch of the Ecumenical Patriarchate to look into what was left from the Orthodox Church after the long and severe persecution against the Church, I was faced with a tragic view. In most cases we were obliged to perform the Holy Liturgy and other religious meetings in open venues, - where in the past there used to be monasteries or churches, - in partly ruined churches or even under large trees. Important Orthodox churches had been entirely demolished, with hotels built instead (in Tirana), an officers' club (in Shkodra), barracks (St. Theodore in Himara), or various buildings for other purposes (in Durrës, Vlora, Korça, Fier and Saranda). Many of the churches had been entirely destroyed, and there were no traces left. Many others had suffered dramatic changes of appearance, in order to become museums (in Korça), a cinema (in Kavaja), offices and clinics (in Lushnja), workshops (in Vlora and Pogradec), a house of culture (in Përmet), and frequently warehouses (in Gjirokastra, Dervişan and many villages of Dropull). In addition, the historically notable monastery of Ardenica was desecrated, for use as a hunters' hotel and night club for entertainment.

But even those religious buildings that had become "cultural monuments" because of their historical and artistic value were in a miserable



condition. They had been abandoned, especially those which were situated in arduous mountainous zones (such as the monasteries of Voskopoja, Dropull, Livadhja and others). The lack of care for a real restoration, the destruction or disappearance of the religious element, and inappropriate, often denigrating use had reduced these buildings to real misery. Irresponsible, criminal conduct over decades caused the loss or ruin of many genuine works of art, bringing incalculable damage to both the national and the world's cultural heritage.

Following my appointment as Archbishop of the Albanian Church, so badly damaged in all aspects, we started from the first moment to battle to restore and return to their sacred function all churches that could be repaired, so that the religious life and cult could be developed immediately. Much work was undertaken for building new churches as well as restoring buildings considered as "monuments of culture." The effort was more complicated and demanding for the latter, since appropriate scientific studies first had to be conducted by specialists, later going on with the delicate procedure of restoration by qualified teams according to the scientific criteria that are in force in Europe today. All this work demanded great effort to find financial sources abroad, since the local Orthodox Church has been





deprived of its wealth and did not even have the funds to support its clerics.

However, by the grace of God, which “passes all understanding and fulfils what is lacking,” with systematic effort and with the generosity of the sponsors, most of them anonymous, who showed complete trust in the Leadership of the Orthodox Church of Albania, with the co-ordination of forces and responsible administration, an intense and superb activity was carried out even in the field of restoration, with more than four million dollars being spent for this purpose. In this book, the basic data about the restoration of 51 religious buildings with historical value are summarised. Prof. Pirro Thomo and his collaborators deserve heartfelt greetings for the preparation and publication of this volume.

Concerning the resurrection from their foundations of 80 churches, five monasteries, various church buildings, schools, clinics and administrative centres, and the repair of 140 other churches, these are reflected in another volume: “Lynette Hoppe, *Resurrection. The Autocephalous Orthodox Church of Albania 1991-2003*, Tirana 2004.”



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With the objective of securing permanent structures for maintenance and restoration, the Department of Cultural Heritage was founded, which aims at the documentation, study, planning and restoration of historical religious buildings as well as the legal regulation of relations and exchanges with the appropriate institutions. In addition, for more than ten years a seminar has been functioning for the students of Architecture and Construction at the Polytechnic University of Tirana and other interested persons, where the students supplement their knowledge about planning religious buildings, an unknown subject until then, as well as obtaining basic knowledge about the science of restoration. A special scientific group has also been set up for cataloguing and describing the existing monuments, even little ones. An enormous amount of descriptive, graphic and photographic material has been collected. At the same time, five videocassettes on the monuments rescued in



Berat, Korça and the zone of Saranda have been produced and put into circulation by Ms. Mavriku.

Parallel to this, a perfected laboratory for the restoration and maintenance of icons has been established in Tirana, where dozens of old icons have been restored. In addition, for the preparation of new specialists in the field of restoration, two branches have been functioning since 2001 in the Institute of Professional Training, -an educational institution following the completion of High School, - one for the maintenance of the works of art and the other for hagiography. For the same purpose, various scientific meetings have been organized, such as the International Symposium “2000 Years of Christian Art and Culture in Albania” and the publication of its practices, and scientific publications on the scientific heritage have been sponsored, such as the work of Prof. Pirro Thomo, *“Post-Byzantine Churches in Southern Albania.”* Furthermore, brochures and articles have been published in the newspaper “Resurrection,” and programmes have been broadcast on the Radio Station of our Church to spread the cultural values and more generally to make public opinion aware of the need to preserve this valuable heritage.

In the field of restoration, too, the work that has been done can be seen even more clearly if we take into consideration that all the above

mentioned work was done during a period full of political changes and economic crises, without the least assistance from the state and occasionally even with a negative stand from it, such as in its seeking taxes for the work of restoration that the Orthodox Church realised by donations from abroad. In the first years, there were even various situations of pressure and direct or indirect persecution.

Despite all this, we continued our difficult and manifold effort with sacred enthusiasm, certain that the restoration and rehabilitation of historical church buildings to their original condition not only covers the needs of the present for suitable places to worship, but also constitutes an indication of honour and respect for the prior generations who for centuries, under the asphyxiating conditions of Ottoman rule, yet managed to create such works; and at the same time, attentive care for future generations, which have the right to be proud of the values of the past and to be inspired by them.

*Tirana, 19 November 2004*

+ Anastasios

Archbishop of Tirana, Durrës and Albania

## INTRODUCTION

An extremely large number of Christian buildings dating from the first centuries of Christianity until today have been preserved in Albania. Because of their special architectural and artistic values, most of them were brought under the protection of the state as “Monuments of Culture,” and as such, they were able to escape the total destruction that their sisters throughout the country faced as they suffered during the many years of religious persecution during Communism.

However, the ban on religion found the scientific and restoration activity of religious buildings in its first steps. Up until then, some articles had been published, mainly in the field of art, but only one article in the field of architecture. The corpus of church inscriptions, which is an important basic area for study, remained closed for a long time, without seeing the light of publication. By banning the study of religious buildings or limiting this study to an extreme, the



scientific treatment of the day created another large gap in the evaluation of the buildings.

Under these circumstances, activities for research on religious buildings, evaluating them and bringing them under protection, which had just started, were deprived of work in the field, which is so necessary for the correct implementation of the complex and important process of the fate of our cultural heritage. The struggle against religion hardened, and the process that had just started of evaluating religious monuments was for the most part restricted. It was categorically demanded that their number, small as it was – approximately 20 – be reduced.

With the efforts of a group of researchers, 129 churches and monasteries (out of 181 listed in the register of monuments) managed to remain under the protection of the state, with the attribute of Monuments of Culture. Many religious buildings worthy of being characterized as monuments of culture were not on this list, and they suffered a bitter fate. Most of them were destroyed or transformed. Others were converted





into depots or warehouses or used for low and base purposes, such as for stables. But the fate of the monuments that remained on the list was hardly better. Other genres of monuments were brought to the attention of the institutions charged with preservation and restoration of monuments of culture, without taking religious buildings into account. Consequently, they suffered from severe damage leading to total or partial destruction.

But even today, fourteen years after the collapse of the dictatorial Communist regime, the situation of these monuments has not changed significantly from that of the previous period. The state's interest in the restoration, protection, and maintenance of these monuments of culture is still ineffective. Many monuments with special architectural and artistic values continue to suffer damage or destruction. On the other hand, the re-establishment of religious belief found many villages without their religious buildings or, at best, with churches in a miserable condition and stripped of their religious artefacts.

The Orthodox Autocephalous Church of Albania (O.A.C.A.), in addition to the enormous efforts that it has made and continues to make in all fields for the reconstruction of the church from the ruins, has devoted special attention to preserving, evidencing and restoring this cultural heritage. Continuing today, under the direct care and full financial support of His Beatitude, the Archbishop of Tirana, Durrës and Albania, Prof. Dr. Anastasios, the restoration of many monuments of culture has been possible, saving them from certain destruction.

The factors analysed above have directly affected the interventions for restoration of religious buildings, presenting some specific requirements.





*Firstly*, considering the process of evaluating the monuments not to be a closed one but as one in progress, interventions for the restoration of many religious buildings that for the reasons given above were not included in the list of monuments of culture have been done based on the criteria for the restoration of monuments already known and accepted by domestic and worldwide practices.

*Secondly*, the restoration of religious buildings with historical and architectural value was regarded as being closely connected with their use. A return to their initial function, which is the most recommended way in general and the most natural one in the concrete case, is quite possible under today's conditions. For this reason, in most cases the restoration works have been of a complex nature. That is, interventions have been implemented not only in the structural consolidation of the buildings, but also in the morphological restoration and in the conservation of works of art, wall paintings, iconostases and other ornamental and functional artefacts of the interior, ornamental ceilings, and so forth.



*Thirdly*, interventions for the integrity or reconstruction of the missing parts have become acceptable and have been widely undertaken, taking into account that most religious buildings have reached the present in quite a damaged structural condition that endangers their integrity, and that the component architectural elements are sometimes missing, caused mainly in recent years by systematic failure of intervention, lack of maintenance on the one hand and return to their initial function on the other. This is much facilitated by the fact that in most cases, the graphic and photographic documentation that is necessary to make these interventions faithful to the original is in existence.

*Finally*, taking into consideration the situation of these monuments, the interventions designed to rescue them are considered to be measures that are quite efficient in avoiding the risk of destruction and the prevention of further damage; in other words, giving them a longer life, with the expectation of more complete restoration work.

This first edition reflects in a summary fashion some of the restoration activity that has been carried out to date to save this part of Albania's cultural heritage. Activity of this kind will continue in the future to preserve these compelling historical and artistic testimonies.

Prof. Dr. Pirro Thomo

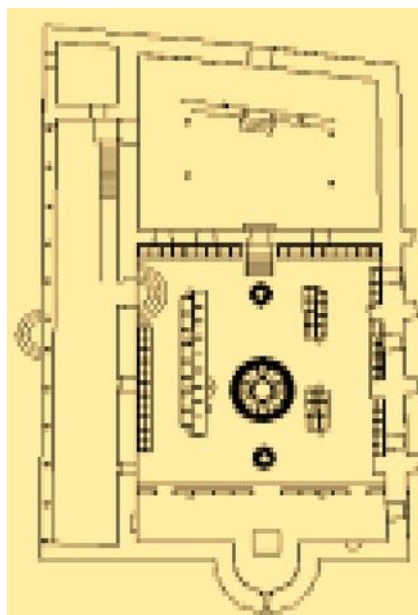


## *GRABOVA - GRAMSH* **CHURCH OF ST. NICHOLAS**

### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

Grabova is a mountainous village about 1,300 meters (4,265 feet) above sea level and about 40 km from the town of Gramsh. It is connected with Gramsh by means of a narrow dirt road that is impassable in the winter. About 40 Vlach families live there now, all of which are Orthodox.

The current village of Grabova was quite well known in the late Middle Ages because of successive generations of church painters who practised their craft primarily in the churches of Myzeqe. These were the families of Çetiri and Katro, who proudly emphasized their origin “from the town of Grabova.” The oldest inscription of painters from Grabova is dated 1775 and is on the large icon of Christ in the iconostasis of the church of St. Demetrius in the village of Mezhanj. It gives the name of the family’s first painter, George Prend Çetiri Grabovari. George and his brother John, who was the most famous painter from Grabova, worked in the church of St. Nicholas in Vanaj (1795) and the church of St. Athanasius in Karavasta (1797), as well as painting a large number of icons. John was the painter of the church



*Plan of the church.*



*General view of the church.  
It rises on rocky terrain, somewhat  
apart from the inhabited quarters.*

of St. Mary in Bishqethem (1798) and of the icons of the church of St. George in Fier. In collaboration with his nephew Nicholas, John painted the church of St. Todri in Kadipashaj (1801) and the church of St. George in Struma (1801). In collaboration with his son Naum, John painted the church of the Annunciation in Kozarë (1806) and the church of St. Nicholas in Toshkëz. Later inscriptions make other younger members of the family known to us, named George, Ndin and others.

Understandably, this village, so richly adorned with artistic traditions, itself contains true works of art. One of these is the church of St. Nicholas. The church of St. Nicholas consists of a naos, a narthex on the western side, a gallery on the south and a belfry tower that rises in the southwest corner of the narthex. The naos is of the basilica type, with a flat ceiling. Three rows of arcades built with *chatma* construction on wooden columns divide it into three longitudinal naves, each covered with a separate wooden ceiling. The gallery is

open in front, with a row of wooden columns. The entire church is gable-roofed, except for a part on the eastern side that is hipped, with slate roofing.

At present, no wall painting is preserved, but clear traces show that church interior contained paintings. In addition, when the church was abandoned during the Communist prohibition of religious ceremonies, many interior artefacts disappeared or were heavily damaged. Of the elements that give evidence of the riches of the inner decoration that the church once had, there are left only fragments of the ceilings that cover the naves.

The ceiling of the nave is one of the rare works of applied art. It was painted using the icon technique on wooden supports. The ceiling is made of Heldreich pine and is divided into a number of squares. In the centre of each square, there are rosettes painted with figures of saints, combined with floral motifs. In the centre of the ceiling of the central nave, there is a large rosette in the form of a dome, with a diameter of about 2m (6.5 feet). It is painted with a band of angels and seraphim, with Christ Pantocrator in the centre.

## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT

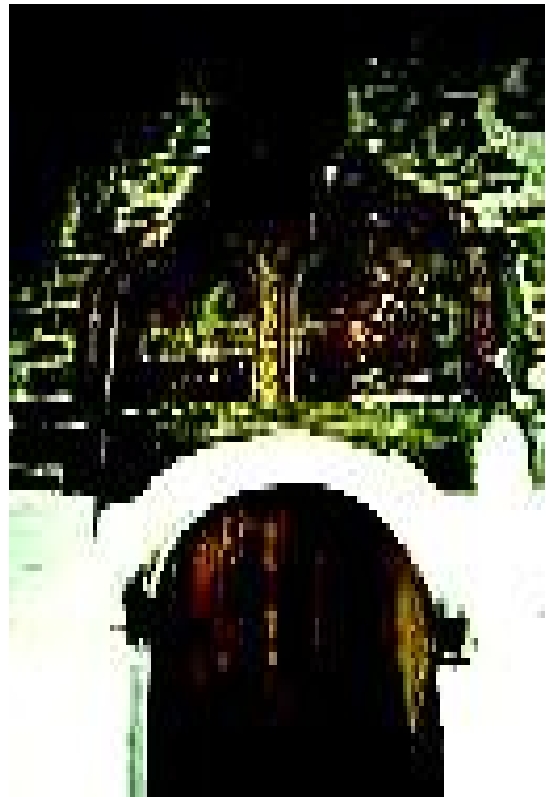
The monument survived, but was badly damaged with regard to its structural integrity and the completeness of the architectural and decorative elements. The roof of the apse and parts of the masonry walls of the naos, narthex, gallery and belfry tower collapsed. There was deterioration in the remainder of the masonry, the roof, large parts of the inner arcade, and other places.

There was serious damage to the ceiling of the naos, such as:

- deterioration of the support construction, beams and joists,

### *Church entrance.*

*Images of the saints on the entrance door of the church. Only a few fragments of the wall painting the church once had are preserved.*





*South view of the church before restoration.*

- deformation, collapse and detachment of the ceiling beams,
- loss, fissures and even decomposition of wooden elements,
- infection with micro-organisms,
- collapse and cracking of the painting.

### **3. CONSOLIDATION AND RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS**

Interventions for structural consolidation and restoration concentrated on:

- Reinforcement of the masonry by means of deep tamp pointing, stitching of the fissures, and injections.
- Rebuilding the missing parts in the masonry of the naos, narthex, gallery and belfry tower.
- Rebuilding the wooden colonnade of the gallery.
- Completely rebuilding the roof.

*South view of the church after restoration.*



- Completion and restoration of the inner arcade of the naos.
- Flooring with stone slabs.
- Drainage system and water isolation of the chapel of St. Parascevy
- Rebuilding the roof.
- Installation of doors and windows

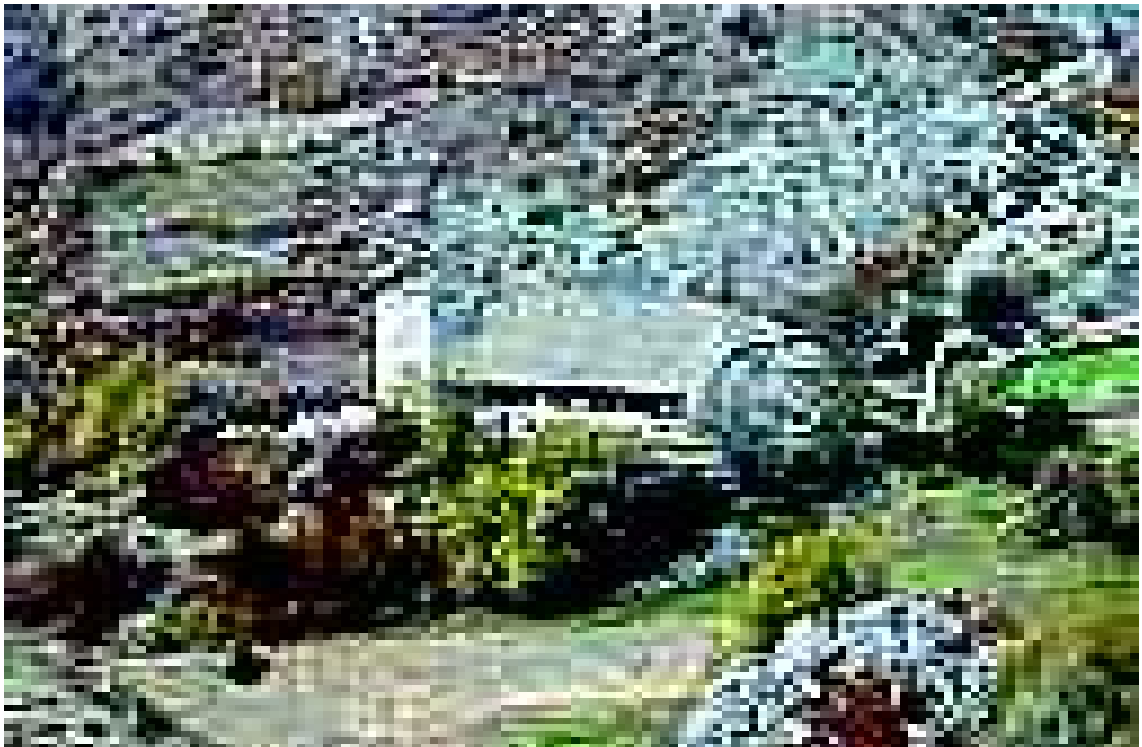
Interventions for the conservation of the decorative ceiling consisted of:

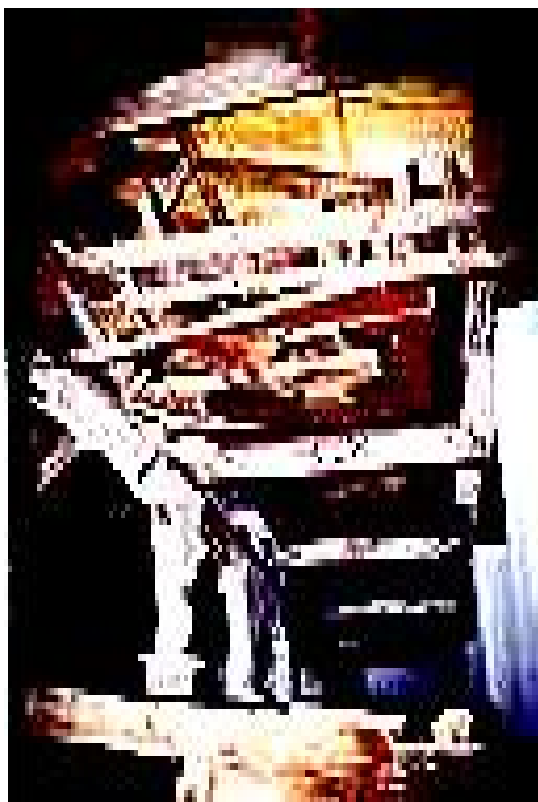
- Levelling and consolidating the support structure of the ceiling.
- Identification of the initial position of the detached or removed fragments that were still present in the church and re-mounting them.
- Completion of the missing parts with new boards.
- Complete decontamination of the original wood structure.
- Consolidation of the parts that had deteriorated.
- Removal of salts, decomposed varnish, and dirt.



*East view of the church before restoration.*

*General view of the church after restoration.*





*Situation of the church ceiling before and after restoration.*

Following the consolidation of the support structure and wooden elements of the ceiling, the ceiling painting was conserved, work that consisted of:

- Removal of the over-paintings that were done without criteria.
- Completion and infill of the collapsed layer of plaster.
- Securing the backing of the paintings.
- Restoration of the support structure of the central dome.
- Removal and re-mounting of damaged painting.
- Injections in the detached places.
- Final cleaning and reintegration of the painting.

This restoration rescued an important 18<sup>th</sup> century monument of outstanding historical, architectural and artistic value.

This town is also the birthplace of prominent painters of Çetiri family.

#### **4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

The project of consolidation and restoration was designed by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

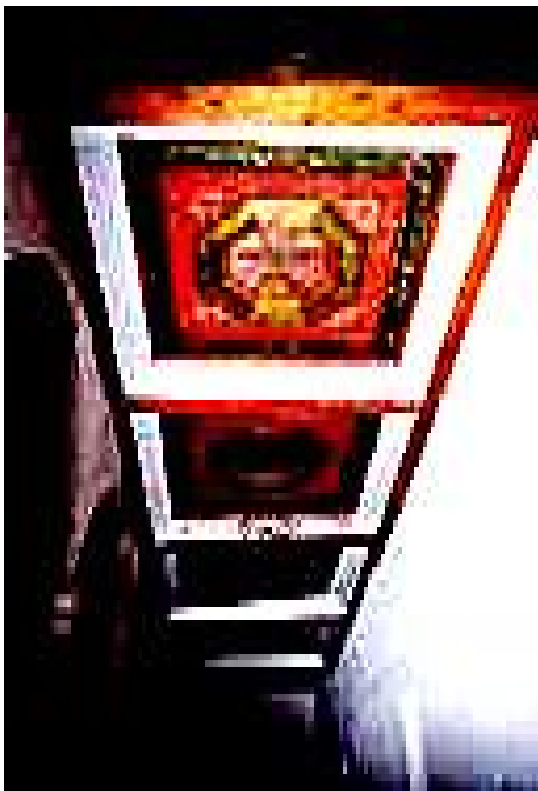
The consolidation and restoration work was implemented by a construction company from Gramsh.

The work had a total value of 18,163,488 lekë.

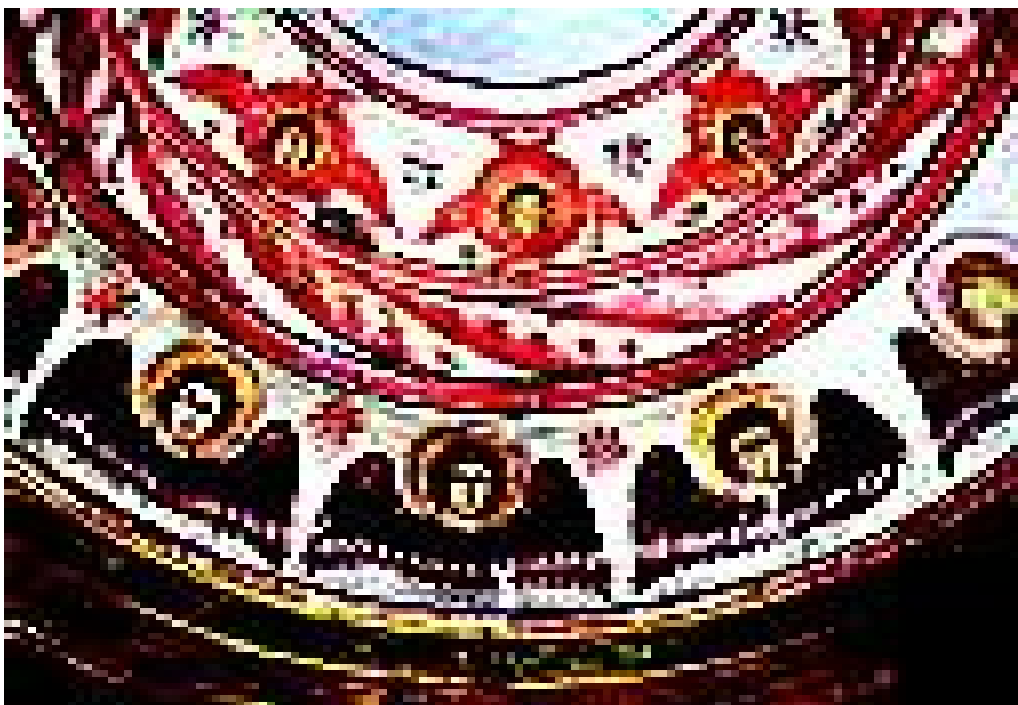
The conservation and restoration project of the ceiling of the naos was implemented by M. Arapi and A. Ago, restorers.

The work and project value reached the sum of 4,475,000 lekë.

The work was supervised by D. Bello, eng., of the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.





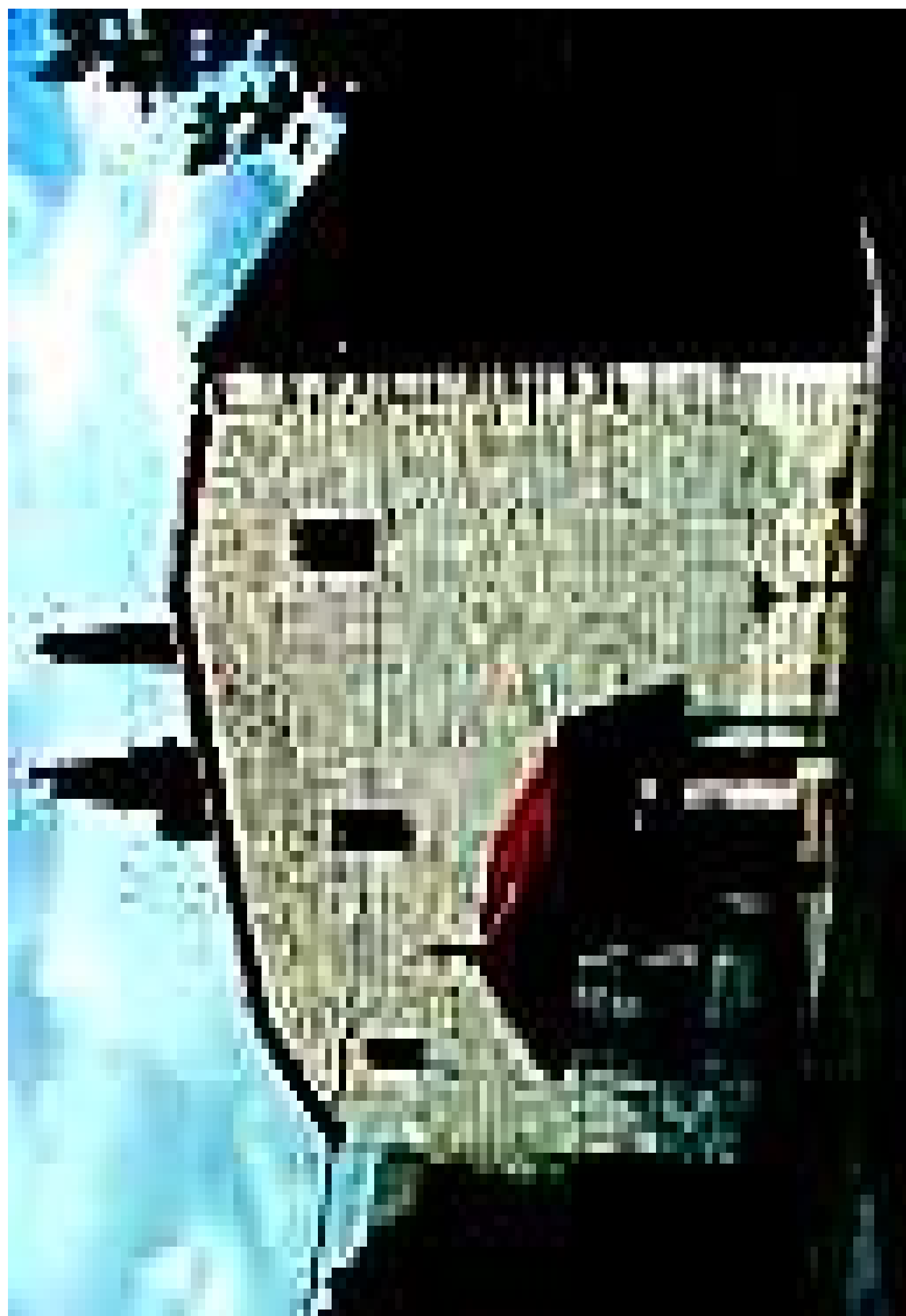


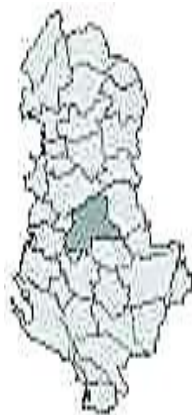
The work started in 1997 and finished in 2001.

**The total value of the restoration work was 22,638,500 lekë (US\$ 226,380)**

*Rosettes on the ceiling after restoration.*

*The application of the icon technique can be seen on the wooden ceiling of the nave.*





## *SHIJON - ELBASAN*

### **MONASTERY CHURCH OF ST. JOHN VLADIMIR**

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#### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The monastery of St. John Vladimir monastery is situated on the west of the city of Elbasan, near the village whose name it bears, Shijon (a deformation of the name St. John), off a branch of the national road from Tirana to Elbasan. The monastery, which at present is a place of worship and pilgrimage of the people from the villages in the area, also preserves an ancient and interesting history. It has been both a religious and cultural centre of importance. In recent years, the

*View of the church before restoration.*





*Results of the archaeological surveys.*



restored guesthouses of the monastery have been used as a girls' summer campsite, organized by the Autocephalous Orthodox Church of Albania.

The church was dedicated to the prince of Kraja, John Vladimir, who was beatified after his death. During the period of conflict between the Bulgarian kingdom and the Byzantine Empire between the 11-12<sup>th</sup> centuries, many allies of the Bulgarians allied with the Byzantines upon the success of the latter. One of these was John Vladimir, but he was killed by the men of the Bulgarian King, Ivan Vladislav, in the vicinity of Prespa. Initially, his body was buried in Kraja, and for almost two centuries his remains were kept in the church of "the Virgin of Kraja." In 1215, the ruler Theodore Angelus Comnenus removed them to Durrës, but it is not known what church they were brought to. Later, in the fourteenth century, the Albanian prince Karl Thopia had them sent to a monastery near the city of Elbasan, where he is likely to have built the church. In honour of the saint, the monastery bore his name: John Vladimir.

There are numerous legends regarding the monastery and the murder of John Vladimir that are known to the people of the area even now.

According to one of them, "John was taking a walk one day when he saw, in a forest near the river Kusha, an eagle holding a shining cross. The eagle swooped down, left the cross on the ground and disappeared. John hurried there, took the cross and built a church at that place."

As to the murder of the prince of Kraja, it is said that Vladislav, Czar of the Bulgarians, in order to occupy John's lands, invites him to his capital in Ohrid. As soon as Vladislav saw John, he took out his sword and cut off his head. The saint, holding his severed head, leapt on his horse and

rode to the church he had himself built. That is where John Vladimir was buried by the archbishop of the country on 4 June 1015. (That date, 4 June, is still a church feast day). Kozara, the wife of John Vladimir, built a house near the church, where she lived until her death. Later, the house became a monastery.

The eminent iconographer and painter of the seventeenth century, Kostandin Shpataraku, has immortalized the saint in an icon. In the centre stands the prince of Kraja with his severed head in his left hand. The central figure is surrounded by twelve different scenes in miniature, mainly from the life of the saint. In one of the scenes, prince Karl Thopia is shown standing and indicating with his right hand the monastery of St. John Vladimir in Elbasan.

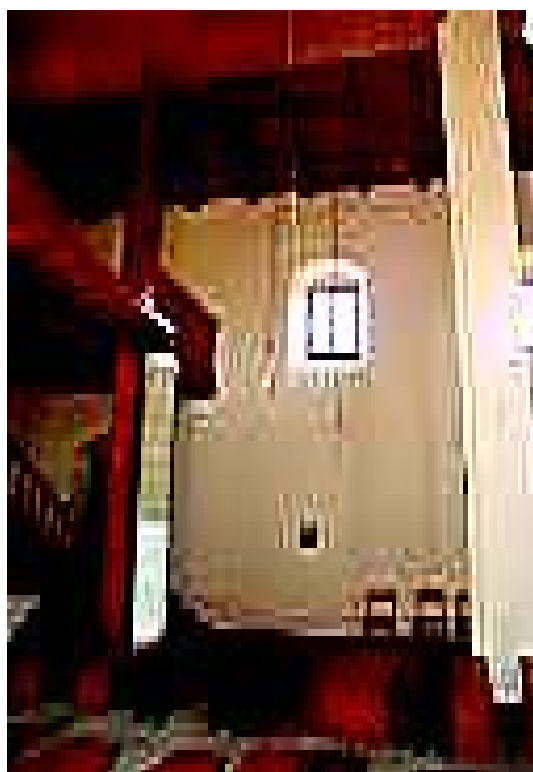
No traces are left from the early phases of the church that could show the type of the church. The only old evidence is a few stone slabs with reliefs and inscriptions, as well as a relief with the emblem of the princely family of Thopia. (Today it is preserved at the National Historical Museum in Tirana).

In today's condition, because of later reconstruction, the church is a basilica with three naves. The main entrance is on the western side, while the north and south have one entrance each, but they are smaller. The area of the bema is divided by the iconostasis, a brick wall. In the area of the apse, fragments of wall painting are partly preserved. Below the level of the floor of the bema, there should be a cemetery, whose presence is attested by an entrance in the shape of a gallery on the northeast corner of the naos. The south side once had an arcade, traces of which can still be made out on the walls of the church.

The floor is paved with stone slabs, elaborated to a greater extent in the central zone, which contains a decorative rosette.



*Views of the ginekonitti:  
above, before restoration;  
below, after restoration.*





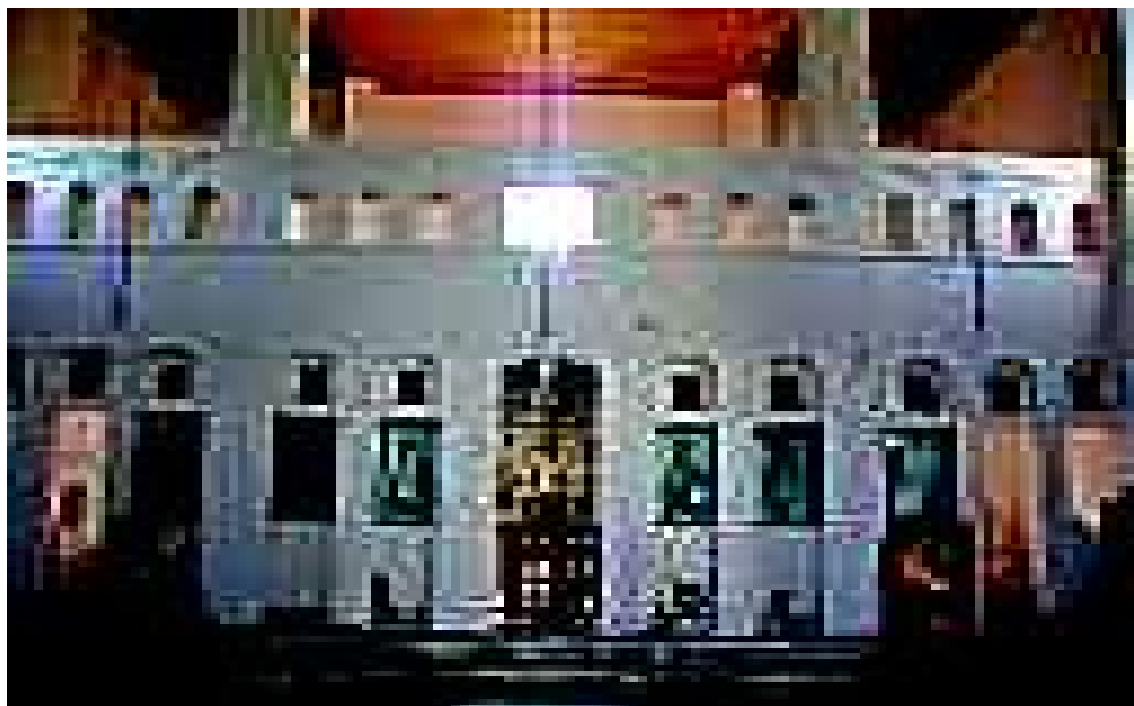
*The iconostasis of the church before restoration.*

The masonry is made of stone bound with lime mortar, and the walls are 80 cm (31.4 inches) thick. On the southern face stone elements worked as grave stelae or architraves taken from other antique objects are much used. Carved stones of earlier periods are embedded in the walls of the eastern face.

Archaeological surveys performed before the restoration work brought to light important elements of earlier phases of the church. A survey on the southern gate uncovered the existence of a circular staircase. A survey on the southeast corner of the naos brought out the base of a rectangular pilaster, while surveys of the outside of the east face showed the presence of two apses of the lateral aisles of the church.

## 2. THE EXISTING CONDITION OF THE CHURCH

The monastery church had survived to the present, but not in a functional condition. The roof had collapsed entirely. Because of the lack of maintenance and long abandonment, even the structural parts were damaged, and their integ-



*The iconostasis of the church after restoration.*

rity was lowered considerably. Another factor affecting the structural integrity of the church was fire. The church was burned twice, first because of the carelessness of Italian soldiers who were located in the monastery, and then again in 1944, when the German army was evacuating it.

### 3. RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

The condition of the church and the function of the monastery today made it essential to perform restoration interventions. They aimed first at restoring the building's structural integrity. These consisted of:

- Consolidation of the masonry of the church. This was accomplished by stitching the fissures, especially in the northeast and southeast corner. The fissures were of considerable size and were endangering the integrity of the building. The work also included injecting the masonry and tamping pointing it in the areas where the mortar had decayed.

- Reconstruction of the roof. During this process, the cornices at the top of the walls were completed with carved scale stones.

- Drainage to remove the dampness caused by underground and surface waters.

Other interventions aimed at returning the building to its function as a place of worship. In this connection, the work done can be summarized as follows:

- Re-plastering of the interior;
- Restoration of the iconostasis;
- Reconstruction of the *ginekonitti*;
- Re-paving the floor with ceramic tiles, preserving and mending the existing central belt that is paved with stone slates and contains the decorative rosette in the centre.

- Conservation of the remaining fragments of the wall painting;



*Views of the interior:  
above, before restoration;  
below, after restoration.*





*East view of the church: above, before restoration, below, after restoration.*

- Installation of doors and windows;
- Interior lighting.

#### 4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA

On the request of the Orthodox Autocephalous Church of Albania, the project for the restoration was drafted by the Institute of the Monuments of Culture, with R. Gega, arch., as author.

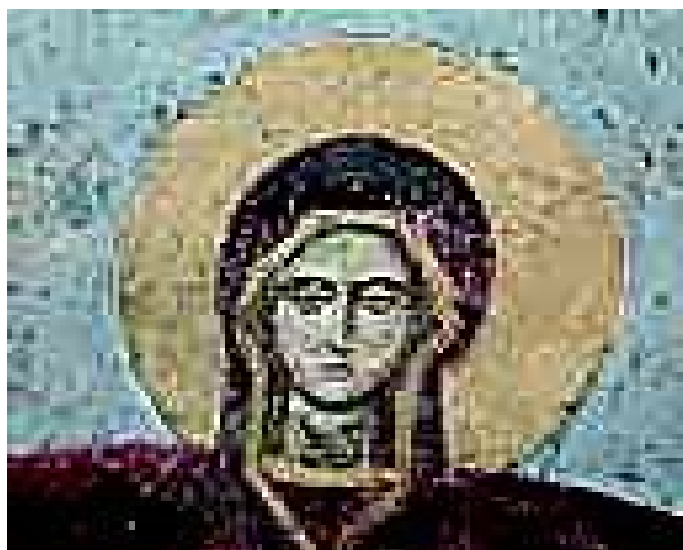
The restoration work was implemented during the years 2004-2005 by the Tirana Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by G. Samimi, eng., in collaboration with the Construction Company "JOGI", directed by J. Basha, eng.

Supervisors from the Department of Cultural Heritage of OACA were Prof. Dr. P. Thomo, and G. (John) Stratobërdha, arch.

The cost of the work reached **9,343,000 lekë (USD 93,430)**.







*Platytera. Fragment of the painting of the apse of the bema.*

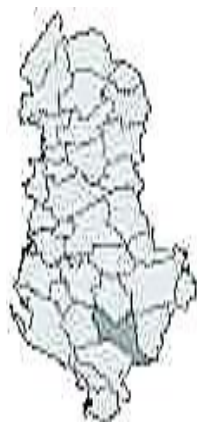


*Painting of the apse of the bema after conservation.*

*A moment from the liturgies in the church.*







## *LEUSA - PËRMET*

### **CHURCH OF ST. MARY**

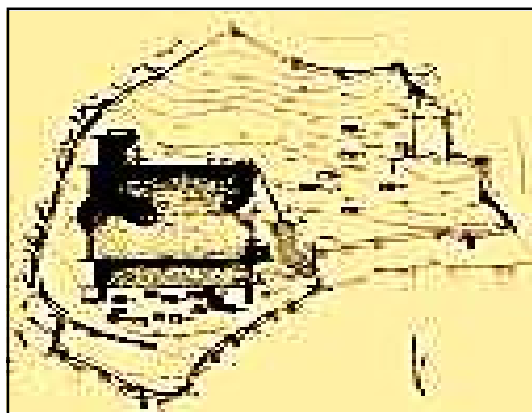
#### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The village of Leusa is situated in the south of Përmet, about half an hour away from the town on foot. The church is located on the northeastern side of the village in a dense wooded area in a scenic position from which there is a broad view of the valley of the Vjosa River.

Leusa has been one of the most developed villages of the Përmet district, both as regards cultural and economic levels as well as achievements in urban and architectural planning. It has a dense city plan with cobblestone and stone dwellings, predominantly two-storied.

The church of St. Mary is a reflection of this general development of the village. Not only is it a large monument, but one of exceptional architectural and artistic value, both as concerns its wall paintings and other interior wood-carved objects, such as the iconostasis, bishop's throne and pulpit, among others.

The painted inscription over the northern front door contains historical data of special interest. It speaks of the building and painting of the church with the contribution of the Christians of the vil-



*General view of the church.*



*Aerial view of the church after restoration.*

lage at the time when one Joasaf was the Archbishop of both Korça and Përmet.

The artists who painted the church on 18 April 1812 were Michael, George and George from Hionadhi. The carved iconostasis dates from 1817.

Although the inscription states that the church was “built from the foundations” in 1812, as is common on inscriptions of this type, other data lead us to attribute that year only to the painting of the church. Thus, it is presumed that the church was built in an earlier year, or that there may have been some important restorations in that year.

The churchyard is surrounded by walls, and it served as the village cemetery. The territory is densely forested, consisting of irregular patterns of trees except for the cypresses on the southwest side of the churchyard.

The church, dedicated to the All-Holy Mary, is composed of a naos, a narthex on the western side and a gallery that runs throughout the north-

ern elevation. The belfry tower is located in the northwest corner of the narthex.

The naos belongs to the three-aisled domed basilica type and is covered with a diverse system of arches and barrel vaults.

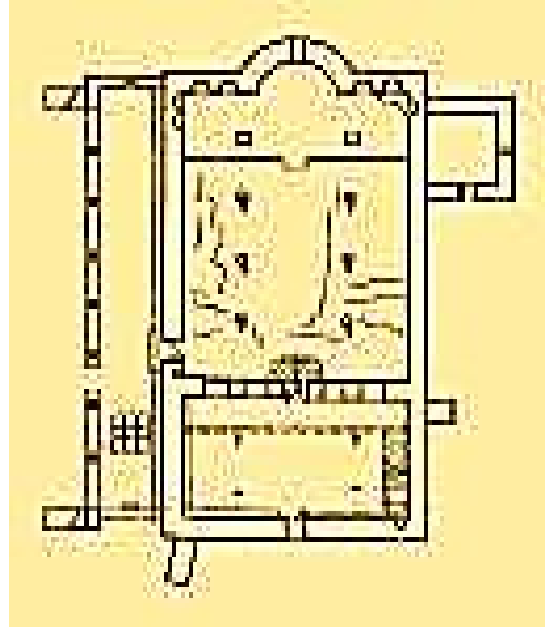
The narthex, which is attached to the naos on the west side, contains the *ginekonitti*, which projects in the form of an inner balcony, partly in the narthex and partly in the naos. The roof of the narthex is flat, with a wooden ceiling.

The gallery that stands on the northern side is open to the front, with a stone arcade over low stone columns.

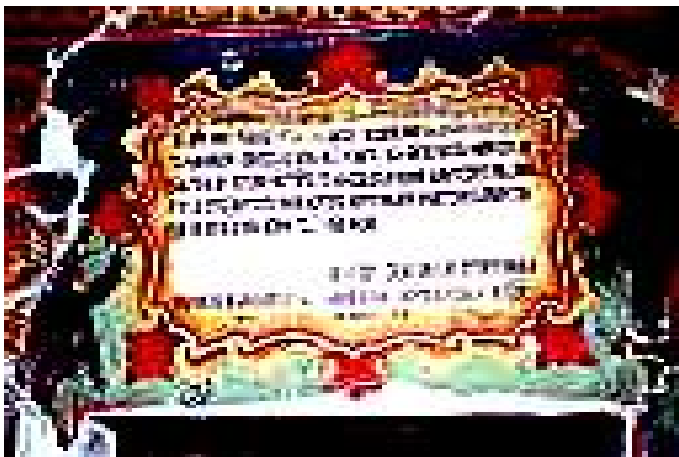
The belfry tower, which rises on the northwest side of the narthex, is in the form of a massive wall and contains a niche in the upper part for placement of the bell.

Wall paintings fill the entire church interior and the southern façade of the gallery. They were painted with the Byzantine wall painting techniques.

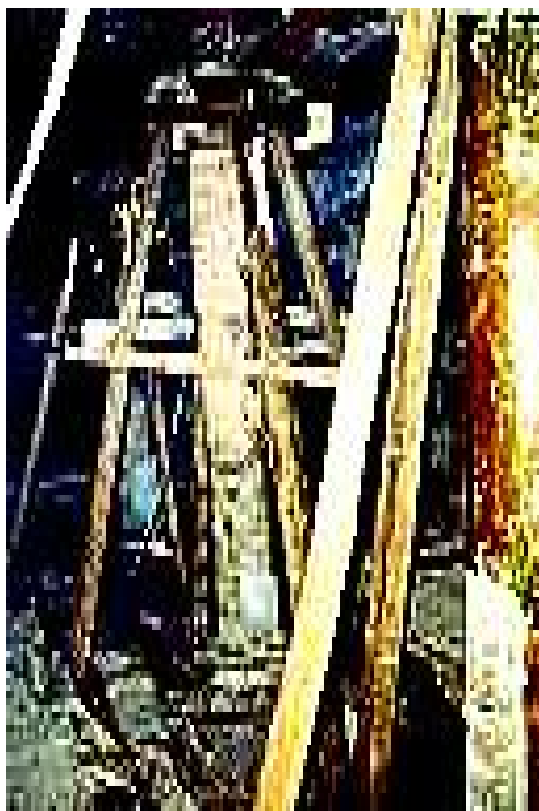
Dated to 1812, the church belongs to the period of post-Byzantine art, a period in which there is a general weakening of artistic values, but the painters of the church of St. Mary of Leusa have preserved the best traditions of post-Byzantine art, both in the iconographic design and in the stylistic features, resulting in a work of high aesthetic and historical value.



*Plan of the church.*



*Church inscription, with information about the building of the church and the painters of the wall painting.*



*Inclination of the columns.*



*Damage to the drum.*

Important elements of the decorative treatment of the interior are its wood-carved artefacts, including the iconostasis, bishop's throne and pulpit. They are considered to be masterpieces of the applied arts. Care has also been taken in the decoration of the narthex, with the central part of the ceiling containing the largest decorative concentration.

## **2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT**

### **2.1 Structural condition of the building**

The monument had suffered severe structural damage, going as far as partial or total collapse. This had considerably lowered its integrity, putting it at risk not only from earthquakes but also from collapsing under its own weight. The damage level was increasing constantly, and damage to the support structure had already led to severe effects on the survival of the wall paintings.

The damages to the monument can be classified as follows:

#### **a) Inclinations, settlements and deformations:**

- The floor of the naos was inclined off the horizontal by 12 cm (4.7 inches) in the east-west direction and 10-20 cm (3.9-7.8 inches) in the north-south.

- The columns were off the vertical by 5-8 cm (1.9-3.1 inches) to the north and 0-9 cm (0-3.5 inches) to the east, and thus, the central column of the row on the south was subjected to bending in its central part, endangering its stability.

- The collapse of the vertices in some transverse arches connecting the columns with perimeter walls had led to the lowering and deformation of their semicircular forms.

· There was a swelling of the building in the central part in the longitudinal direction, which reached as much as 7 cm (2.7 inches).

**b) Fissures in the support elements:**

· The main fissure went through all the vertices of the central nave arches, descending into the apse and the masonry. That fissure had led to the division of the building into two parts, along the longitudinal axis, and the consequent loss of coordination between them, that is, the construction no longer functioned as a whole according to the initial plan.

· Similar longitudinal fissures and numerous other fissures in different directions were observed throughout the entire roof system.

· There were vertical fissures in the masonry, corresponding in most cases to those of the inner construction.

**c) Loss of structural capacity or functional loss of constructive elements:**

· Because of the great strains resulting from the fissures and settlement of the construction, as well as the aging of the material, the braces, important elements of the equilibrium of horizontal thrust, had become detached from the masonry, thereby losing their function.

· Both the constructive and decorative wooden elements, such as the construction of the roof, the *ginekonitti*, the staircases, the decorated wooden ceiling and parts made of *chatma* had suffered from considerable damage or were completely destroyed.

**2.2 The condition of the wall paintings and other objects of art.**

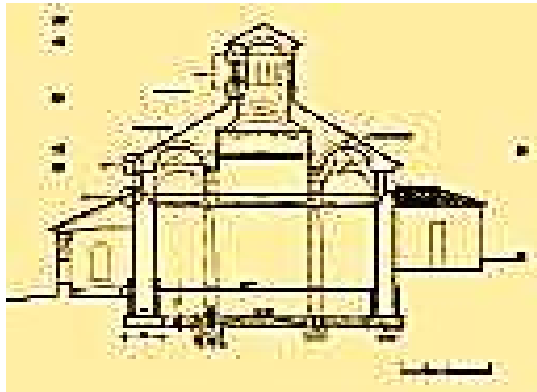
Damage to the paintings and the causes of it can be classified as follows:

· Structural damage caused severe damage in the paintings, such as fissures, partial or

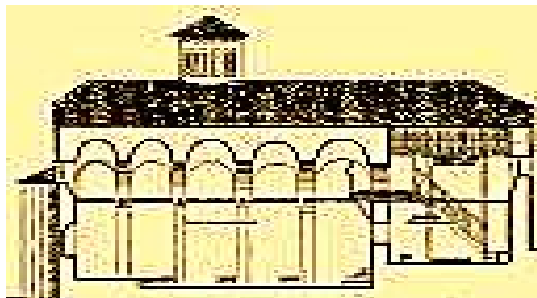


*Damage to the support structures.*

*Condition of the wall painting and the ornamental ceiling of the narthex before restoration.*



*Cross-section of the church.*



*Lengthwise section of the church.*

complete; detachment from the wall; discoloration; *intonakos*; and *arrachio*.

· Deterioration of the layers of the fresco, a significant accumulation of calcium salts, the loss of adherence between the support structure and the paintings and the occurrence of swelling and pockets came from the presence of humidity, both capillary action and condensation, as well as moisture caused by rainfall.

· Interventions by unqualified people, such as the placement of unnecessary layers of plaster on the painting, the covering of the old painting in the apse, the retouching of the original painting, new painting in the apse, layers of varnish, and other interventions had damaged the aesthetic



unity and the entire perception of the pictorial composition.

- Damage caused by carelessness during the functioning of the church, such as the darkening of the painting from layers of smoke and soot from the abundant usage of candles and oil lamps, as well as lacquer and varnish.

- Damage caused by vandalism, such as scratches with hard tools and numerous writings, especially on the painting of the gallery.

- Demolition of the support structure of the decorative ceiling of the narthex and decomposition of its timbers.

- Effluence and infection of wood-carved art objects, such as the iconostasis, pulpit and bishop's throne, which had led to the initial stages of decomposition.

### 3. CONSOLIDATION AND RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

Because of the complicated problem areas presented by the monument, the study and restoration interventions were of a complex nature.

#### 3.1 Geo-technical and hydro-technical study

From the first examination of the monument, it was noticed that the very terrain of the church presented the problems that had caused the major damage to the structures of the building. For this reason, a geo-technical and hydro-technical study was carried out in order to gather evidence about the existing situation and to determine the geo-technical phenomena, their consequences, and the measures that could be adopted to counteract them.

This study brought into evidence the negative phenomena that had led to the major damage to the building.



*Work of consolidation of the construction.*



*Work of consolidation of the foundations of the building.*

·**Geological phenomena:** The church building stood over two different geologic formations with different physical and mechanical properties, thus putting its foundations on an unequal footing and causing differential settlement. The demarcation line of these formations coincided roughly with the longitudinal axis of the church.

·**Hydro-geological phenomena:** The presence of a large amount of poorly drained surface and underground water negatively affected the stability of the building. This led to the emergence of a *suffosa* phenomenon, that is, the elimination of minute fractions of the geological strata because of hydro-mechanical pressure. The surveys discovered the presence of deep caverns below the foundations of the building, endangering its longevity.

To remove the consequences of these phenomena, the following measures were adopted:

·Reinforcement of the building foundations by enlarging and deepening them with walls, reinforced concrete underpinning, foundation columns and reinforced concrete beams.

·Infilling spaces and caverns below the foundations of the building.

·Building a drainage system for the underground waters.

·Building a canal network for the removal of surface waters.

·Mending or rebuilding the boundary walls both of the churchyard and the terraces built in the churchyard, using walls and/or reinforced concrete buttresses to function as supports and to eliminate the occurrence of any landslide of the terrain.

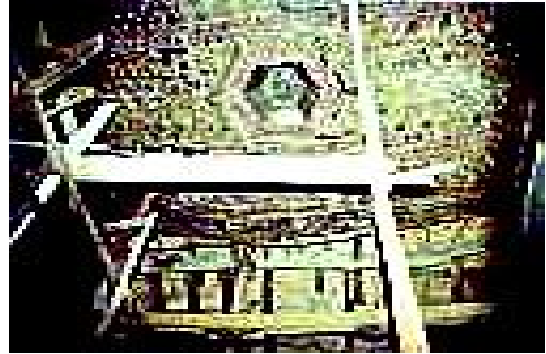
### **3.2 The project and the consolidation work of construction**

Considering the severe damage to the structure of the building, the basic criterion for the interventions of the proposed structural consolidation was the strengthening of the existing structures. This was implemented to regain the lost capacity, to the extent possible. When this strengthening was insufficient, new constructive elements would be employed, respecting the initial morphological features and not altering the constructive scheme.

This criterion was implemented by the following measures:

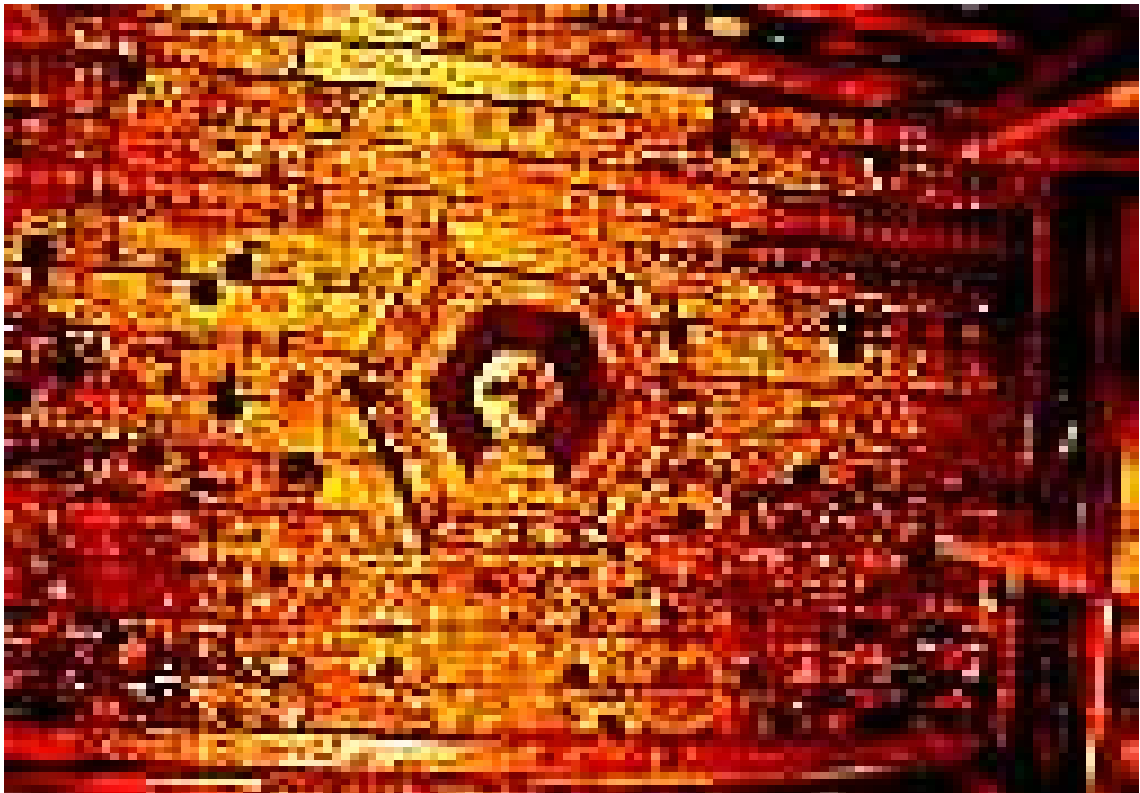
- Strengthening the existing constructive elements such as arches, vaults, and spherical calottes. This was implemented by means of interventions that are locally accepted and widely implemented in restoration theory and practice, such as tamp-pointing, local injections, infilling and stitching.

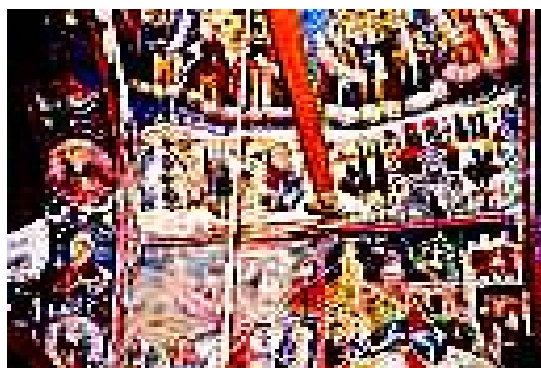
- Reinforcement and use of other subsidiary measures where the interventions for strength-



*Ceiling of the narthex before restoration.*

*Ceiling of the narthex after restoration.*





*Views of the wall painting after restoration.*

ening were insufficient. This included interventions for reinforcing the foundations and placing reinforcing braces in the spherical calottes and in the drum of the cupola, as well as easing the load from the support construction at the naos by building an independent roof.

- Replacement of elements that were completely damaged or out of function, such as the substitution of the old wooden braces with horizontal metal ones. This category also includes the reconstruction of the wooden structures of the narthex, such as roofs, elements of the *ginekonitti* and others. These structures had been so badly damaged that conserving them was impossible.

- Conservation and infilling both of architectural and decorative elements, such as ceilings, *chatma* structures, doors and windows, and railings.

### **3.3 The project and the conservation of the works of art**

Because of the problems presented by the condition of the wall paintings and the enormous amount of work needed in the first phase, interventions for this phase consisted only in consolidation and conservation. Interventions for the aesthetic re-assessment of the pictorial complex will constitute a second phase.

The measures taken for consolidation and conservation of the wall paintings were:

- Injections in the places where there were swelling and pockets.
- Reinforcement with mortar in the areas where the plastering had fallen.
- Stitching of fissures.
- When neither injections nor reinforcement gave results, stripping off the fragments that were on the verge of falling and replacing them.

·Cleaning the paintings of dust, soot, micro-organisms and mould, varnish and wax, and removing calcium salts, which otherwise would continuously damage the paintings.

·Integration with colour in areas where there were some in-fills with special mortar for consolidation of the paintings.

·Rebuilding the structure of the ornamental ceiling of the narthex.

·Cleaning, disinfecting, consolidating, and infilling the missing parts of the ceiling of the narthex.

·Cleaning, disinfecting, consolidating, and re-varnishing the iconostasis, pulpit and bishop's throne.

·Restoring the front doors and chairs.

### **3.4 Project and work of the territory arrangement**

The project plan for arrangement of the territory was guided by the principle of preserving the character of the monument. It had simultaneously served both as a church and as the village graveyard, thus having a quiet and solemn character. This necessitated the following interventions:

·The preservation of the morphological character of the boundary walls and their architectural elements, such as the front door.

·Restoration of the main entry, narrow street, and spiral staircase in front of the gallery.

·Creation of grave plots, green areas, a courtyard, and narrow streets.

·Arrangement of the vegetation.

### **3.5 Project and electrical installations**

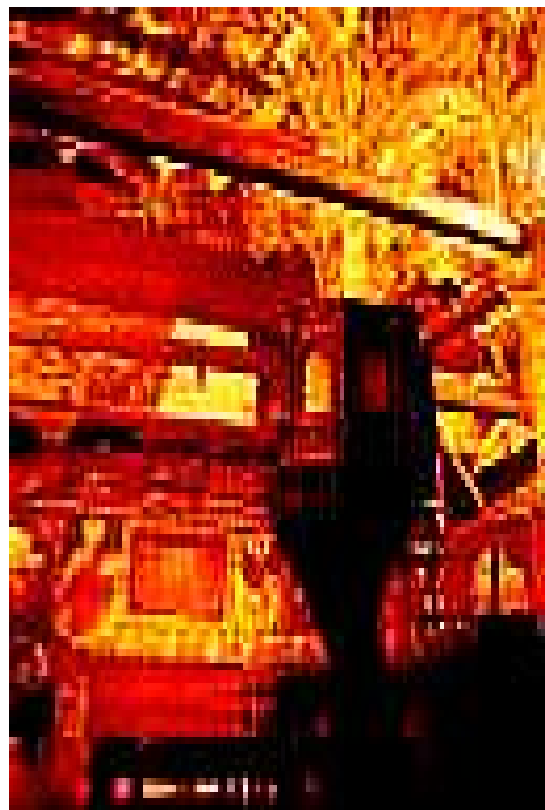
The monument was supplied with interior and exterior lighting:

·The interior lighting has two functions, independent of one another. First, the lighting will function for the needs of the liturgy, while the



*View of the interior of the church before restoration.*

*View of the interior of the church after restoration.*





*Fragment of an old wall with wall painting.*



*Painted stones from the wall reused in the building of the vaults.*

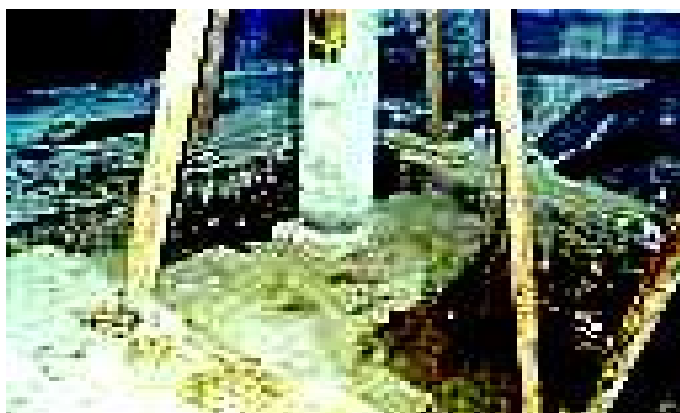
*During the work for reinforcing the foundations, old traces of the church were discovered. Of these, there was wall painting on both a fragment of a column and a wall, and they were open to public.*

second function will highlight the architectural and artistic parts of the monument.

The exterior lighting brings out the architectural aspects of the monument, which, when viewed from a distance, appears as a building of exceptional importance.

Prior to the beginning of the work, a road was built from Përmet to the church, in order to facilitate the work and later to serve worshipers and visitors.

Throughout the course of the work, many elements were discovered, such as the re-used stones in the superstructure, which contained old pieces of fresco; fragments of the old foundations in the substructure, a part of which was covered with frescos; and other elements that verified the initial hypothesis of the existence of an older building on this site. The most interesting fragments are preserved *in situ* and are displayed for visitors.



The implementation of the work on the monument preserved its safety and longevity. It brought to light its real architectural and artistic value. It restored this deserving temple of grace and prayer to the residents of the village and the surrounding region.

#### 4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA

Those who performed the study and the restoration project are:

- For the study of the geo-technical and hydro-technical conditions:

Prof. Dr. L. Bozo, and B.Lilaj, eng.

- For the study and project of consolidation and restoration:

Prof. Dr. P. Thomo, and J. Bej, M.S.Eng.

- For the study and project of consolidation and conservation of the wall paintings: M.Arapi, Painter, Restorer.



*View from the north of the church before restoration.*



*View from the north of the church after restoration.*

·For the conservation work of the wooden artefacts:

A. Ago, Restorer.

Compensation for the conservation project and its implementation was 7,100,000 lekë.

·The work of consolidation and restoration:

Berat Branch of Monuments, directed by A.Nallbani in collaboration with the private company Ad-Star, directed A.Çoma, eng.

·The consolidation and restoration work amounted to 31,078,585 lekë, and road construction work had a further value of 3,800,000 lekë.

The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Technical Service Office.

The scientific work and the elaboration of the project were directed by Prof. Dr. P. Thomo.

·The work started in August 1999 and was finished in October 2000.

·**The total value of the building reached the sum of 45,613,585 lekë (US\$ 456,130).**

*A moment from the visit of the Archbishop, Prof. Dr. Anastasios, on the occasion of conclusion of the restoration work.*







## *LEKËL - TEPELENA*

### CHURCH OF PROPHET ELIJAH

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#### 1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW

Lekël is a mountainous village located about 800 meters (2,624 feet) above sea level. It is 12 km from the city of Tepelena along the highway that connects it with the town of Përmet.

The church stands in a dominant position from which a broad view opens over the surrounding landscape. A legend that relates the church with the name of Ali Pasha Tepelena is still preserved. On his way to Iannina, the Pasha ordered one of his faithful soldiers from Lekël, Thanas Vaja, to see that a mosque was built on the most pictur-

*Southeast view of the church after restoration.*





*Traces of the columns of the gallery.*

esque rock in the village. Contrary to the Pasha's order, the soldier delivered the word to the village to build a church instead. On his way back, the surprised Pasha asked the soldier why his order has not been executed, and the soldier replied that he built the church for the Christians, because they had been asking for it for a long time. At that time, the village had about 600 Christian families.

The church is a three-aisled basilica in type, with dimensions of 14.5 x 10.7 meters (47.5 x 35.1 ft). The two rows of stone columns that divide the naves are connected with each other and with the perimeter walls by arches. They create a large number of cores covered with spherical calottes. The cores of the sanctuary are with barrel vaults. The sanctuary contains three apses that project outwards. There are no wall paintings in the naos, and its interior artefacts have disappeared.

On the west, the naos is connected with the narthex, which functioned as a baptistery. The belfry tower rises in the southwest corner of the narthex. Based on what remains, the gallery may have been in the north.

The masonry and roof are built with irregular stones bound with lime mortar.

The external treatment is quite simple. The stone masonry mass predominates, with an absence of ornamental elements. The only elements in which this simplicity is broken are the apses in the east, which are treated with a row of blind arcades. The broad gable roof, which is hipped on the east, is covered with tiles.

## **2. CONDITION OF THE BUILDING**

During the Communist period, the church was entirely transformed. The naos became a cul-

tural centre, the narthex became a bakery, and in the north an addition was built that served as a clinic for the village. In addition to this, the long abandonment of the building created severe problems for its structural integrity, as follows: there was decomposition of the connecting mortar and total damage to the roof, non-functioning of the braces of the arches, fissures in the masonry and in the curved roof of the interior, weakened cross sections of the columns, and severe weakening at the capitals of the columns, where they were in contact with the spring lines of the arches.

### **3. CONSOLIDATION AND RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS**

The poor structural situation that the building had reached and the functional transformations it had suffered made restoration interventions a necessity.

Although for various reasons the building was not included on the list of Monuments of Culture, because of its style, history and the value that it embodies, its restoration was conducted using the

*View of the interior after restoration.*





*View of the church from the north-east, before restoration.*

same criteria as for those Monuments. Thus, the main criterion of restoration was the reassurance of the structural integrity of the building, preserving its initial structural scheme, and the restoration of its initial function, while taking its typological and morphological features into account.

The restoration work was concentrated on the following:

**a) Cleaning work**

- Stripping the masonry from the plaster.
- Removing the roof and cleaning the system of the curved roof.
- Demolition of the later additions.

**b) Consolidation work**

- Closing up large fissures in the masonry and in the arches of the roof with iron bars.
- Complete tamp pointing of both the masonry and the roof system.
- Repairing the collapsed parts in the roof system.
- Consolidating the columns and arch supports

**c) Construction reinforcement with new elements**

- The installation of new metal braces and wooden in-fill for aesthetic reasons.

*View of the church from the north-east, after restoration.*



- The building of a reinforced concrete tie beam on top of the masonry.

#### **d) Reconstruction work**

- Rebuilding the gallery on the northern side, preserving the previous traces and using analogy with other monuments of the same era.
- Rebuilding the roof.
- Internal plastering of the naos and the narthex.
- Paving the naos and the narthex with stone slabs.
- Re-opening the space that had been closed up and installing doors and windows.

#### **e) Work on arranging the territory and electrical installations**

- Implementing the arrangement of the territory and the interior and exterior electrical installations.

After the above work, the monument regained its value and its importance as an indicator of the extent of Christian buildings and Christianity in this region, although the region was later subjected to Islamisation.

### **4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

- The restoration project was designed by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service, directed by Father Theologos, arch, restorer.
- The restoration work was implemented by a construction company directed by S. Çela, eng.
- The work started in June 1999 and finished in June 2000.
- The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.
- **The value of the restoration work reached 17,199,800 lekë (US\$ 172,000)**



*Views of the western side of the church, before and after restoration.*



## HIMARA

### CHURCH OF ALL SAINTS

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*View of the Castle quarter.*



#### 1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW

Himara is an old residential centre, appearing with this name in the 5<sup>th</sup> century BC. Its dwellings rose on the top of a hill with a naturally protected position and were encircled with strong boundary walls. Fragments of the boundary wall from this period, built with large and regular stone blocks, have survived to the present.

In the 9<sup>th</sup>-10<sup>th</sup> centuries AD, there is documentation that Himara was the centre of a bishopric. In all probability, the centre of this bishopric was near the church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus, which contains many elements of that period inside the boundary walls. After the Ottoman conquest, because of the resistance of the people of Himara, the Sublime Porte was obliged to grant them a number of privileges, such as the rights of having self-governance in compliance with the native customary law, having their own trials, having their own employees, having their own flag, bearing arms, and others.

Throughout this period, many churches were erected whose ruins are preserved until today. Of all those churches, the church of All Saints, a

work of the 18<sup>th</sup> century, stands out. It holds a dominant position in the centre of the quarter and may have been the major church of the village. In typology, it is a three-aisled basilica covered with a flat ceiling. Two longitudinal arcades over stone columns divide the naves from one another. On the western side is the U-shaped *ginekonitti*. On the southwest corner of the churchyard, a tall belfry tower stands. Currently, there are no wall paintings in the church. The carved wooden iconostasis and the ceiling are important elements of the interior decoration.

## 2. CONDITION OF THE BUILDING

During the Communist regime, the church was converted into a warehouse, and the apse was demolished. But the worst damage was to the iconostasis, which was carelessly taken out and abandoned. The building, too, suffered structural damage as a result of abandonment: there were fissures and cracks in the masonry, and the roof had completely deteriorated, causing the ornamental ceiling to collapse.

## 3. RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

In order to prevent further deterioration of the church, rescue measures were adopted starting in 1993. These measures were:

- Rebuilding the apse.
- Entirely rebuilding the roof.

The restoration work of the second phase aimed at restoring the lost value to the church. This work concentrated on:

- Completing the floor level of the church.
- Internal plastering.
- External tamp pointing of the masonry.
- Restoring the belfry tower.
- Electrical and plumbing installations.



*Views of the belfry tower before and after restoration.*





*East view of the church before restoration.*

- Arrangement of the church territory.
- Restoring the iconostasis.
- Restoring the ornamental ceiling.

### **3.1 Restoration of the Iconostasis**

The iconostasis of the Church of All Saints is one of the most beautiful ones preserved in our churches. It is entirely carved in a colourless walnut wood. Various motifs of human figures, animals, and everyday life are combined with diverse elements of vegetation and religious and mythological symbols.

Following the re-proclamation of the church as a Monument of Culture, a team of restorers of the Institute of Monuments collected all the fragments that remained from the destruction of the year 1967 and re-mounted the assembly, but without implementing full measures of conservation.

As a result of the poor condition of the building and the penetration of humidity into the interior, the iconostasis had suffered severe damage that had affected its entire surface area. The



effects of micro-organisms and humidity had decayed the iconostasis and reduced its bottom part to a spongy state. Micro-organisms had even affected the new construction implemented by the Institute of Monuments. The entire front surface was covered with decomposed or rusted varnish, thus creating darkening and, in places, charring of the engraved parts.

The conservation and restoration work consisted of:

- Combating and removing micro-organisms, that is, entirely decontaminating the structure and the engraved surface area.
- Cleaning the dust and unnecessary layers.
- Reinforcing and securing the detached parts.
- Consolidating the spongy parts.
- Chemically cleaning decomposed varnishes and oil-painted layers.
- Staining wood that had lost its natural colour.
- Varnishing and chromatically integrating the entire engraved surface area.

### **3.2 Restoration of the Ornamental Ceiling**

The field of the ceiling is decorated with geometric motifs, circles, triangles and squares, while the dome-shaped central rosette contains images of angels, who encircle the figure of Christ Pantocrator. The central rosette was created with the oil painting technique.

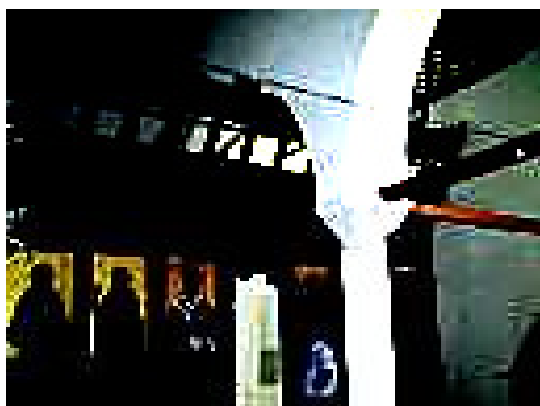
The condition of the ceiling presented problems both as to structural integrity and as to aesthetic value. The central part had settled and suffered visible deformations from the damage to the structure. This led to damage to the ornamentation, the paintings on the plaster, the paint-



*View of the interior of the church during restoration.*

*View of the interior of the church after restoration.*





*Iconostasis during and after restoration.*

ings on the canvas, and the wooden carvings. The infiltration of humidity as a result of the damage to the roof had created bleached or layered areas and problems from salination. In addition, the ceiling was affected both by micro-organisms and by bird droppings. All of this had caused decomposition of wooden fragments, making them spongy or powdery.

Conservation and restoration interventions were implemented with regard to the structure and the ceiling decoration. They consisted of the following processes:

- Reinforcement of the supports by replacing structural elements that had deteriorated.
- Elevation, levelling and stabilizing of the central rosette.
- Decontamination of the entire wooden structure.
- Completion of the missing parts.
- Consolidation of decomposed or spongy parts.
- Removal of excess layers, colour changes, and decomposed varnish.
- Pictorial reintegration of the entire surface area of the ceiling.

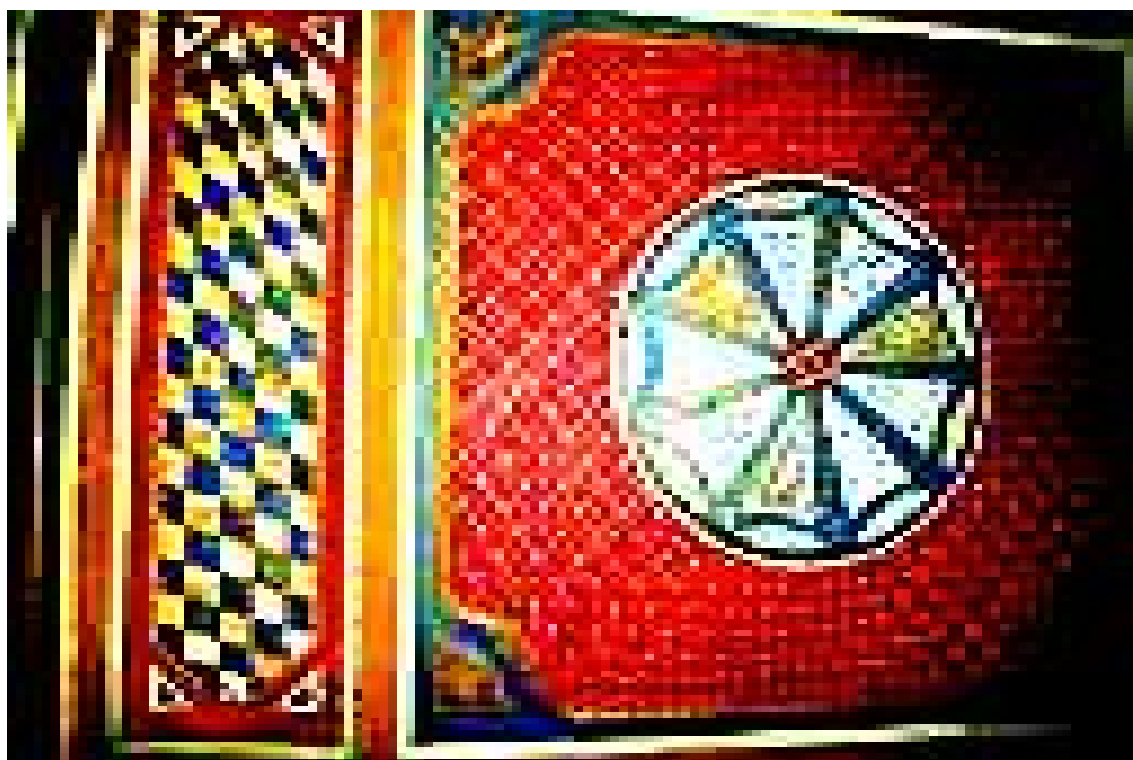
With the conservation and restoration of decorative elements of the iconostasis and ceiling, the church regained the functional, artistic and architectural values that it had lost.

#### **4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

The first phase of the work was implemented by the Greek construction company “Etan Overseas” between October 1993 and January 1994.

The value of the work in this phase reached 17,000,000 drachmas (US\$ 45,000)

The second phase of the work was implemented by the “Speed Ltd.” construction com-



pany, directed by P. Koka, eng., between April 2000 and April 2002.

The value in this phase was 27,200,000 lekë.

The plan and work for conservation and restoration of the iconostasis were implemented by M. Arapi and A. Ago, restorers.

The value of the restoration work of both the iconostasis and the ceiling reached the sum of 5,360,000 lekë.

The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

**The total restoration work reached a value of 32,560,000 lekë and 17,000,000 drachmas (US\$ 370,600).**

*Views of the ceiling after restoration.*





## *QEPARO - HIMARA*

### **MONASTERY CHURCH OF ST. DEMETRIOS**

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#### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The monastery of St. Demetrios stands in a square in the centre of the town's lower quarter. It is located in a dominating position from which there is a picturesque view overlooking the village and going as far as the sea. The monastery consists of the church and adjoining guesthouse,

*General view of the monastery after restoration.*



which during the Communist regime were used as co-operative offices.

The monastery church was built in the year 1760 and it belongs to the domed cross-in-square type, which is a characteristic variant of the churches of the region of the Seaside in which the inner structure is not reflected on the outside and has a shape reminiscent of domed basilica buildings. Another feature is the absence of a narthex and the presence of an elevated belfry tower, which is located over the pediment of the west wall.

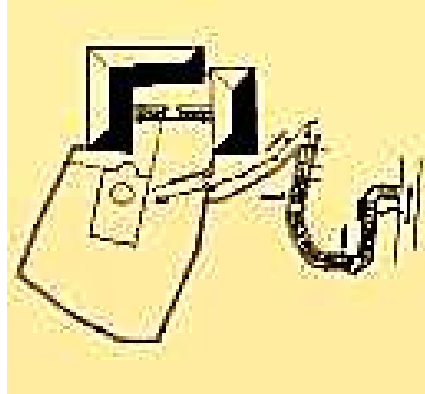
The guesthouse of the monastery runs along the southeast side of the church and is in a P - shape, with more architectural emphasis in the central part.

## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT

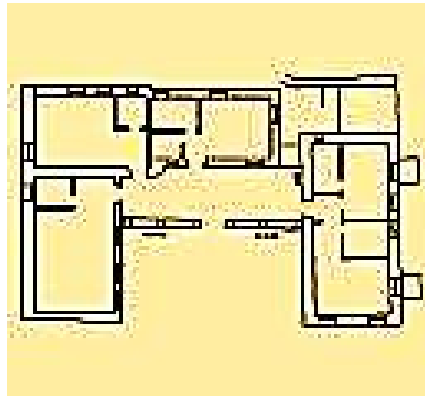
In the pre-restored condition of the guesthouse, many of its morphological features had been transformed. In addition, the structural condition of the church was not satisfactory. There were fissures in its structures, such as the masonry, arches, and vaulting system. With the passage of time, this would have brought about the collapse of the structure and consequently the loss of the architectural and monumental value that it embodies. The badly damaged roof of the church, which allowed rainwater to enter the interior and its structure, worsened the situation.

## 3. CONSOLIDATION AND RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

The condition of the monument and the loss of its initial function made restoration interventions a necessity. The purpose of these interventions was the consolidation of the structural condition and the restoration of its initial function for



*General plan of the monastery.*



*Plan of the guesthouse of the monastery.*



*View of the guesthouse before restoration.*

the spiritual life of the village. Furthermore, there is no other church in the village.

The restoration work was divided into two phases. During the first phase, the guesthouse of the monastery was entirely reconstructed. This reconstruction consisted of re-connecting the wings of the building to the central part, restoring the monumental staircase, and re-forming the upper floor of the central part using an open arcade, thus preserving the traces of the previous construction and supplementing them by analogy with the guesthouses of other monasteries built in the same period and region. Electrical, plumbing and heating installations were also done.

During the second phase, the monastery church was restored. This restoration consisted

*View of the guesthouse after restoration.*

*The missing parts and the open gallery in the centre were rebuilt while preserving the original elements, based on the traces and oral testimony, as well as by analogy with other buildings of the same architectural genre and building period.*





of the consolidation of the structures, the reconstruction of the roof, and the treatment of the masonry by deep tamp pointing. Also, a new addition was constructed towards the west. This addition was to function as an exo-narthex or gallery, since the existing church lacked such an

*Views from the southeast of the church before and after restoration.*





*Views of the church and guesthouse of the monastery after restoration.*

environment. The new volume was given a composed treatment, with elements that are customary for such premises. During this phase, the interior and exterior of the territory of the monastery were arranged with roads, support walls, squares, parking spaces, and outer lighting.

After the completion of the work, the monastery complex of Qeparo regained its value and became an important spiritual and social centre for the inhabitants of the village, also providing an appropriate architectural focus for the surrounding quarter.

#### **4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

The guesthouse reconstruction project was designed by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

The church restoration project was designed by the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by R. Gega, arch.





a.



b.

The reconstruction and restoration work was implemented by the SPEED Construction Company, directed by P. Koka, eng.

The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

The work started in 1996 and finished in 2000.

*West view of the monastery church:*

*a. before restoration*

*b. after restoration*

*An addition of the narthex was built with a controlled volume and in harmony with the other buildings of the monastery.*



## *VUNO-HIMARA* **CHURCH OF ST. SPIRIDON**

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### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The church of St. Spiridon rises in the lower quarter of the village, in a square, forming an ensemble with other buildings of a social character, the school and the building of the church administration. Nearby is the church of St. Michael.

*General view of the complex.*





*View from the southwest of the church.*



*View of the gallery of the church.*

The church of St. Spiridon was built in the year 1778 and decorated with pictures in 1784 by the painter John from the region of Drinopoja and Gjirokastër.

The church is a three-aisled basilica in type, covered with a flat ceiling. Two rows of arcades over stone columns divide the inner space into three naves, while on the western side, an intersecting arcade bounds the area of the *ginekonitti*. The two-storey *ginekonitti* is connected to the naos by two swan-necked wooden ramps, opening in the form of a raised platform to the naos. On the east, an iconostasis built of stone masonry separates the sanctuary, which contains a large apse projecting out of the bema.

The aisles are narrow, leaving more space to the central nave. The nave and the aisles have



*View of the ornamental ceiling of the church, before the fire.*

wooden ceilings, with the ceiling of the nave being higher than that of the aisles. The ceilings are richly decorated, having special artistic value.

On the western side, there is a square-shaped gallery in front of the entrance to the church. The gallery is open on three sides, with arcades over thin stone columns.

The masonry walls of the church are of stone, covered with a thin layer of plaster, leaving visible the corners of the walls and the casing of the doors and windows, which are carved in stone.

## **2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT AND RESTORATION WORK**

The church had suffered from damage to structural and decorative elements, as a result either of long abandonment or of inappropriate use during the Communist regime.

The restoration work was concentrated on rebuilding the roof and consolidating the masonry, to continue with the conservation of the decorative ceilings and the wall-paintings.



*View of the interior of the church, before the fire.*

For unknown reasons, the church suffered a major fire, which burned the roof and ceilings completely and damaged the wall paintings beyond repair, as well as weakening the structural integrity of the masonry.

The work was implemented by the Atelier of Monuments of Vlora during the years 1998-1999.

**The value of the work amounted to 13,000,000 lekë (US\$ 130,000)**

*Note:*

After the fire, the Institute of Monuments of Culture undertook work consisting of re-covering the church and re-vetting the masonry, but the artistic and decorative values of this church were irretrievably lost, causing incalculable damage to the national cultural heritage.



*Views of the church after the fire.*



## *VRAHOGORANXI - GJIROKASTËR*

### **CHURCH OF ST. MARY**

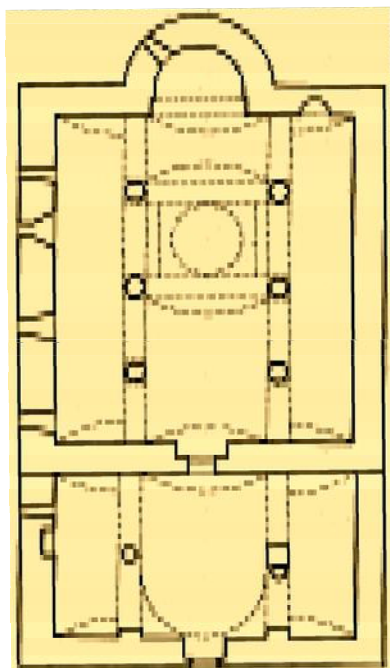
#### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The church of St. Mary of Vrahogoranxi was painted in the year 1622 by Onufër Qiprioti and Alivizi. Onufër Qiprioti was a distinguished painter of the 17<sup>th</sup> century who exercised his activity in Berat, among other places. He also created a large number of icons.

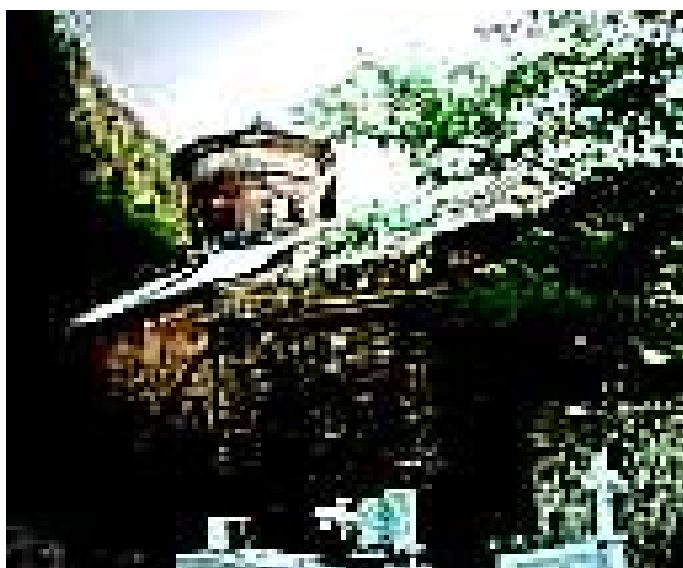
The territory of the church is surrounded by stone walls, and the village graves are located there. A belfry tower rises in the southwest corner of the churchyard, in the form of a massive structural wall made lighter by niches for bells in the upper part.

The church is composed of a naos and, on the west, a narthex. The naos is of the basilica type, with a cupola. Two rows of columns divide it into three naves, of which the central nave is covered with barrel vaulting, while the aisles are half barrel vaulted. The central nave is intersected by a square core, which is covered with a cupola over a tall drum. The roof cover of the narthex has the same structure as that of the naos.

A carved wooden and gold-painted iconostasis rests on the eastern pair of columns.



*Plan of the church.*



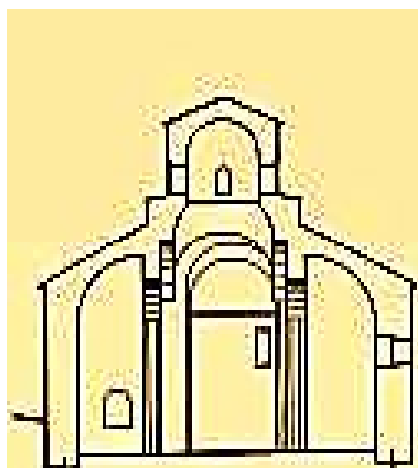
*View from the northwest of the church before restoration.*



*Elevation view of the west of the church.*



*View from the southeast of the church after restoration.*



*Cross-section of the church.*

In general, the exterior is composed of a simple architectural and decorative treatment. The masonry is built with stone, devoid of any decorative elaboration. The wide gabled roof is covered with slate. The only element that breaks the simplicity is the drum of the cupola, which includes a row of arched niches framed in the upper part by a brick cornice in a saw-tooth shape. The fields of the filled-in niches contain various brick patterns.



*Views of the church from the west  
before and after restoration*



*Elevation view from the east.*

## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT

The major damage to the church building was in its structural integrity, consisting of the following:

- Fissures that were both numerous and of considerable size in the masonry and in the system of both the arches and the vaulting of the roof.
- Inclinations from the vertical of the perimeter walls of the church that went as far as 13 cm (5.11 inches).
- Settlement of the floor and settlement of the roof that were off the horizontal as much as 40 cm (15.7 inches).
- Dangerous caverns below the foundations.
- Clear detachment of the apse from the remainder of the building, with damage to the slate roof that allowed rain water to penetrate into the interior.

This caused severe harm to the wall paintings, artefacts, and other interior ornamentation.

## 3. RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

The work undertaken was in accordance with the needs of the church's condition. It consisted of the consolidation of the construction in order to restore and improve its structural integrity, which had been lowered considerably. This was achieved by:

- Strengthening the existing construction, such as by tamp-pointing, stitching and injections.
- Increasing the support integrity of the building by reinforcement of the foundations with reinforced concrete underpinnings and reinforced concrete walls and by filling in the caverns below them.
- Adding other structural elements, such as mounting metal braces to absorb the horizon-





*Views of the cupola before and after restoration.*

tal thrust of the arches and vaults and installing metal plates for the anchoring of the apse.

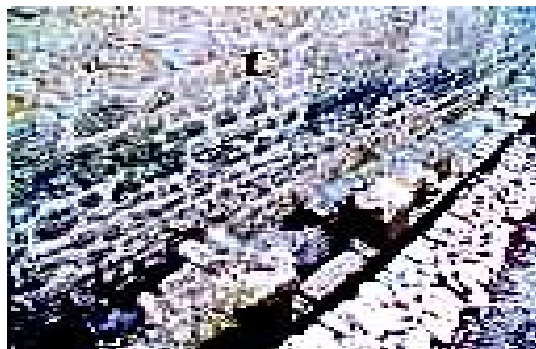
Other interventions consisted of:

- Reconstruction of the roof.
- Rebuilding the flooring layer.
- Restoration of the belfry tower.
- Arrangement of the territory.
- Conservation work on the iconostasis.
- Furnishing the interior with a pulpit,

bishop's throne, pews and other items.

During the restoration work, traces of previous construction were discovered, revealing earlier phases of the building of this church.

*Traces of old buildings discovered during restoration.*





*View from the east of the church before restoration.*

#### **4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

The design of the restoration project and the consolidation and restoration work: B. Strazimiri, eng. restorer, in collaboration with the Branch of Monuments of Berat, directed by A. Nallbani.

Conservation work on the iconostasis was performed by a restoration group of the Institute of Monuments, directed by G. Treska.

The work started in July 2001 and finished in February 2002.

The total value of the work reached the sum of 14,235,000 lekë.

The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service, directed by Father Theologos, Arch. Restorer.

**The total value amounted to 15,125,000 lekë (US\$ 151,250).**

*View from the east of the church after restoration.*





*VRAHOGORANXI, GJIROKASTËR*  
**CHURCH OF ST. MARY,  
CONSERVATION OF THE WALL  
PAINTING**

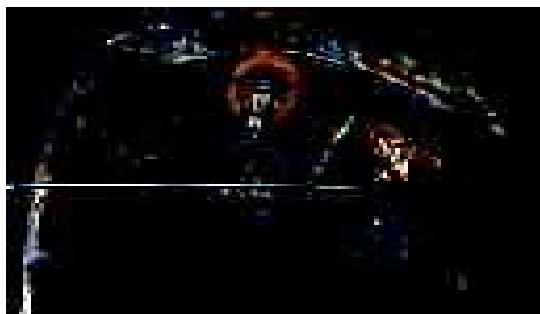
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Following the completion of the work for consolidation and restoration of the building, work for the conservation of the wall paintings was undertaken.

According to the inscription on the west gate of the naos, the church was painted in the year 1622 by Onufër Qiprioti in co-operation with another painter whose name was Alivizi. Onufër Qiprioti is known as a painter of frescoes and an iconographer, based on activity conducted in the churches of the town of Berat and in many monasteries and churches of the region of Gjirokastrë. It is precisely in the church of St. Mary in Vrahogoranci where a complete pictorial ensemble is displayed. Here scholars may discover the favourite stylistic and thematic motifs of the painter and the artistic value contained in the work of this great painter of the seventeenth century. But these values could not have been completely revealed in the condition in which the painting had reached the present.

*Christ Pantocrator*





*St. Mary Platytera: above, before restoration, below, after restoration.*



## 1. THE EXISTING CONDITION OF THE PAINTING

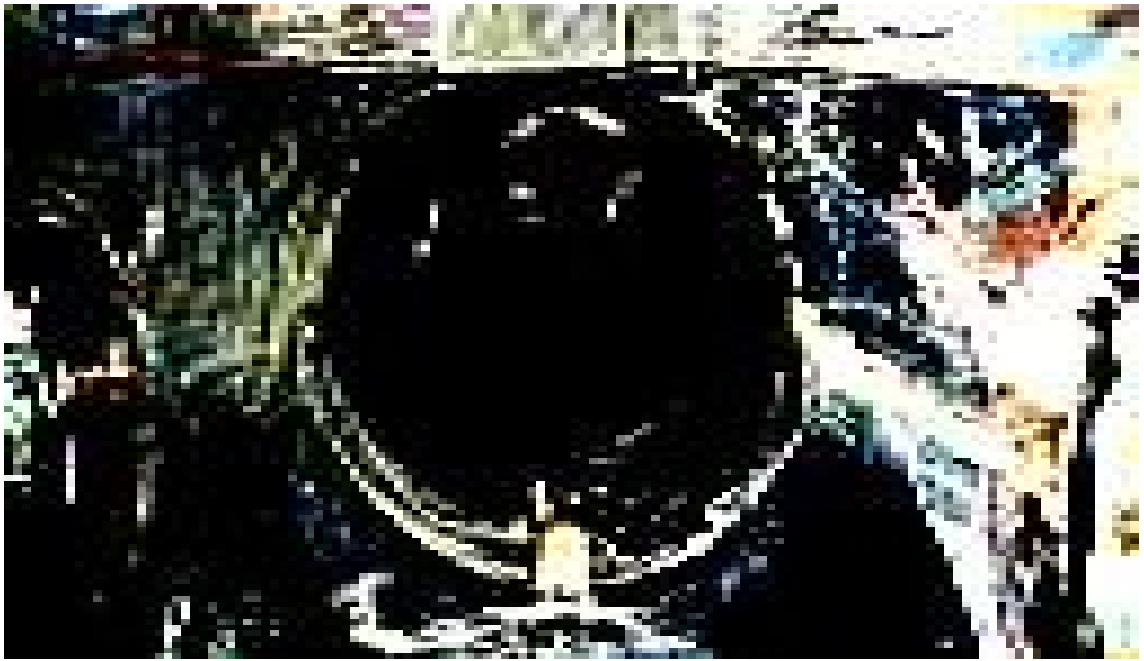
An investigation of the existing situation brought out the damage to the wall paintings and the causes of this damage:

- There were numerous fissures in the painting, caused by the damage to the construction of the building.
- The structural support addition of the painting was detached from the masonry of the building, endangering the integrity of the fresco.
- Salinization had been caused by the penetration of humidity.
- The painting had been darkened by fire, decomposition of varnish and microbiological factors.
- A particularly intense darkening of the painting had been caused by a fire in the pulpit, which not only singed the surface of the painting but also caused it to fuse into the burned varnish and lacquer, rendering the painting dirty in some places.
- Careless later interventions, such as the caulking of fissures with cement mortar and using lime paint, had also damaged the painting.

## 2. CONSERVATION INTERVENTIONS

The main aim of the conservation interventions was to consolidate the painting and make it legible.

- The detachment of the layer of the painting from the masonry was eliminated by means of injections and infilling spaces with special mortar.
- In some limited areas, when the detachment of the painting was more than 10 cm (3.9 inch), the painting was removed and re-installed after reworking the detached fragment and its support base.



· Another measure for consolidation was the stitching fissures and infilling the cracks. In those places where the fissures or cracks were capillary or of a small size, they were filled during the injection process.

· On the other hand, if the fissures were considerable, they were cleaned deep into the masonry and tamp pointing was used or infill with

*Christ Pantocrator: above, before restoration, below, after restoration.*





*Images of standing saints: above, before restoration, below, after restoration.*



fresh mortar. There were difficulties with the fissures on the eastern wall, where it was discovered that the main cause of damage was the presence of wild vegetation in the masonry, the action of which had even decomposed the connection of the masonry.

- Freeing the fissures from caulking or later infill with lime mortar presented difficulties, since the mortar had created a strong connection and every carelessness in removing it would cause detachment of the painting or of its surface.

- The removal of the salts from the surface of the painting was an important conservation measure, because further decomposition of the painting would be caused if it were left in that condition.

- After the general consolidation of the wall painting, an aesthetic evaluation was made, through a general but not deep cleaning of dust, soot, blackening from candle smoke and decomposed varnish.

With these interventions we can say that the first and the most important phase of the conservation of the wall painting of this church was finished: the wall painting regained its integrity and at the same time, discovered its artistic and aesthetic value.

### **3. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

- The project of conservation and restoration of the wall painting was prepared by M. Arapi, painter and restorer.

- The work for the conservation and restoration of the wall painting was performed under the direction and direct participation of the author of the project during the year 2004.

- The work was supervised by the Department of Cultural Heritage of OACA were Prof. Dr. P. Thomo, and G. (John) Stratobërdha, architect.

- The value of the work came to **2,000,000 lekë (US\$ 20,000).**



*BODRISHTA - GJIROKASTËR*  
**CHURCH OF THE ARCHANGEL  
MICHAEL**

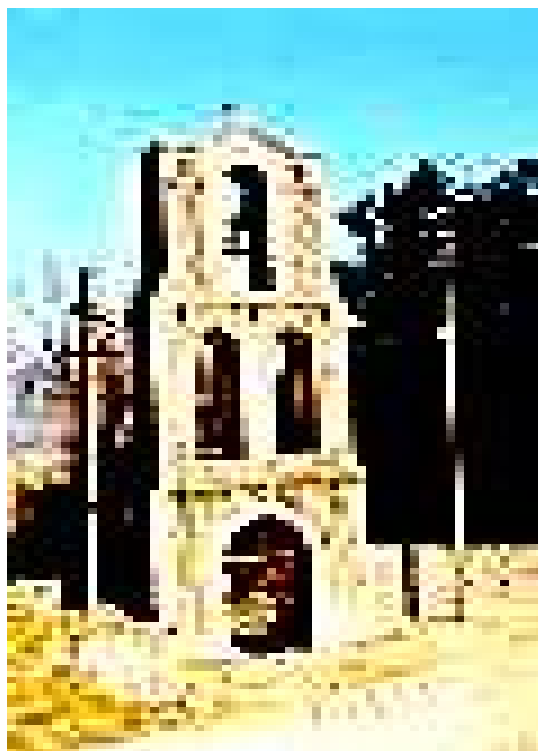
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**1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The village of Bodrishta is situated in the upper region of Dropull in the Gjirokastrë district.

The region of Dropull runs through the valley of the river Drinos at the foot of the Mali i Gjerë (the Wide Mountain) and Stugara Mountain. The villages of Dropull have a scenic position, strung out in a row at the foot of Mali i Gjerë and along the plains of Dropull.

Archaeological excavations show that region was inhabited in ancient times. Near the village of Sofratik, the ruins of a theatre, temple, and necropolis were discovered, which are thought to have belonged to the ancient city of Hadrianopolis. This region was probably also the headquarters of the Bishopric of Drianopoja. The most ancient monument surviving from the Byzantine period is the church of St. Mary in the village of Peshkopi e Sipërme, most probably dating from the 12<sup>th</sup> century. Starting from the 16<sup>th</sup> century, a large number of monuments were erected on the eastern side of Mali i Gjerë, eight of which have survived to the present.



*Entrance to the church complex.*

The church of the Archangel Michael of Bodrishta was built in the centre of this village.

In his book *To Dhelvino tis Voriu Ipiru* (*Delvina of Northern Epiros*), Baras gives us a catalogue of the monasteries and churches built and/or restored by Bishop Dhositheu of Drianopoja and Gjirokastër between the years 1778 and 1790. The church of the Archangel of Bodrishta is mentioned in this catalogue. Typologically as well, the building of this church is in conformity with the above period.

The land surrounding the church is enclosed by walls, thereby creating a closed churchyard that functioned as the village graveyard. The churchyard has an irregular planar form and a gentle slope in the east-west direction, where terraces paved with slate have been systematically arranged in various places.

The sole entrance to the churchyard is a gate on the southwest side. It is of a monumental character, with the belfry tower rising over it in the form of a wall or high tower. There are other buildings besides the church in the churchyard: a

*View of the church from the west, after restoration.*







*Damage to the supporting structure. Part of the vaults of the northern aisle had collapsed.*

chapel on the south side and a building in the shape of an open gallery on the northwest side of the church.

The church is composed of a naos and a narthex on its western side. The entrance to the naos is on the north. There are clear traces of the existence of a portico that once protected the entrance.

The naos is a three-aisled basilica in type and is covered with a system of arches, vaults and spherical calottes.

The sanctuary is divided from the naos by a wooden iconostasis, which leans against the eastern pair of columns. The sanctuary terminates on the eastern side with three apses: the central apse of the bema, polygonal on the outside, and the apses of the prothesis and the diaconicon, which are three-sided on the outside.

The narthex is joined to the naos on the western side and is connected to it by a gate and two windows, one on either side. The entrance from

*Inclination of the columns.*





*Situation of the apse before restoration.*

*View of the apse after restoration.*



the churchyard is a gate with an arched cover on the west side. The roof system of the narthex is the same as that of the naos. The belfry tower is a wall of stone containing arched openings for the bells. It rises above the windowless wall on the west side of the narthex.

The entire interior of the naos is filled with wall paintings, which are the main elements of its interior ornamentation. Other interior artefacts such as the iconostasis, *proskynetarions*, bishop's throne, pulpit and pews are either in very poor condition or have disappeared completely.

The volume composition and exterior decoration are quite simple. This is because the interior system of the roof is not reflected in the exterior, which is covered by a wide gabled roof. The elements that break this uniformity are the apses on the east side, the belfry tower rising above the western wall, and the portico, which protected the entrance on the northern side.

The church masonry is built with stratified limestone bound with lime mortar, 70 cm (27.5 inches) thick. The layering of the stones in the masonry has been done almost completely in regular rows. The mortar is made of small and medium-sized granules of sand, with lime used as a binder. The columns are built of stones with circular *spondiles*.

The building technique of the vaulted elements and the building material are the same as those of the main masonry. The structural system of the arched roof was based on counteracting and mutually cancelling the horizontal thrust of the arches, as well as a network of wooden braces placed at the spring lines of the arches.

A wooden roof is built over the old roof system of the interior ceiling. Its ceiling is made of white stone slabs, 5 cm (1.96 inches) thick and laid in regular rows.



### 1.1 Other Buildings in the Churchyard

Of the churchyard buildings, we single out the building that rises on the northwest side of the church, closely related both architecturally and functionally to it. Through it we can pass to the grounds in front of the church.

The eastern façade of this building is open, with a stone arcade giving it the character of a “gallery”. From here, religious services organized in the churchyard could be followed. The arcade might also have served as a pleasant resting place. There is a broad view of the surrounding landscape from it.

*A moment from the work of returning the northern wall to its initial position. This is considered one of the most difficult interventions, especially in this case when the entire vaulting system rested on the interior of the masonry. By using a jack-screw and easing the masonry from the weight of the vaults, it was managed to eliminate the inclination of the masonry to a considerable extent.*

## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT

The church suffered from serious structural damage, resulting in a catastrophic situation. The collapse of the vaults was advancing; and there were visible inclinations of the perimeter walls as far as 29 cm (11.4 inches) off the vertical, considerable fissures in the roof and the masonry,



*Views from the north aisle before and after restoration.*

inclinations of the columns as far as 29 cm (11.4 inches) off the vertical, breaking or decay of wood braces, damage to wall paintings, and much other damage. This ever-worsening situation would have led to the inevitable collapse of the monument.

The masonry of the “gallery” was in poor condition. There were inclinations and numerous fissures at the northern and western walls; a portion of the western wall even reached 25 cm (9.8 inches) from the vertical. In addition, the entire eastern arcade inclined from within as far as 8 cm (3.14 inches).

### **2.1 Causes of the Damage**

Generally, the building foundations rest on hard terrain, which has kept the masonry from settling and the structure from collapsing.

The numerous fissures in the roof system of the naos resulted from the aging of the material, especially the wooden braces, which over time lost their function. Consequently, the system lost its structural stability because of the irresistible force of the horizontal thrust of the arches by means of their mutual cancellation. Because of this, a slight earthquake shock was enough to cause fissures in the structures and their collapse.

The loss of this stability had negative consequences both for the northern and the southern masonry walls. The interior columns, unable to resist the horizontal thrust of the roof, also suffered from inclinations, cracks and fissures.

Damage to the “gallery” also resulted from the system’s loss of structural stability, caused principally by the collapse of the roof and the separation of the arcade braces. This removed the building’s transverse connection to the adjacent building, especially at the two longitudinal faces.

### 3. INTERVENTIONS FOR CONSOLIDATION AND RESTORATION

The restoration interventions consisted of:

**3.1** Returning of the elements inclined off the vertical to their initial position. These elements included the northern and southern wall of the naos, the columns of the northern row of the naos, the arcade of the “gallery,” and others.

**3.2** Interventions for strengthening the existing construction:

These interventions are those made up of local technique, such as tamp-pointing, injections, in-filling the damaged elements, and stitching the fissures.

**3.3** Consolidation of the construction with new elements and the replacement of non-functional elements:

This category includes those interventions undertaken when the interventions for strengthen-



*View from the west of the church before restoration.*



*View from the west of the gallery before restoration.*



*View from the east of the gallery before restoration.*

ing mentioned above were insufficient to achieve their objective. It includes the substitution of horizontal braces, the placing of circular braces in the spherical calottes, reinforcement of the foundations of columns and other interventions.

### 3.4 The rebuilding work consisted of:

- Rebuilding the structure of the collapsed roof.
- Rebuilding the roof with wooden material, separate from the structure of the inner structure.
- Rebuilding the roof of the gallery.

*View from the northeast of the church after restoration.*



- Rebuilding the northern portico.
- Rebuilding the southern arcade of the gallery, while preserving traces from the previous construction.

### 3.5 Conservation work on the wall paintings:

During the consolidation work for the construction, measures were taken to protect the wall paintings. Work to conserve the wall paintings that remained was also undertaken by consolidating and cleaning them.

### 3.6 Work on arranging the church territory:

This included work in the churchyard, such as the completion of the perimeter walls, the arrangement of paths, grave plots, green areas, and a canal network for the surface waters. Interior and exterior lighting of the monument was also implemented.

With the execution of the above work, we can say that this monument was protected from all but certain destruction. Its collapse would have had a great psychological and social cost not only for the residents of the village but also for the whole region, because the church is closely associated with the history and the life of the village.

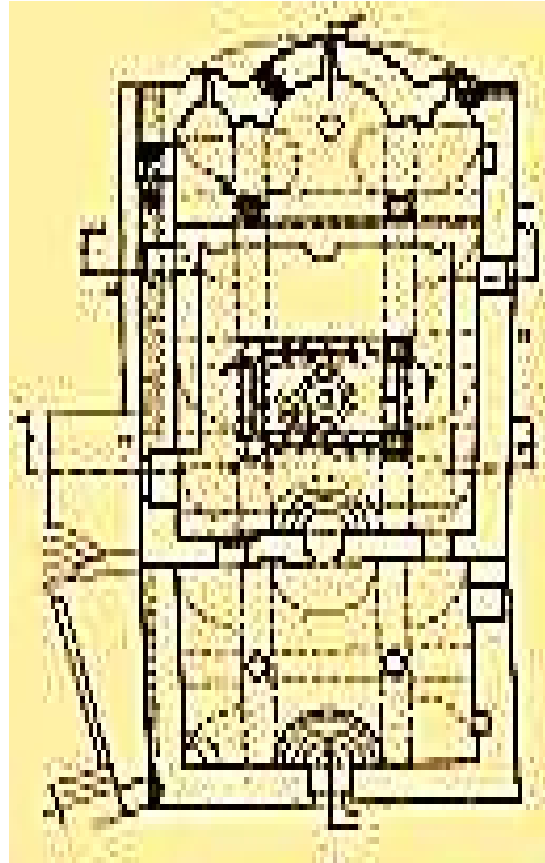
## 4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA

The project restoration was performed by Prof. Dr. P. Thomo.

The consolidation and restoration work was implemented by the private company Ad-Star, directed by A. Çoma, eng.

The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service, directed by Father Theologos, arch. restorer.

Restoration work was implemented during the years 2001-2002.



*Plan of the church.*

*View of a cross section of the church.*



**The total value for the building complex  
was 13,650,000 lekë (US\$ 136,500)**

*View of the southwest of the  
church, after restoration.*







## *ZERVAT – GJIROKASTËR*

### **THE CHURCH OF THE DORMITION OF THEOTOKOS**

---

The Church of the Dormition in the village of Zervat, region of Dropull, is one of the most important monuments of the Post-Byzantine period preserved in the area, with special artistic and architectural value. It is of special interest not only for its typology and morphology, but also for the study of the construction phases and their dating. Furthermore, because of the lack of systematic maintenance, the monument had suffered such damage that, if it continued, both the struc-

*Entrance gate to the church yard,  
elaborated with carved stones.*





*View of the church from the southwest before restoration.*

tural integrity and the painting that covers the interior would be considerably endangered.

## **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The church was erected at the entrance of the village, in the middle of the cemetery. The territory is surrounded by walls, with the western entrance standing out, built with dressed stones and decorated with different motifs carved on a flat relief. The gate is made of iron, worked by the master Z. Kizas in the year 1936.

Two inscriptions, still intact, attest to the dates of the building and painting of the church. The first inscription, carved in a stone embedded in the masonry of the belfry, apparently at a later phase, bears the date 1583 and the name Kalistos. We find the same name on an inscription of the *katholikon* of the monastery of Drianos, above the village of Zervat, dealing with a building of the year 1569.

The second inscription, painted on the plaster above the western gate of the naos, deals with



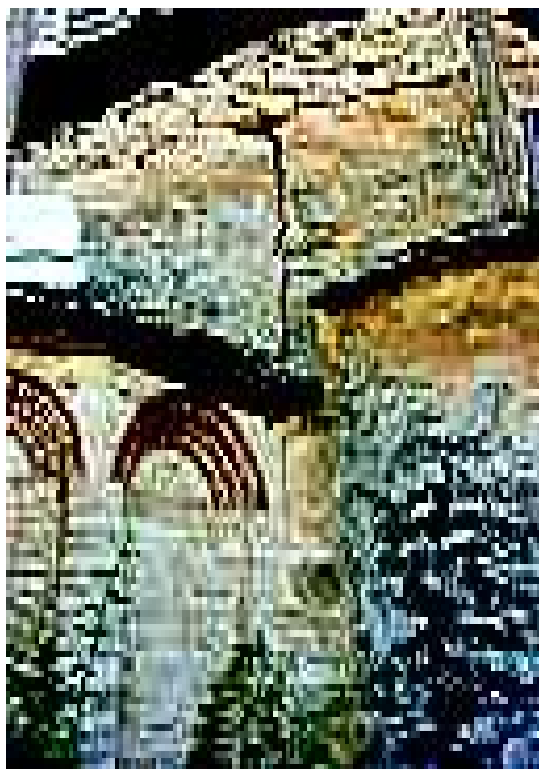
the building and painting of the church by the painters Michael and Nicholas in the year 1606.

*View of the church from the east before restoration.*

The church consists of the naos, a narthex on the western side, and a gallery in the south, connected by a portico in front of the northern entrance of the naos, a belfry that rises over the western wall of the narthex and a second portico in front of the northern entrance to the narthex.

In the present situation of the church, the naos belongs to the domed three-aisled basilica type with a transept. The internal supports that divide the aisles are connected by lengthwise arches, strongly emphasising the basilica composition of the nave. The cupola is elevated above a high drum at the intersection of the lengthwise naves with the transept. The covering of the naves is barrel-vaulted.

The sanctuary is separated from the nave by a wooden iconostasis that leans on the eastern pair of pilasters. On the exterior it ends in three apses that project outward, projected-out apses, with the side apses being polygonal and the central ones circular.



*Separated seams of the phases:  
above, view from the east, below,  
view from the north.*



On the western side, the narthex is covered with a vaulting system, which does not repeat the composition of the covering of the nave. The narthex has a separate entrance on the northern side, which is protected by a portico. There are clear traces that there used to be a second entrance through the gallery.

The gallery is developed along the southern side of the church. It is open in front, with an arcade supported by stone columns, and it is covered with a wooden shed roof.

The southern entrance of the naos is protected by a portico with two columns in front, which are connected with one another and with the perimeter walls of the naos by arches, thus forming a square core covered with a spherical calotte.

The belfry tower rises over the pediment of the western wall of the narthex. The heavy mass of its masonry becomes lighter in the upper part because of the curved spaces where the bells are placed.

The church has little lighting and few artefacts or decorative elements. The wall painting is the principle element of its decoration, covering the entire interior of the church, both the naos and narthex.

## 2. PHASES OF CONSTRUCTION

From a careful look at the church, many traces can be made out, leading to the conclusion that the monument comes from different phases of construction and that its present appearance is the result of interventions at various times.

In the eastern, southern and northern masonry there are clear vertical seams, which show the existence of two different construction phases. An analysis of samples of mortar taken from each phase showed differences in their composition, verifying the above conclusion.

· Vertical seams in the eastern masonry divide the central apse from the two side ones, while in the masonry of the north and south sides, seams fit with the boundaries of the transept.

· The naos is divided from the narthex by vertical seams, showing that these two parts do not belong to the same time period.

· Vertical seams also divide the masonry of the narthex from that of the gallery.

· Some additions were made in the pediment of the eastern, southern and northern wall to increase the height of the roof. The masonry of these additions was done completely without technical care, and it is not connected to the existing masonry.

Since the above-mentioned elements clearly show the existence of different phases of construction, surveys were conducted to verify the nature of these phases and determine exact information about them.

· The first surveys were conducted in the foundations of the building, beneath the vertical seams. These surveys showed that the seams continued as far as the foundations, making it quite certain that these two phases were built at different times.

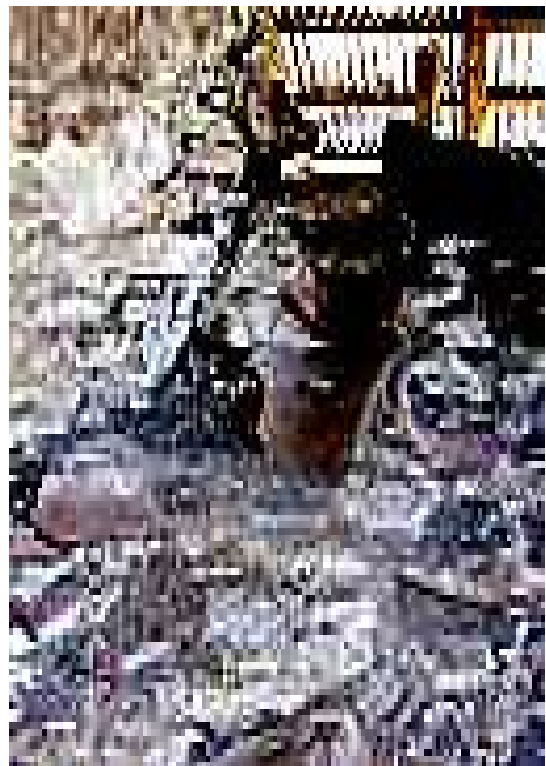
· The surveys conducted inside the naos, between the columns, pilasters and perimeter walls, brought out the foundations of the first building phase, which corresponded with the exterior vertical seams.

· Another survey was conducted on the roof, next to the drum of the cupola. Large Byzantine tiles were discovered, set with mortar directly on the vault of the east arm of the cross.

Based on observations of the monument and on the surveys conducted, six building phases were defined:



*Traces of the tiles of the covering of the first phase, discovered during the surveys.*





*First building phase, in which the church belonged to the domed free cruciform type.*

*Second building phase, in which the church was converted to a domed cross-in-square church.*

- In the first phase, the church belonged to the architectural type of a domed free cruciform plan, with the arms of the cross of equal sizes.

- During the second phase, four angled areas were added, and the church was converted into the type of a cross-in-square church.

- In a third phase, the church was added to on the west side, becoming a basilica with a cupola and transept, and with a portico in front of the southern entrance.

- The narthex, belfry tower, and northern portico belong to the fourth phase.

- During the fifth phase, the gallery on the southern side was added and the church was completed with all the constituent elements.

- It is to be noted that the sequential phases were done in harmony with one another, with each successive phase completing the previous one. Thus the church was converted from a small and simple place to worship into a large church of the region, doubtless in response to the increasing requirements of the village.

- The sixth phase no longer has to do with functional and typological requirements, but with a later addition, during which the roof was made



higher and all traces of the previous phases were covered up. This had negative consequences, both to the structural integrity of the building and in the monument's aesthetic aspect.

· Removing the covering, which was necessary for consolidating the construction, also brought to light many other important elements. Numerous traces of the tiles of the first phase were discovered, as well as the arms of both the cross and the cupola, the height of the roofs of later phases, fragments of cornices in saw-tooth form that ended up the masonry of the arms of the cross, as well as many other elements of different building phases.

With regard to the chronology of the building phases, there is now no doubt that the first phase belongs to the Byzantine period. The second phase has to have the year 1583 as its outside limit, since that is the date on the first inscription. We can consider 1606, the year on the second inscription, as the end of the third phase. This date also serves to mark the boundary between the third and fourth phases, during which the narthex was added. The building of the gallery may be attributed to the eighteenth century, a

*Final phase, in which the church was converted to the domed basilica type and equipped with all elements: narthex, gallery, belfry tower.*





*Tamp pointing and stitching of vaults.*

period during which basilicas with a gallery generally appeared.

### 3. RESTORATION WORK

Based on the condition of the building and an architectural and artistic study of the monument, a project for restoration was prepared. It proceeded step by step and took final form with the discovery of traces and other elements.

*Restoration of the arms of the cross of the first phase.*

Structurally, the interventions were concentrated on consolidating the supporting construction, the foundations, the masonry and the vaults,







in order to return them to a condition of structural integrity, which had been weakened by time and damage.

With regard to architecture and typology, the main criterion implemented was the preservation and evidence of all the main building phases, to make it possible to trace all the history of the development of the monument. To reach this aim, the sixth building phase was eliminated, something that is also supported in the Charter of Venice, which permits the removal of a building phase when it hides elements of outstanding archaeological value or when it damages the integrity of the monument. The instant case meets these conditions completely. The sixth phase, with its great volume of infill, exerts an unnecessary weight on the construction of the building. On the other hand, it should be removed because of the necessity of consolidating interventions in the construction. Returning the structure to its initial condition after the consolidating interventions would otherwise have no meaning.

Regarding the things of value that have been uncovered, it goes without saying that the discov-

*Restoration of the roof of both the first and second phases.*

Restoration of the covering of the cupola, based on the traces discovered during surveys.





*A fragment of the wall painting before restoration.*

ery of the first phase of Byzantine period is a very important datum for the history of church architecture in these regions, showing, among other things, the spread of the free cruciform plan, which until today has been known only in the monastery church of Zvěrnec and in the church of Marmirol. To make this phase more visible, as well as the second phase in which the church became a cross-in-square church, the roof of the third phase, which hid the covering of the first two phases, was interrupted at the end of the sec-

*A fragment of the wall painting after restoration.*



ond phase. In this way, this act is considered as an archaeological or stratigraphic cut, making it possible to observe what was hidden under it.

The covering of the first phase was completed with tiles produced in the traditional way, with the same size and shape.

Parallel with the architecture work, conservation work of the wall painting went on. The work consisted first in consolidation, then in the elimination of the salts, darkened spots, decomposed varnish and plaster. These interventions and the cleaning of the fresco brought the real artistic values into the open, which are of a high level but in the previous condition were not accessible to visitors.

#### 4. TECHNICAL DATA

The consolidation and restoration work was prepared by Prof. Dr. P. Thomo, in co-operation with L. Papas, eng. with a Master's degree in restoration.

The scientific work and the elaboration of the project were directed by Prof. Dr. P. Thomo.

The work was implemented by the building company AD-STAR, directed by A. Çoma, eng.

The conservation work of the wall painting was prepared by Prof. Dr. H. Nallbani.

The implementation of the conservation work was directed by the author of the project, Prof. Dr. H. Nallbani.

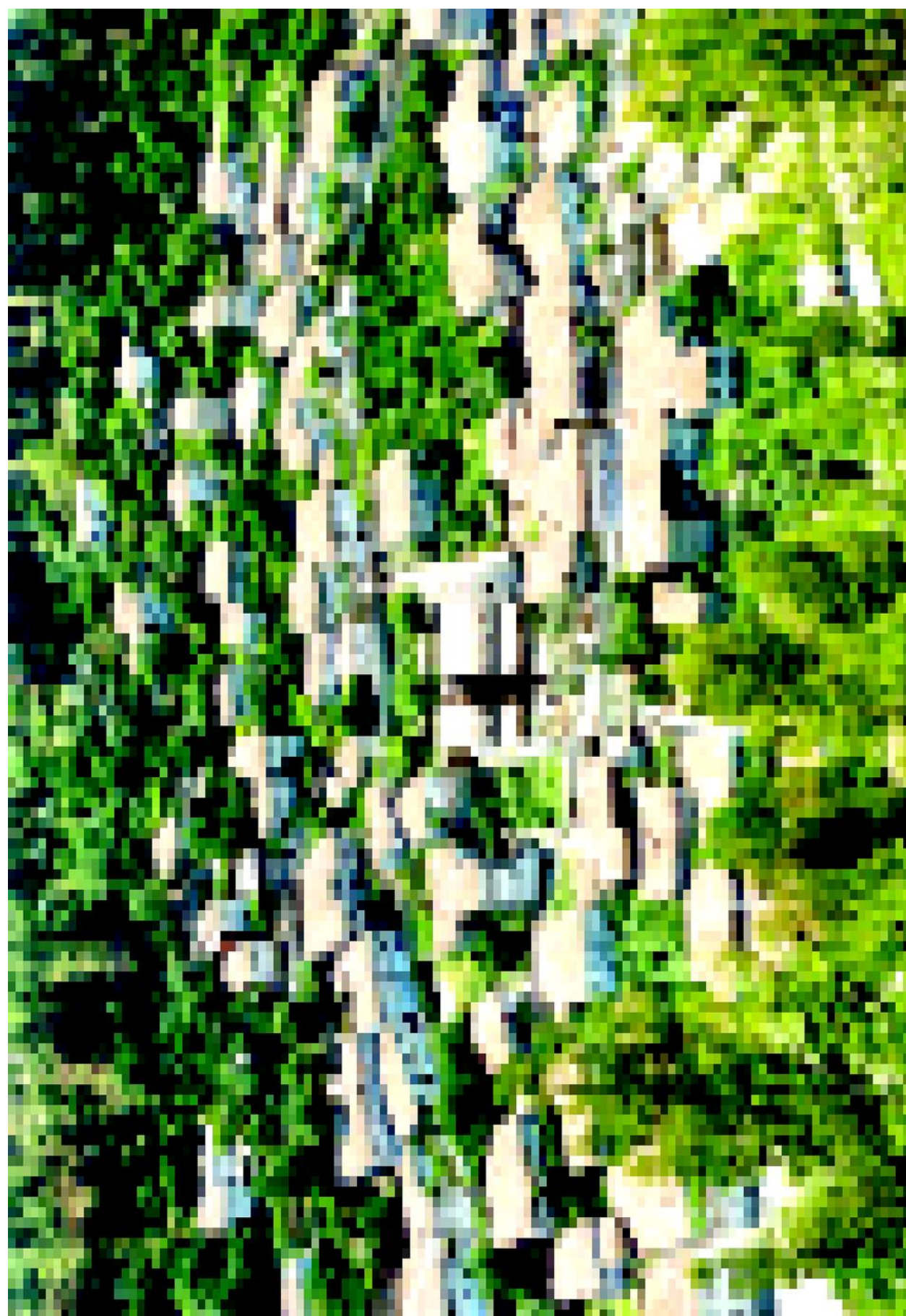
The restoration work started in the year 2002 and is expected to finish during 2005.

The value of the work performed reached the sum of **40,000,000 lekë (US\$ 400,000)**.

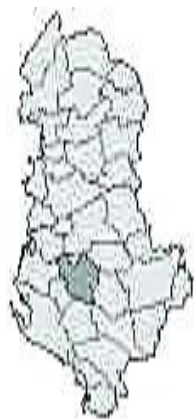


*Fragments of the wall painting after restoration.*









## *BERAT*

### CHURCH OF ST. SPIRIDON

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#### 1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW

Berat is one of those rare cities that history has generously endowed with historical and artistic values of every period and genre. Archaeological finds, boundary walls, Christian buildings, urban complexes with traditional buildings, wall paintings, icons, miniatures, iconostases, carved wooden ceilings, fine work in textile and metal and other treasures comprise a valuable source of study extending over a wide range.

St. Mary's church of Vllaherna, St. Trinity's church inside the castle, and the church of St. Michael outside the walls of the castle have all reached the present from the Byzantine period. A large number of churches were also built throughout the post-Byzantine period. Many of them were painted by well-known masters of that time, such as Onufri, Onufer Qiprioti, Nicholas of Onufri, and others.

The church of St. Spiridon rises in the centre of a quarter called Gorrica, across from the Osum River. Gorrica is one of the town quarters with such exceptional urban and architectural value that it has become a Museum Quarter, under the

*Belfry tower of the church after restoration.*





*View of the church before restoration.*

protection of the government. The Gorrica quarter is situated at the foot of the mountain in an amphitheatre shape, gently descending towards the Osum River. With its large dimensions, silhouette, and position, the church of St. Spiridon makes up the principal highlight of the complex and its compositional centre.

The church of St. Spiridon was probably built in the eighteenth century. It is composed of a naos, a narthex, and a gallery open on the northern side. The belfry tower, which has three levels, stands in the north-west corner. The naos, is of the basilica type covered with a flat ceiling. Two longitudinal arcades with stone columns divide the naves from one another. Each of them is covered by a separate ceiling with vaulted indentations at the centre. On the western side, the *ginekonitti* projects out in the form of an inner balcony. The masonry of the church contains such architectural decorated elements as windows, gallery arcades, a belfry tower, and others.

*View of the church after restoration.*



## 2. RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

During the Communist period the church was abandoned, and consequently its structures were heavily damaged.

The first restoration interventions consisted in the structural consolidation of the building and in the restoration of the absent or totally damaged architectural elements. Similarly, some work was carried out to improve the functionality of the building in order to preserve its initial use as a Christian building. Between the years 1997 and 2000, the following work was done:

- Rebuilding the missing parts of the masonry and repairing the existing parts.
- Returning the gallery colonnade, which had a marked deviation from the vertical, to its initial position.
- Removing earth from the southern side and supplying it with a drainage and water-isolation system to avoid humidity.
- Complete rebuilding of the roof.
- Installation of windows on the southern side.
- Rebuilding the belfry tower.
- Supplying the naves with wooden ceilings.
- Flooring.
- Building the baptismal font.
- Electrical, plumbing and heating installations.
- Arrangement of the outdoor territory.

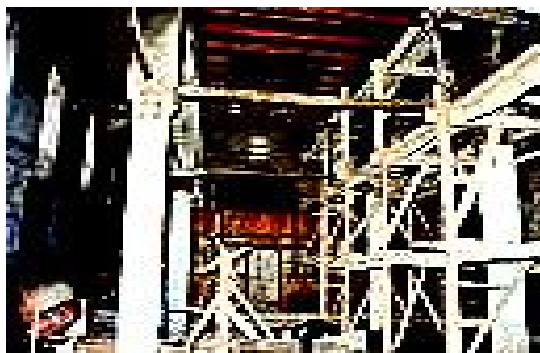
## 3. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA

The first phase of the restoration project was designed by the Institute of Monuments of Culture.

The second-phase of the restoration project was designed by the O.A.C.A's Office of the Technical Service.



*Views from the interior before restoration. The roof was entirely ruined, and the presence of water can be seen, while the braces are out of function.*



*View from the interior during restoration.*

The implementation work was performed by the “Number 1” construction company of Berat, directed by M. Baballeku.

The work was done between the years 1996 and 2000 under the supervision of D. Bello, eng. of the O.A.C.A.’s Office of Technical Service.

**The cost of the work reached the sum of 29,290,399 lekë (US\$ 292,200)**

*View from the interior after restoration.*







## *KOLONJA - LUSHNJA* **MONASTERY OF ARDENICA**

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### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The monastery of Ardenica is the largest and the best known monastery in all of Myzeqe. It is situated at the top of a high hill in a very picturesque position. On one side, there is a broad view of the field of Myzeqe, while on the other, the view extends to the Adriatic Sea. The area encircling the monastery is forested with cypresses and sea pines.

*Aerial view of the monastery of Ardenica.*





*View of the monastery during the beginning of the restoration of the roof.*

From a distance, the view of the monastery is very impressive.

Throughout its history, the monastery has undergone various building phases until reaching its present state. The oldest phase may be attributed to the Byzantine period. According to legend, the celebration of the marriage of the great Prince George Castriot Scanderbeg took place here in 1451.

The monastery is in the shape of a triangle, with a surface area of about 2,500m<sup>2</sup> (26,900 square feet).

*View of the church from the south-east and the belfry tower, after restoration.*





*View of the guesthouse on the southeast of the monastery before restoration.*



*View of the guesthouse on the west of the monastery after restoration.*



*View of the guesthouse on the southeast of the monastery after restoration.*



*View from above of the guesthouse on the west side of the monastery, after restoration.*





*View of the church from the west after restoration.*



A church dedicated to the Dormition (the Sleeping Holy Mary) has been erected in the centre and is surrounded by a guesthouse. In the northeast corner of the church of the Dormition, a chapel of the Holy Trinity is located. In the churchyard, in front of the west guesthouse, the main well is located, while cisterns of water are scattered around the grounds of the monastery. The monastery also has a bakery, an oil press and other facilities.

The guesthouses have the structure that is customary for monastic buildings: the rooms are situated in rows, one after the other, lengthwise, and in front there are galleries or open vestibules, of which those of the ground floor open with stone columns and those on the second floor with wooden columns.

The church was painted in 1744 by the Zografi brothers, Kostandin and Athanas, from the city of Korça. The church is composed of the naos, narthex, southern and western galleries, and an elevated belfry tower in the southwest corner of the church. The naos is of the basilica type, with a flat wooden ceiling. Two rows of wooden columns divide it into three naves. A carved wooden iconostasis with exceptional artistic values divides the altar area. It contains icons of a high artistic quality, some of which

are the works of the well-known iconographer of the 18<sup>th</sup> century, Kostandin Shpataraku. In exterior architectural detailing, the apse, which is worked in carved limestone and enlivened with a blind brick arcade, and the colonnade of the south gallery stand out. Some fragments from ancient reliefs have been placed on the masonry; they are presumed to be from nearby ancient sites, perhaps from Apollonia.

## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT AND RESTORATION WORK

During the Communist regime, the monastery of Ardenica was converted into a tourist site: a hotel, a restaurant and a coffeehouse. Consequently, certain adaptations were made to meet the requirements for these functions. There was a lack of maintenance of the entire monastery, and therefore, when the monument was returned to the church, a great problem existed both for the structural consolidation of the buildings and for the restoration of the complex to its initial function as a monastery.

The following work was implemented for this purpose:

- Rebuilding the church roof.



*Holy Trinity chapel before restoration.*



*Holy Trinity chapel after restoration.*



*A moment from the visit of the Archbishop Anastasios to the monastery.*

- Rebuilding the roof of the guesthouse.
- Repairing the masonry of the guesthouse.
- Installation of doors and windows in the guesthouse.
- Restoration of the chapel of the Holy Trinity.
- Construction of the iconostasis of the chapel of the Holy Trinity.
- Repairing the monastery kitchens.
- Supplying the monastery with drinking water.
- Electrical, plumbing, and heating installations.

### **3. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

The Tirana Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by G. Samimi, eng., performed the work for rebuilding the church roof.

The work for rebuilding the roof and masonry of the guesthouse was realized by the ELIRA construction company, directed by S. Kola, eng.

The restoration work on the chapel of the Holy Trinity was implemented by GEN-RED construction company, directed by R. Gega, arch.

The iconostasis of Holy Trinity was built by the craftsman Mr. Musha.

The work was supervised by the Office of Technical Service of the O.A.C.A, under the direction of Father Theologos, architect and restorer.

The work was implemented between 1996 and 1999.

**The total value of the work amounted to the sum of 19,942,200 lekë (US\$ 199,420)**



## *KOLKONDAS - FIER*

### MONASTERY OF ST. KOZMA

---

#### 1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW

The monastery was erected in memory of the monk Kozma from Etolia, who traveled twice through these regions, in the years 1777 and 1779, in order to carry out religious and educational activity. At that time the ruler of Berat, Ahmed Kurt Pasha, gave orders that he be killed, and eventually, on August 24, 1779, he was indeed murdered. His body was thrown into the Seman River, and it washed up near the village of Kolkondas. Kozma was buried in the narthex of St. Mary's Church. Afterwards, the monastery was erected in his memory near that church.

Two letters of Ali Pasha Tepelena, the Pasha of Ianinna, addressed to the Christians of the Berat *Nahije* (Turkish word for region), published by Alexoudes in 1868, as well as an inscription carved on a stone slab in the apse of the church show the contribution of the Pasha in the building of the monastery. According to the legend, Ali Pasha had struck up a friendship with the monk Kozma, because of the predictions he had made about the Pasha's career and future. A second inscription over the western front door of the



*Views of the katholikon: Above: before the archaeological excavations. Below: after the archaeological excavations.*







*View of the monastery guesthouse after the archaeological excavations. A previously unknown situation of the guesthouse was discovered during these excavations. The element is known in buildings of the same nature in the monuments of the region of Myzeqe (Ardenica) and other regions, but here the arcade is carefully elaborated with dressed stones.*

church gives the date of the building of the church as 12 May 1814.

The monastery complex consisted of the church (*katholikon*), the monastery guesthouse, which enclosed the northern and eastern side of the churchyard, St. Mary's Church in the southern part of the *katholikon* (built in 1782), a chapel between two churches where St. Kozma's relics were placed, and a cenotaph containing his ashes.

At the beginning of the 20<sup>th</sup> century, because of the overflow of the Seman River, the entire monastery was flooded. The church was filled with alluvial materials up to a height of 2.5m (8.2 feet) from the floor. Only the top floor of the monastery guesthouse functioned, while the western wall and a part of the eastern wall remained from St. Mary's Church. During the Communist dictatorship, the monastery was abandoned. Those few parts of the guesthouse that were left were destroyed in 1986.

In the summers of 1995 and 1996, youth camps were organized here by the Archbishopric.



One of the youth activities was the excavation and removal of earth around the two churches. Later, the excavation of the monastery took on a more scientific nature, under the supervision of the Institutes of Monuments of Culture and Archaeology.

The excavations revealed evidence of great interest for the typology of the monastery guesthouse and for elements of the churches of St. Kozma and St. Mary. The ground floor of the monastery guesthouse contained a stone arcade on circular-section columns, developed along the front view. The premises on the ground floor appear to have been used as auxiliary premises.

The excavations in the church of St. Mary revealed its entire northern side, which was covered with wall paintings. It also revealed a large part of the floor, paved with stone and marble slabs. From the typological viewpoint, St. Mary's Church was a basilica with a wooden ceiling. This type was widespread in the region of Myzeqe in both the 18<sup>th</sup> and 19<sup>th</sup> centuries.

With respect to the monastery *katholikon*, the excavations went as deep as its initial floor, bringing to light the entire volume of the building. The church is a domed basilica with lateral apses, which is characteristic of monastic churches. The inner ceiling was implemented with barrel vaulting that covered the central nave and transept, and with spherical calottes covering the aisles. This inner coverage system is partly reflected in the outer views, primarily in the covering of the longitudinal nave and that of the transept, at the intersection of which the dome rises over a high octagonal drum. The dome and the belfry tower that is elevated above the pediment of the western wall give two elements of vertical emphasis to the building and make the outer volume composition more dynamic.

*Interior view of the katholikon during excavations. The excavations reached as deep as the initial level, where the ceiling, containing many original elements, was discovered.*



*View from the north of the katholikon after archaeological excavations.*

*In order to protect the building from any damage that could affect the new static situation, the masonry was reinforced with wooden braces.*

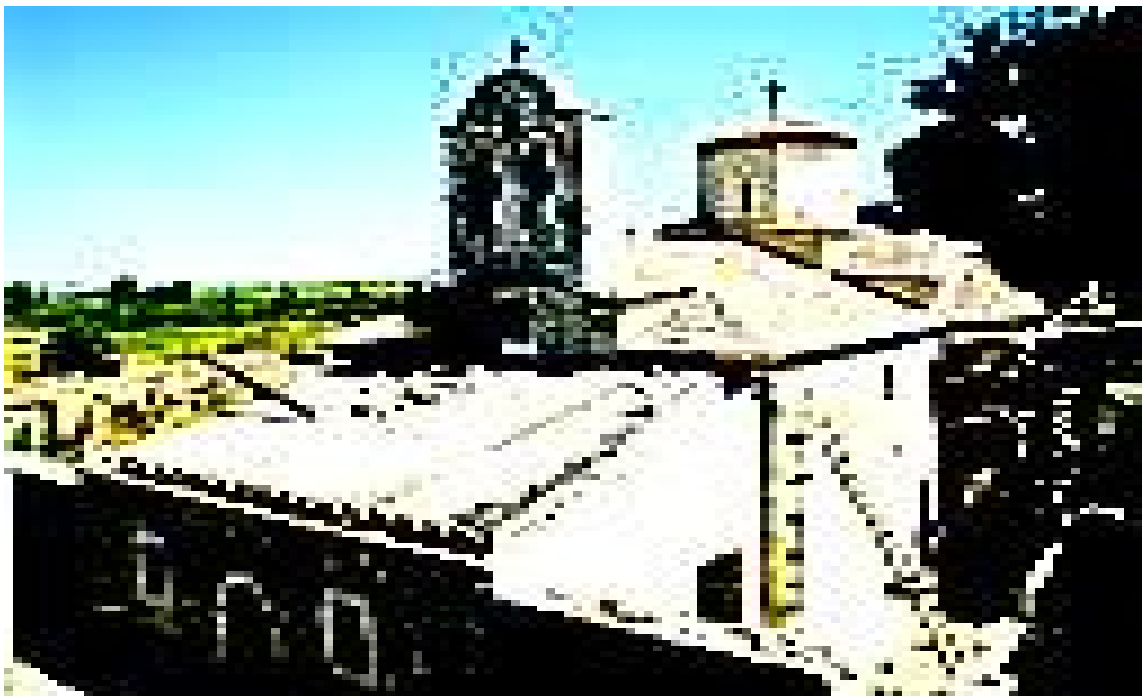


*View of the katholikon from the southeast during restoration.*



The building technique is relatively good. The masonry is implemented with stones bound with lime mortar and is reinforced with hidden wooden tie-beams. The inner covering system, the vaults and the spherical calottes are stone, with the exception of the western side of the central nave, which is built of brick. This is a sign of later restoration.

The outer ornamental elaboration is simple: a mass of stone masonry dominates. Decorative attention is paid to the building of the eastern apse, which is enlivened with a blind arcade, and to the treatment of the architectural elements, such as the entrance door and windows, which are framed with carved stones.



## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT

Although the monument preserved the basic typological and morphological features, its condition presented some problems.

- There were cracks in the mortar and degradation of the wooden tie-beams.

- The inner covering system had suffered serious damage. During the period between the two world wars, the building must have suffered heavy damage, and the roof of the central nave was partially collapsed. The interventions performed at that time consisted of the placement of metal braces (metal profiles), the rebuilding of the collapsed parts of the central nave using bricks as building material, and the mending of other parts of the roof. This intervention work, as can be seen, did not stand up. The metal braces failed, causing fissures and deformations of the roofing system.

- There was also some damage in the roof construction. The tiles were out of alignment, and there were numerous points of leakage into the interior.

*View of the katholikon from the southwest during restoration.*

*A narthex was built on the west to make the church functional. During construction, all the original elements that had survived were evaluated and preserved.*



*View of the katholikon during the restoration work.*

*View of the katholikon from the southeast after restoration.*



### **3. CONSOLIDATION AND RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS**

The criteria for the restoration interventions were conditioned on the one hand by the existing situation of the monument and on the other by the new situation after the archaeological excavations. The latter had created problems both with the structural situation of the monument and with the area around it. The elevation of the terrain was below the level of the Seman River and the field canals, leading to the risk of flooding of the monastery area. This situation was dealt with as follows:

#### **a. The risk of floods**

- A deep drainage system was arranged for collecting underground and surface water. In addition, a pumping station was constructed to remove the waters from the monastery site.

#### **b. Consolidation and restoration of the katholikon**

- Excavations of approximately 2m (6.5 feet) inside and around the church, and the ac-

tual digging to the initial elevation, created the risk of ruining the structural equilibrium of the building, achieved after many years in its particular condition. To avoid this risk, the existing foundations were extended and deepened, and a network was created connecting the inner column foundations with those of the concrete perimeter walls.

- A plan was implemented for stitching the fissures in the masonry, injection, and complete inner and outer tamping-pointing. A new network of metal braces was installed.

- The inner covering system was stitched, and deep tamping-pointing was done.

- The roof of the church was entirely rebuilt, partially with wood and partially with infill of a light material in order to lighten the load from above the inner roof system, and the surface roof surface was inlaid with old-fashioned tiles.

- The narthex was rebuilt, preserving existing traces, in order to meet the functions of the church, but with a new material and volume



*Fragments of the wall painting discovered during archaeological excavations in the Church of St. Mary.*

*View from the south of the Church of St. Mary.*

*A temporary tent was built with sheet-iron to protect the wall painting that had been discovered.*





*Wall painting of St. Kozma and moments from the conservation interventions.*



to distinguish between the original building and the restoration.

#### **c. Church of St. Mary**

· Following the archaeological excavations, wall paintings were discovered at the northern wall of the Church of St. Mary. They were in a bad condition, and preliminary measures were adopted for the careful removal of the earth and for fixing and consolidating the paintings.

#### **d. The Chapel of St. Kozma**

· In the chapel of St. Kozma between the *katholikon* of the monastery and the Church of St. Mary, a wall painting showing St. Kozma standing was discovered. It was in poor condition, and in addition, because of the marked presence of humidity, conditions for preserving it were inappropriate. It was decided to detach it and re-mount it when measures have been adopted to assure an appropriate environment.

#### **e. Various works**

· Among the other works that can be mentioned are the construction of a 3.3 km road connecting the monastery with the main road, electrification of the monastery, the enclosure of the territory and safe-keeping measures.

### **4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

The enclosure of the territory, electrical installations and road construction, as well as other auxiliary work, amounted to 11,644,557 lekë. The work was done by the ELIRA construction company in Fier, directed by S. Kola, eng.

The drainage work reached the sum of 6,800,000 lekë. The work was implemented by the ELIRA construction company in Fier, directed by S. Kola, eng.

The archaeological excavations totalled 20,000,000 lekë. The work was implemented by the ELIRA construction company of Fier, directed by S. Kola, eng., and by GEN-RED of Lushnja, directed by R. Gega, arch., under the supervision of the Institute of Monuments and the Institute of Archaeology.

The project for the church restoration was designed by R. Gega, arch.

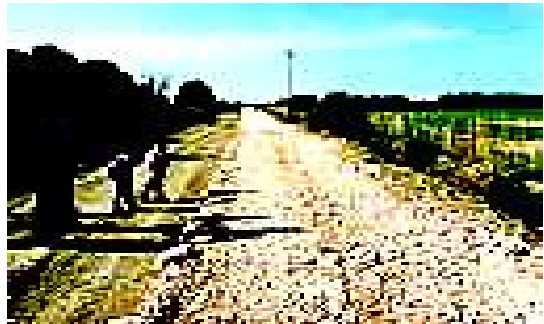
The restoration work on the church had a value of 31,623,000 lekë. The work was implemented by the GEN-RED construction company, directed by R. Gega, arch.

The work was supervised by the employees of the Institute of Monuments and by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

The conservation work for the wall painting in St. Mary's Church was implemented by the staff of the Institute of Monuments.

The work took place between 1996 and 2000.

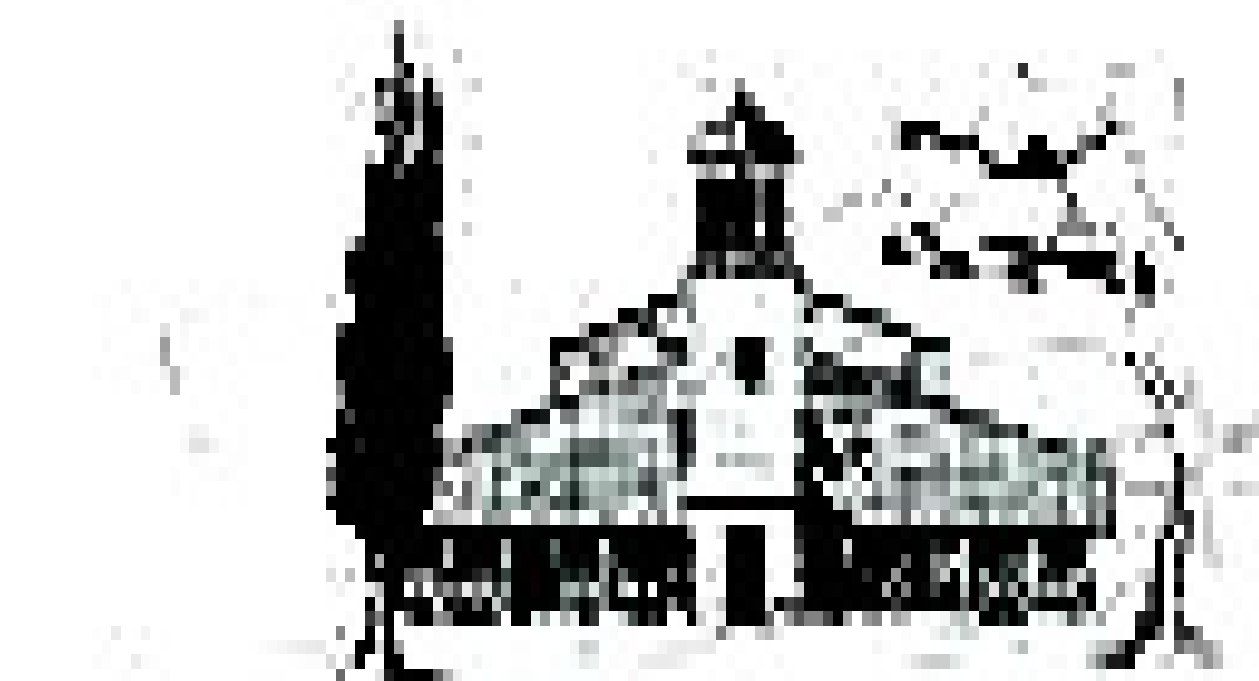
**The expenses totalled 71,600,000 lekë (US\$ 716,000)**



*Pictured above: Building of the road.*

*A scene from the ceremony of St. Kozma's festival.*









## *LIBOFSHA - FIER*

### **CHURCH OF ST. GEORGE**

#### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The church is located outside of the residential area, crowning the top of a slight elevation in the terrain. This creates the principal highlight in the otherwise flat silhouette of the village. Around the church is the old village graveyard.

The church of St. George is a typical representation of a church building type that was widespread throughout the Myzeqe region in the second half of the 18<sup>th</sup> century and the beginning of the 19<sup>th</sup> century. It is composed of a high central naos, surrounded by three closed galleries and by a tall belfry tower. The naos is divided by two rows of wooden columns into three naves with

*General view of the Church of St. George, Libofsha.*



*View of the interior of the church. This church represents the typical way the churches of Myzeqe were furnished during that period. The ceilings are ornamented with carved parts (rosettes), while the fields and columns have various coloured geometrical motifs. The iconostasis, pulpit, bishop's throne and other elements are made of carved stone with different floral motifs and religious symbols.*

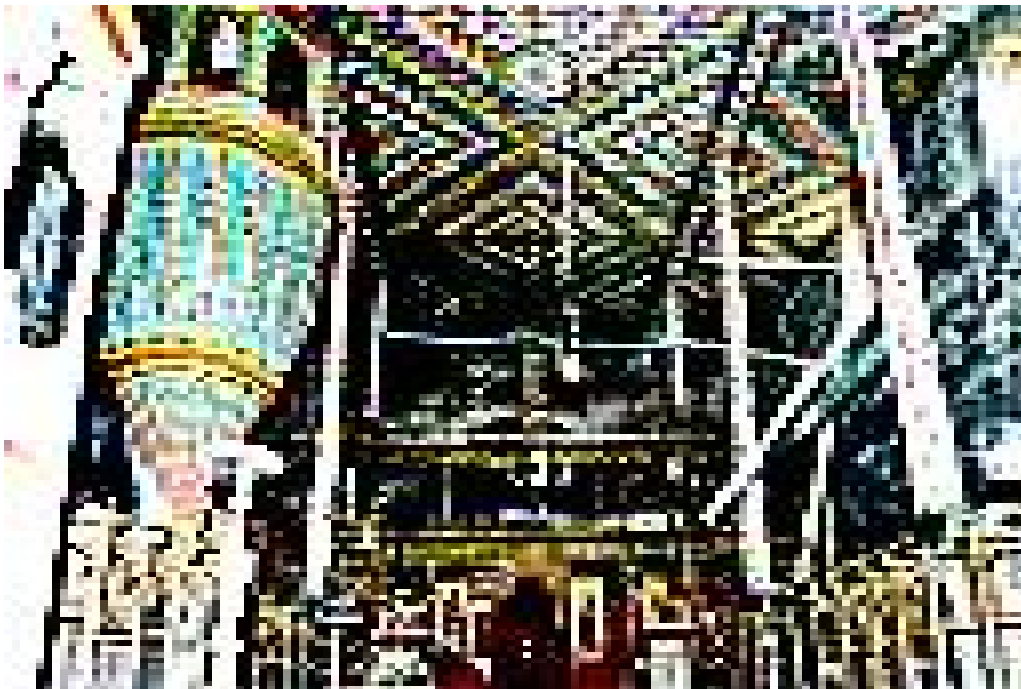
wooden ceilings. The iconostasis is made of carved wood and rests on the eastern pair of columns.

Of the closed galleries that surround the naos, the western part is wider and functions as the narthex. An open gallery is in front of it.

The tall belfry tower, which was built later, is in the centre of the western view.

In the exterior is a voluminous structure, gradually inclined. The prismatic volume of the naos, with a gabled roof, rises in the centre. Below are the low roofs of the galleries. On the west, an open gallery generates a feeling of ease, while the belfry tower creates a vertical emphasis.

The masonry of the church is built with pumice stones and is strong, while that of the gallery is fragile. The masonry of the gallery has a wooden framework and is filled with stones held together by a mud mortar. The apse, which is artistically designed with carved limestone blocks and ornamented with a blind arcade, stands out in the east. In different places throughout the masonry, ancient architectural or decorative fragments are placed on the walls. They are pre-



sumed to come from Apollonia and other ancient sites of that region.

According to the inscription, the church was built in 1776 and was painted in 1782 by the painters Kostandin and his son, Terpo, from the distinguished Korça family of the Zografi.

## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT

The damage to the building came about mainly as a result of its abandonment and the lack of maintenance. The roof suffered damage to its support structure and covering, leading to the penetration of rainwater into the church, harming the ceiling, masonry, and wall paintings. Moreover, the high level of the earth on the north, east, and south kept the masonry in continuous humidity and thus in conditions unfavourable to its longevity.

As for the constituent parts of the church, the belfry tower was not preserved, being ruined during the Communist religious persecution, as also happened with many other religious institutions.

## 3. RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

The restoration interventions were concentrated on consolidating the damaged structures, avoiding the external causes that had brought about the damage, and rebuilding the missing elements:

- Rebuilding the belfry tower, as a symbol not only of the church but also of the revival of religious faith, was considered as a proper intervention in this case. The rebuilding was implemented in accordance with the existing graphic and photographic documentation.
- The roofs of the naos and the galleries were rebuilt.
- The cornice was restored with stone slabs at the end of the masonry of the naos.



*View of the church after the restoration interventions.*



*View of the church after restoration.*

- The elevation of the earth was lowered in the north, east, and south. Concrete support walls were built to support the pressure of the earth at those places.
- The fragile masonry of the galleries was consolidated.
- The open western gallery was rebuilt.
- The floors of both the naos and of the galleries were rebuilt with brick.
- The decorative ceiling of the naos was conserved.
- The wall paintings underwent some conservation measures.
- The outdoor territory surrounding the church was arranged.
- Electrical and plumbing facilities were installed.

#### **4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA**

The restoration project was designed by the Institute of Monuments of Culture with R. Gega, arch., as the designer.

The restoration work was implemented by the Tirana Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by G. Samimi, eng.

The conservation work on the wall painting was performed by the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by S. Mihalçka.

The electrical and plumbing work was done by the ELIRA construction company, directed by S. Kola, eng.

The work was supervised by Father Theologos, architect and restorer, of the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

The work started in 1996 and finished in 1998.

**The total cost of the work reached the sum of 7,500,000 lekë (US\$ 75,000)**



## *VANAJ - FIER*

### **CHURCH OF ST. NICHOLAS**

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#### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The church stands on the top of a low hill, in the middle of a dense cypress forest. The inscription preserved over the south gate of the church displays the dates of the building and its paintings. The church was built in the year 1777 and was painted in 1795 by the brothers from Grabova, George and John, who practiced intensely in the Myzeqe region.

*View of the church from the west.*





*View of the church before restoration. The total abandonment both of the building and its surroundings can be observed.*

The church is of a type quite widespread in the Myzeqe region for the 18<sup>th</sup> and 19<sup>th</sup> centuries. It is composed of the naos and closed galleries that encircle it on three sides. The naos is a single nave basilica with a flat ceiling. A carved wooden iconostasis separates the sanctuary, which contains a large apse projecting out of the bema and two niches of the prothesis and the diaconicon.

The naos is surrounded on the north, south and west sides by closed galleries, of which the western part is wider and functions as the narthex. An empty space is set apart in it, where the baptismal font used to be. On the west, there is a low wooden belfry tower.

The inner decorative elements are wall paintings that fill the entire masonry plane, an iconostasis, a skilfully carved wooden pulpit, and a ceiling made of dyed wood.

Standing out in the exterior view is the volume of the naos, covered with a gabled roof, rising above the shed-roofed galleries.

The apse stands out in contrast to the poorly worked decorative elaboration of the exterior. The apse is built of sculptured stone blocks and features with a blind arcade. It also contains ancient reliefs, presumably taken from Apollonia of the Fier region.

## 2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT

The monument survived, but with serious damage to the roof and masonry structures, especially at the galleries. This subsequently led to the damage of decorative interior elements of both the wall paintings and the ceiling. This damage was a result of the abandonment of the building and the intense presence of humidity both from underground and from rainfall.

## 3. RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

The restoration interventions that were done primarily emphasized consolidating the structures and consisted of:

- Entirely rebuilding the roof.
- Rebuilding the walls of the galleries.
- Tamp pointing the masonry of the naos.
- Restoring the masonry of the apse.
- Restoring the ceiling of the naos.
- Slab flooring of the galleries.
- Outer arrangements and removal of earth from the masonry in the north, east, and south.
- Electrical installations.

## 4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA

The restoration work was implemented by the Tirana Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by G. Samimi, eng.,



a.



b.



c.

*Views of the church: a. before restoration, b, c. after restoration.*



The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

The work was done in 1998 and 1999.

**The value of the restoration work was 7,200,000 lekë (US\$ 72,000).**

*View of the interior of the church.*





## ZVËRNEC - VLORA

### MONASTERY OF THE DORMITION

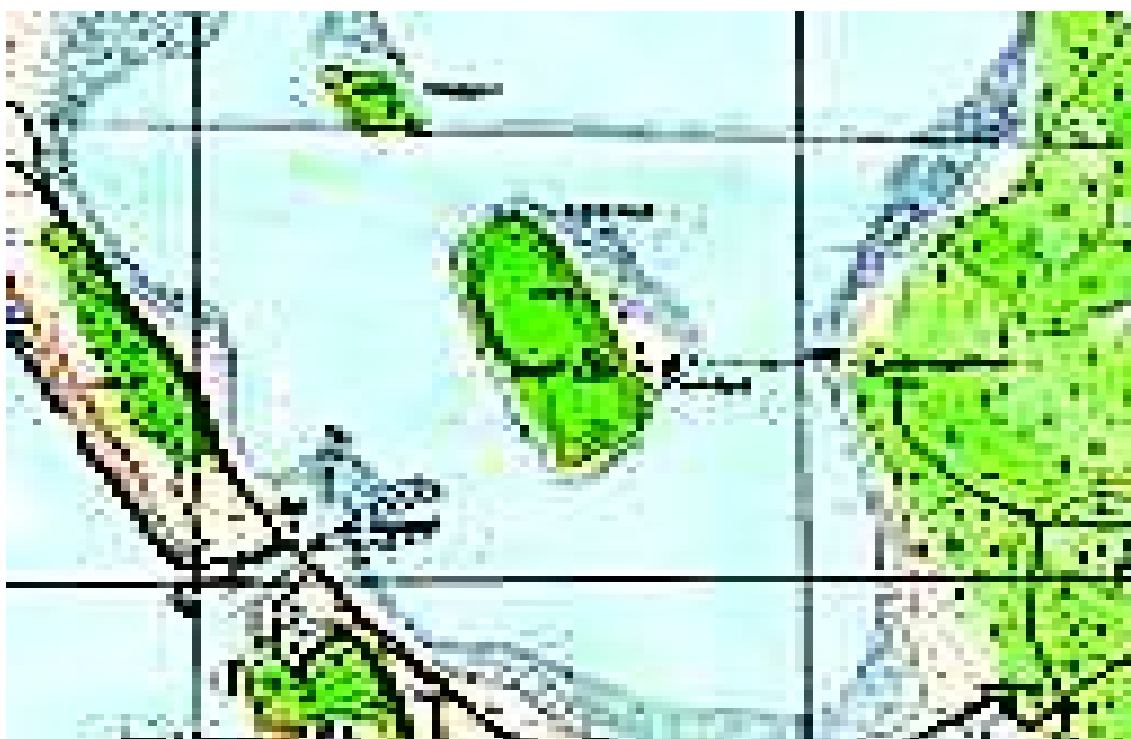
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#### 1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW

The monastery was erected on the island in Narta Lake, opposite the village of Zvërnec. The monastery complex is composed of the *katholikon* and guesthouses that surround it on the north, east and west.

The *katholikon* is composed of the naos, the narthex on the west side and the gallery on the north. The naos was built in the 13<sup>th</sup>-14<sup>th</sup> centu-

*Map of the island of Zvërnec.*





*Entrance to the monastery before and after construction of the bridge.*



a.



b. *Building of the monastery: a. before restoration, b. after restoration.*

ries and belongs to the free cruciform typology, with a cupola. The narthex and gallery were built in a second phase, in the 18<sup>th</sup> century.

The guesthouses of the monastery are gallery in type, which opened in the direction of the church.

## 2. RESTORATION INTERVENTIONS

Because of the long abandonment, the guesthouses had suffered severe damage and became uninhabitable. The purpose of the restoration was to rescue this important monument of culture by returning it to its initial function as a monastery. Meanwhile, since the function of the monastery would temporarily be that of summer camps for the youth, there would be some adaptation for this interim function.

The restoration work on the monastery of Zvrnec was the following:

### a. Subsidiary and infrastructure work:

- Building a pedestrian wooden bridge 240m (787.3 feet) in length, preserving traces of the old bridge.

- Installing supply lines for drinking water and electricity and construction of a road to the monastery.

### b. Restoration work on the guesthouses:

The buildings of the monastery were entirely reconstructed, the reconstruction work being as follows:

- Rebuilding of the roofs.
- Rebuilding of the galleries, preserving traces of the previous construction.
- Rebuilding of the wooden floors and the connecting staircases to the upper levels.
- Rebuilding of wooden and plaster ceilings.
- Installation of doors and windows.

- Internal and external plastering.
- Electrical and plumbing installations.

### 3. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA

The infrastructure work, that is, the bridge, water and electricity supply, the road and temporary constructions, kitchen and bathrooms, was implemented between 1997 and 1998 by the ARIS construction company, directed by A. Vera. The value of the work reached the sum of 12,600,000 lekë.

Reconstruction of one of the collapsed guesthouses was implemented in 1998 by the the Vlora Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by D. Nika, and reached the value of 1,800,000 lekë.

Reconstruction of the guesthouses of the monastery was implemented in the year 1999 by the ELIRA construction company, directed by S. Kola, eng. The value of the work amounted to 24,050,300 lekë.

The study and project for reconstruction of the monastery buildings was designed by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service, under the direction of Father Theologos, arch, restorer.

The work was supervised by the O.A.C.A's Office of Technical Service.

**The total value of the expenses incurred was 38,540,000 lekë (US\$ 385,400).**



a.



b.



c.

*Views of the guesthouse: a. before restoration, b. during restoration, c. after restoration.*





## *ZVËRNEC-VLORA*

# **MONASTERY CHURCH OF THE DORMITION OF THEOTOKOS**

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### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The church of the Dormition, the most valuable building of the monastery with the same name, rises on a small island in the marsh of Narta, opposite the village of Zvërnec. The extremely picturesque landscape and the tall cypresses that cover the entire low hill of the island also give value to the ambience of the monastery.

The church is one of the most important monuments of the Byzantine period and together with the church of Marmiroi constitutes the only examples of domed free cruciform type, known to date in Albania. It consists of the old naos, which belongs to the initial phase, and the narthex on the west and gallery in the north, which were both added in a later phase, during the 18<sup>th</sup>-19<sup>th</sup> century.

The naos contains several wall paintings, which are preserved in the sanctuary and partially in the cupola, which was not built at the same time as the church. Certain parts, especially the window casings, contain a substratum of the old painting. The iconostasis of the church, though not entirely preserved, gives evidence of high artistic quality.



*View of the church from the north-east, before restoration.*

The carved parts are in gold and beautifully displayed against the background, which is painted in dark red and deep blue.

## **2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT**

The monument survived, but was badly damaged. The deep corrosion in the masonry, caused by the saline atmosphere, had especially affected the binding mortar and the porous pumice stones

*View of the church from the north, after restoration.*



of which all the architectural-decorative elements of the exterior were built. This phenomenon is very obvious in the pumice columns of the gallery. As a result of it, the columns have taken on the shape of a clepsydra, with a dangerous thinning in the middle.

In addition to this damage, a considerable number of fissures were observed in the covering system, and to a lesser extent in the masonry.

### 3. RESTORATION WORK

The main objective of the restoration work was the consolidation of damaged structures, avoidance of the risk of corrosion and a reassessment of the different building phases, bringing to light and better clarifying the first phase of the Byzantine period.

The work of stripping the monument was implemented with the greatest care in order to discover any remaining traces of the initial phase. Consequently, many elements were discovered that brought the morphology of the old church to light. Thus, after the removal of the roof covering, the shape of the roof in the first phase, the original tiles of the covering and the manner of installa-



*View of the church from the south-east, before restoration.*



*View of the church from the south-east, after restoration.*

*General view of the monastery after restoration.*



*Traces of the initial cornice of the apse.*



*Rebuilding of the cornice of the apse based on the preserved traces.*



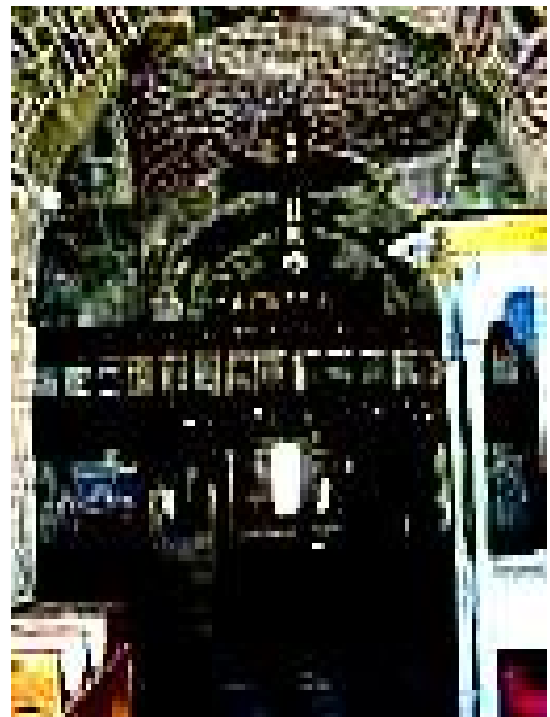
tion were discovered. The openings in the north and south arms of the cross revealed the spaces of the walled up gates, as well as the way they were opened. The excavations of the earth around the church revealed the base of the old church, thus showing its real height. The surveys in the masonry of the drum of cupola and apse revealed their initial technique.

The entire idea of the restoration interventions was based on preserving the traces and elements that had been discovered. The principal restoration work was concentrated on:

- Consolidation of the damaged structures, such as those of the vault of the narthex, by using a deep tamp pointing.



- Replacement of wooden braces that were out of function or had been cut.
- Consolidation of the masonry by removing the mortar that was decomposed because of corrosion and replacing it with new mortar more resistant to corrosion.
- Cleaning and infill of the masonry of the drum of the cupola and the apse.
- Rebuilding of the roof of the narthex and the gallery.
- Revival of the covering of the old church, preserving the same shape and technique by leaving as they were a considerable number of the original hollow tiles and completing the ridge tiles.
- Installation of doors and windows.
- Flooring of the narthex.
- Lowering the terrain around the building.
- Drainage of underground and surface water.



*View of the interior after restoration.*

*General view of the iconostasis after conservation interventions.*





*View of the wall painting in the sanctuary after the conservation interventions.*

- Saturating the entire surface of the masonry with a special solution that protects against dampness.

- Inner and outer lighting.

Work to conserve the works of art, the wall paintings and the iconostasis was implemented in parallel with the above work.

#### **4. TECHNICAL AND ECONOMIC DATA**

The restoration project was prepared by the Technical Service Office of the O.A.C.A, under the direction of Father Theologos, arch, restorer, with Prof. Dr. P. Thomo as scientific consultant.

The restoration work was implemented by the building company AD-STAR, directed by A. Çoma, eng., in collaboration with the Berat Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by A. Nallbani.

The restoration of the works of art was directed by Prof. Dr. H. Nallbani.

The work was supervised and scientifically directed by Prof. Dr. P. Thomo and J. (G.) Stratobërdha, arch.

The restoration work was implemented during 2003.

**The value of the work amounted to 15,930,746 lekë (US\$ 159,300).**



## *BALLSH-MALLAKASTËR*

### **BASILICA**

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#### **1. HISTORICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW**

The basilica is situated at the entrance of the town of Ballsh, about 100 m to the east of the road which leads to the oil production facility.

The ruins of the Basilica of Ballsh were almost completely discovered from archaeological excavations of 1975-1976. Architecturally, the church is of the three-aisled basilica type, with architectural and decorative features of early

*General view of the basilica of Ballsh.*





*Partial view of the surrounding wall of the archaeological area.*

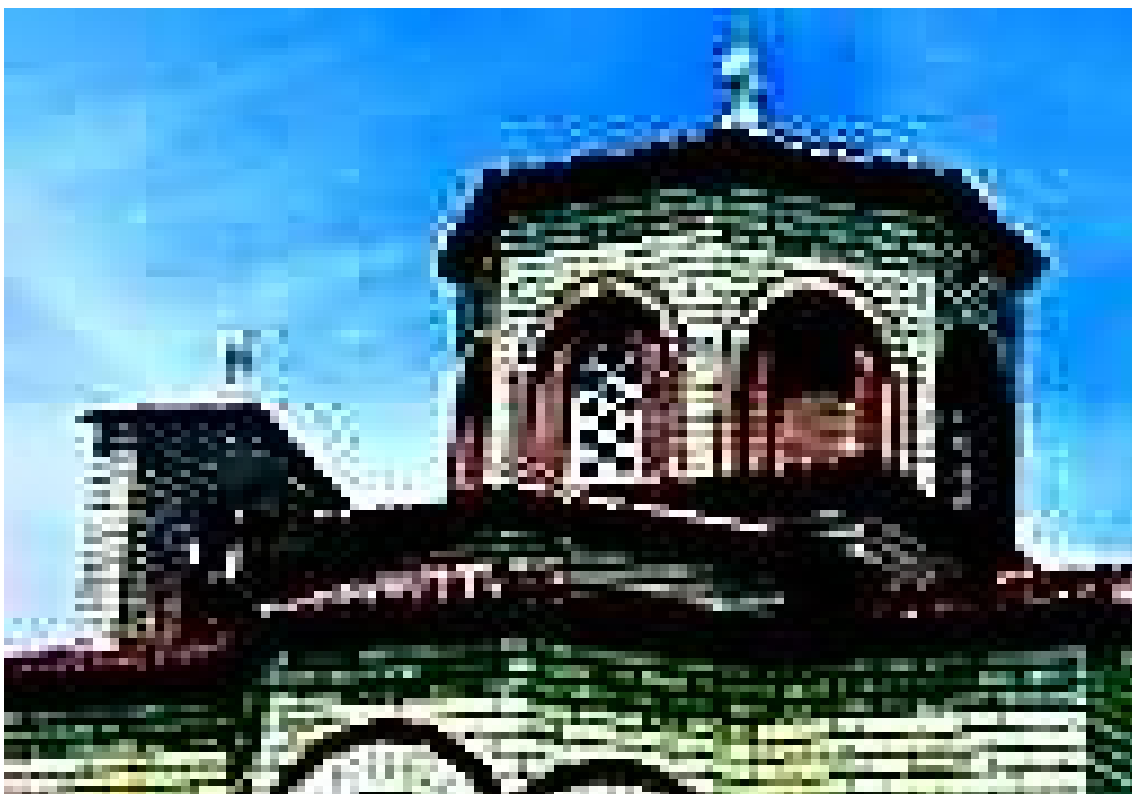


Christian basilicas. During the First World War, the Austrian archaeologist Praschniker discovered a stone pilaster there bearing an inscription about the conversion of Tsar Boris of Bulgaria and his people to Orthodox Christianity in the ninth century. Today, some scholars identify Ballsh with the ancient Glavenica, a well-known Episcopal centre.

## **2. CONDITION OF THE MONUMENT**

During the 1990s, because of the lack of care in the connection with the protection of the monuments of culture, the ruins of the basilica of Ballsh were among those left at the mercy of fate. The environment around these archaeological ruins was turned into a place for collecting garbage and waste, as a result of abandonment and unlicensed building near the monument. What was inherited from the ruins of the basilica gave the impression of a wasteland. But the message that these ruins transmit, the artistic values created with such skill by masters of the Christian belief, are still clearly preserved and constitute a treasure of the heritage of the culture and history of the Balkans in general.

Much damage has appeared in the ruins of the basilica in the last decade. The walls of the monument have been damaged, not only by the action of atmospheric agents and the loss of the binding capacity of the lime mortar, but also from mechanical interventions in the structure of the walls, the removal of stones and bricks from the masonry, and the breaking off of architectural and decorative fragments, all of which was created a very serious situation that if neglected would bring incalculable scientific and historical damage.



### 3. INTERVENTION FOR THE PROTECTION OF THE MONUMENT

*Partial views of the chapel.*

In order to avoid such a situation, the Orthodox Autocephalous Church of Albania in co-operation with the Institute of Monuments of Culture undertook a study project, which was divided into three phases.

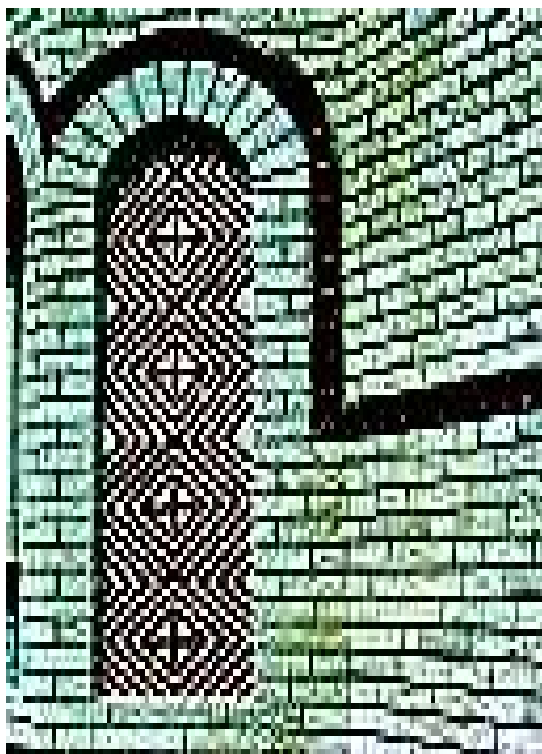
The first phase relates to enclosing the monument, in order to stop people and vehicles from passing through the territory of the basilica.

Both the second and third phases aim at making the monument a place that is easier to visit and integrating it into the cultural and spiritual life of the region. A small chapel has been built, in the service of this aim, on the north-eastern side of the ruins, more than about 15 m away, in an area where there are no archaeological remains. The work will also define the urban connection of the ruins with the city of Ballsh, since the traditional road has been closed.

The work for the enclosure of the basilica started in January 2002 and was completed in April

*Partial view from the east.*





*A fragment of the exterior ornamentation of the chapel.*

*Partial view of the interior of the chapel.*



of that year. During this work, it was observed that the layer of earth where the foundations were going to be built on the elevation foreseen in the project was unstable. According to these observations, the layer had come from added soil and was too loose, making it unsuitable for supporting the foundations. This required excavation up to the solid natural layer of the earth. In places, the digging went as deep as 3.40 m (11.1 feet) from the current floor of the basilica.

The foundations of the encircling wall were built with unworked stone material, lavishly mortared. The masonry on the rim of the foundation has been built with decorative concern, ending up with thick stone lid that adds visual weight and creates a strong base to support the decorative metallic railing. The railing reaches the height of 200 cm (78.7 inches).

The performance of this work returned the monument to its real values that it has for the history of Christianity in Albania and more widely in the Balkans.

#### 4. TECHNICAL AND FINANCIAL DATA

The project for the enclosure and for the chapel was drafted by the Institute of the Monuments of Culture, with the author Dr. G. Pani, architect, and consultant L. Papajani, archaeologist and restorer.

The work was supervised by the Department of Cultural Heritage within the Orthodox Autocephalous Church of Albania under Prof. Dr. P. Thomo and G. (John) Stratobërdha, architect and restorer.

The work was implemented by a construction company under the direction of G. Lame, engineer.

The work value for the enclosure reached **15,526,000 lekë, (US\$ 155,260).**



*View of the chapel from the east..*

*View of the chapel from the south-east.*







## RESTORATION AND RESCUE WORK

*In addition to all its restoration interventions, the Orthodox Autocephalous Church of Albania has also implemented a wide range of work in the nature of rescue and maintenance in churches whether or not considered “Monuments of Culture” but which have architectural, artistic and historical value and which await re-evaluation in the future. The purpose of these interventions has been to prevent damage that could lead to total or partial destruction of the buildings, thus extending their life pending more complete restoration interventions as well as the return to their initial functions.*

*Voskopoja according to an engraving dated 1742.*





## *VOSKOPOJA – KORÇA*

### CHURCHES OF VOSKOPOJA

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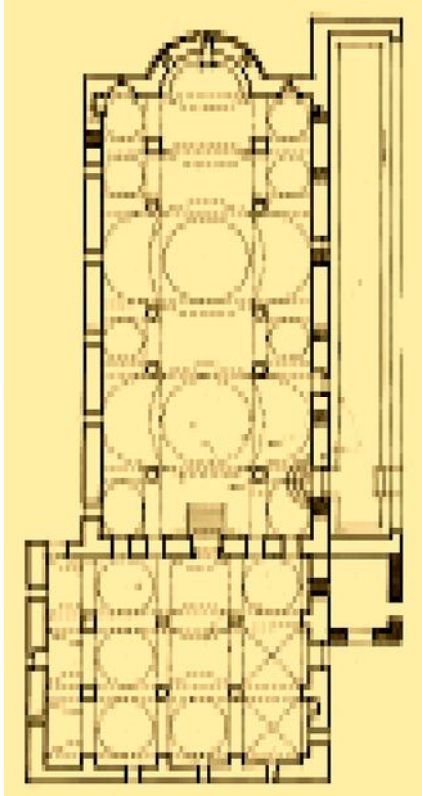
Built on a high plateau about 1,200 m (3,937 feet) above sea level in a naturally protected position, Voskopojë, originally only a place for shepherds, gradually progressed economically and culturally. Its flourishing culminated in the 18<sup>th</sup> century and it became one of the most important metropolises of the Balkans. According to some scholars, its population reached 60,000.

About 20 guild organizations operated in the city. Besides the production of daily consumer products, the people of Voskopojë were also noted for the production of luxury articles. But above all, Voskopojë was known for its trading activity. Caravans from Voskopojë regularly frequented the main centres of Epirus, Macedonia, Thessaly, and other places. With the increase of the city's economic power, the merchants of Voskopojë even established trade agencies in developed European centres such as Venice, Trieste, Ancona, and the cities of the Austro-Hungarian Empire.

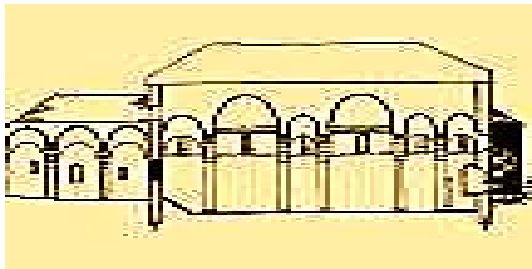
The city's cultural life was significantly developed as well. The two culminating achievements of the city during its highest period were a printing press and a high school. The printing press of Voskopojë, which started around the year 1730, was one of the very few that functioned during



*Belfry tower of the Church of the Dormition.*



*Plan of the Church of the Archangels.*



*Lengthwise section of the church.*

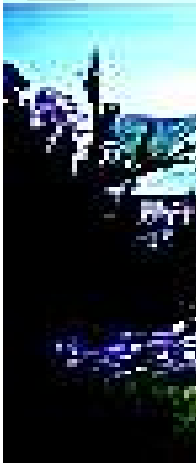
that period in the Balkans. The high school, opened in the year 1744, was known in the year 1750 as the “New Academy.” The founders and directors of the printing press and the high school were outstanding intellectuals of that time, and they introduced advanced systems into the school program. Among many others, we may mention Sevast Leontiadhi from Kosturi, who graduated from the University of Padova; Theodore Kavalioti, who was a teacher and a distinguished philosopher; and Grigor Voskopojari. At the “New Academy,” there was a rich library to which the outstanding figures of the time contributed, such as Gregory, the Metropolitan of Durrës, and the notable merchant from Voskopoja, George Sina.

This great economic and cultural development was also reflected in the construction field. Fragments of a road network, old water taps, and a great number of ruins show that an advanced urban system with superior infrastructure existed.

But those few things of value that managed to survive, and which show the cultural splendour and economic power of Voskopoja in the 18<sup>th</sup> century, are its churches, five grand basilicas and a monastery. They are the most valuable monuments erected in that period, of about 20 churches that functioned in the city.

The oldest preserved monument is the **monastery church of St. Prodomos**, which was built about 2 km north of the city. From the monastery complex, a few old constructions remain, while some are in ruins. The church, built in the year 1632 and painted in 1659, is a domed cross-in-square church with side choirs.

Gradually, construction activity increased until it culminates at the end of the 17<sup>th</sup> and the beginning of the 18<sup>th</sup> century. Four basilicas were built in a short period of time. In their size and especially in their plan type and spatial composi-





*Church of the Dormition before restoration.*



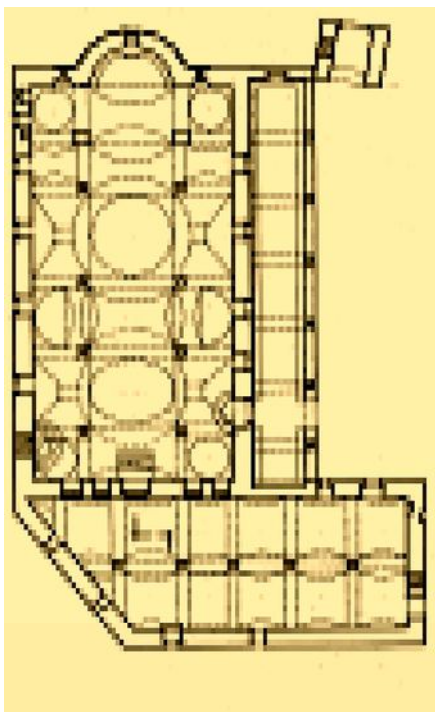
*Church of the Dormition before restoration.*



*Church of the Dormition after restoration.*

tion, these basilicas comprise the highest achievements of post-Byzantine architecture. The four basilicas are the following: (1) **the Church of the Dormition**, which is thought to have been finished, and painted by the painters from Agrapha, Theodhosi, Anagnost and Steriani, in the year 1712; (2) **the Church of St. Nicholas**, built between





*Plan of the Church of St. Nicholas.*



*Elevation view from the east of the Church of St. Nicholas.*

1721 and 1722 and painted in the year 1726 by the master painter David Selenica and his apprentices Constantine and Kristo, also containing paintings in the gallery by the brothers from Korça, Constantine and **Athanasius**, who painted them in the year 1750; (3) **the Church of the Archangels**, painted in the year 1722; (4) **the Church of St. Athanasius**, built in 1724 and painted in 1745 by the brothers from Korça, Constantine and **Athanasius**.

With regard to typology, these four churches belong to the same architectural type, a variant of the three-aisled basilica covered with a system of arches, vaults and spherical calottes. Compositionally, the basilicas have a naos, a narthex on the western side, and a gallery on the southern side. However, in the present situation, not all of the components are preserved in all of the churches.

In contrast to these basilicas, the fifth church, **Prophet Elijah**, belongs to another variant of the basilica type. It stands on the western outskirts of the city and was built in 1751. It is a three-aisled basilica covered with a flat ceiling, whose central nave is higher than the two lateral aisles.

Besides their outstanding architectural value, the basilicas of Voskopoja also stand out for the high artistic quality of the wall paintings that fill their interiors. They are also distinguished for other artefacts, such as iconostases, bishop's thrones, pulpits and *proskynetarions*, all of exceptional value in the field of applied arts.

Because of the absence of regular maintenance, these rare monuments suffered from serious damage. For this reason, funds were appropriated for emergency interventions in the two churches that were most in danger: the Church of the Dormition and the Church of the Archangels.

**The Church of the Dormition** is the largest basilica of the city, and it served as its cathedral. From the pictures and traces that remained, there is evidence that an entire complex existed there, including the building of the metropolitan's centre, the chapel of Anargyros, the chapel of St. Marena, and others. The monumental belfry tower, which was built in the year 1887 by the master builders Nicholas, Coli, and **Athanasius** Veria, rises in the entrance of the churchyard. Of the church buildings only the naos is preserved. The narthex was destroyed during World War II, and the gallery was destroyed by an earthquake in 1960.

A serious problem for this church was its roof, which was almost entirely destroyed. Indeed, part of it collapsed before the work started. The emergency work concentrated on a complete rebuilding of the roof.

The **Church of the Archangels** stands in the southwest quarter of the city. Here also a building complex stood, including the chapels of St. Spiridon and St. Varvara. Of the church buildings, the naos and narthex are entirely preserved but the gallery was destroyed by the earthquake of 1960.

The roof of this church also suffered severe damage. It was completely decayed. For this reason, the emergency work was primarily concentrated on rebuilding the whole roof.

#### **Technical and Financial Data**

The work was implemented in 1999 by the Korça Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, under the direction of K. Kallamata, arch.

The value of work on the Church of the Dormition was 2,184,098 lekë.

The value of the work on the Church of the Archangels amounted to 3,256,255 lekë.

**The total value of the work was 5,440,353 lekë (US\$ 54,400).**



a.

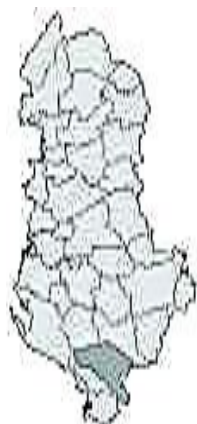


b.



c.

*Church of the Archangels: a., b. before restoration c. after restoration.*



## *GJIROKASTËR*

### **CHURCH OF THE ARCHANGELS**

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The church of the Archangels is situated in the quarter of Varosh. It was built in the year 1776 and rebuilt in 1883, following a fire in 1828. The church is a three-aisled basilica in type, covered with a vaulting system.

The sanctuary area, separated from the naos by an iconostasis made of carved wood, contains three projecting apses.

The masonry is of a high technical level, built with layered stones and contains numerous details in carved stones. Special decorative care has

*View of the church from the south-east, after restoration.*





been paid to the construction of the apses, which are enlivened with blind arcades and crowned with saw-tooth cornices. The roof is covered with slabs of stone.

The church had suffered severe damage as the result of its long abandonment and the aging of the materials, which made it unsuitable for performing the religious liturgy so needed by the city.

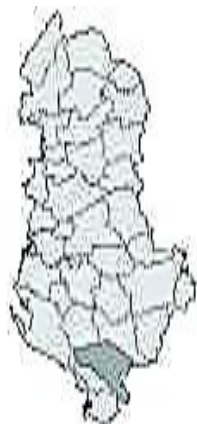
The restoration interventions concentrated on:

- Consolidating the construction.
- Completely rebuilding the roof.
- Furnishing and arranging the interior.
- Arranging the exterior.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë during 1992-1993 and reached the sum of **6,800,000 lekë (US\$ 68,000)**.

*View of the church from the south-west, after restoration.*





## *GJIROKASTËR*

### **CHURCH OF THE TRANSFIGURATION OF OUR LORD**

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*View of the church from the south-east, after restoration.*

The church was erected in the “Old Bazaar” quarter, at the foot of the city’s castle. It was built in 1784 and is a three-aisled basilica in type, covered with a barrel-vaulting system. In the naos, the columns are connected with lengthwise arcades, while transverse intersecting arcades support the eastern and western pair of the pillars, respectively dividing the sanctuary and the endonarthex.



The sanctuary, separated from the naos by an iconostasis made of carved wood, contains three projecting apses. The *endonarthex* is divided into two levels, thereby functioning as a *ginekonitti*. The upper level is entered through an external stone staircase on the northwest side, near the entrance portico to the naos.

The masonry is of a high technical level, built with layered stones and contains numerous details inserted with carved stones. Special decorative care has been paid to the construction of the apses, which are enlivened with blind arcades and crowned with saw-tooth cornices. The roof is covered with slabs of stone.

The church had suffered severe damage as the result of its long abandonment and the aging of the materials and was unsuitable for performing religious liturgy, which the city needed so much.

The restoration interventions concentrated on:

- Consolidating the construction by installing braces in the vaulting system.
- Rehabilitating the church interior so that the church could perform its initial function.
- External arrangement.
- Rebuilding the belfry tower in accordance with old photographs.

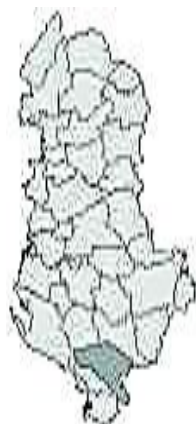
The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokaštër between 1993 and 1995 and cost a total of **3,200,000 lekë (US\$ 32,000)**.



*View of the interior of the church.*



*View of the church from the east, after restoration.*



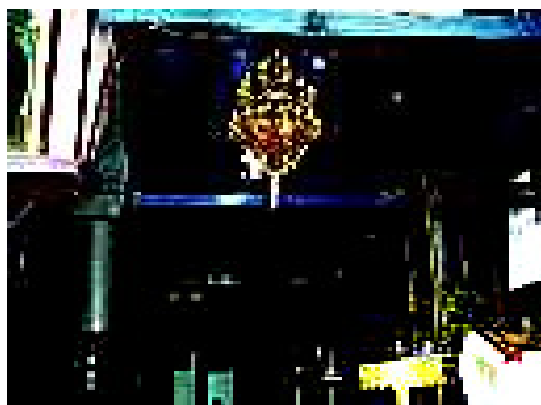
## *BULARAT-GJIROKASTËR*

### **CHURCH OF ST. ATHANASIUS**

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*View of the church from the south-west.*



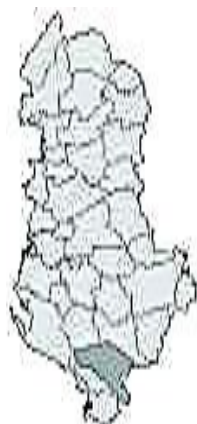
*View of the interior of the church.*

The church of St. Athanasius was built in the 18<sup>th</sup> century and is a three-aisled basilica in type. The interventions that were implemented were aimed at returning it to its initial function.

The interventions consisted of:

- Consolidating the construction by installing braces in the internal covering system.
- Re-covering the roof with stone slabs.
- Repairing the porticos in the western and southern entrances.
- Arrangement of the territory.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë between 1994 and 2002 and amounted to a value of **2,300,000 lekë (US\$ 23,000)**.



*RAHULLA – GJIROKASTËR*  
**CHURCH OF APOSTLE ANDREW**

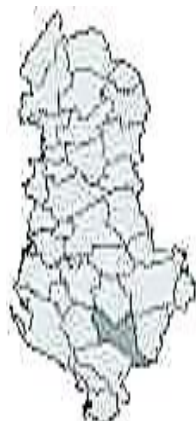
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The church of Apostle Andrew is a one-aisled church covered with wall paintings of a high artistic level. The church was completely exposed to destructive factors, thus endangering the works of art that had been preserved.

The rescue work consisted of:

- Completion and consolidation of the masonry,
- Binding the masonry with a hidden reinforced concrete tie-beam.
- Rebuilding the roof.
- Completion and restoration of the narthex and southern gallery.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë in 1995, at a value of **2,100,000 lekë (US\$ 21,200)**.



## *BODARI - PËRMETI*

### **CHURCH OF ST. NICHOLAS**

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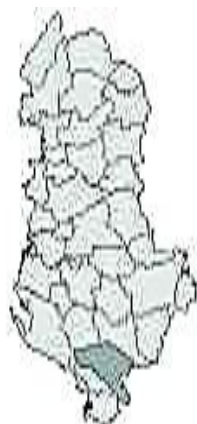
The church is the only building remaining from the monastery with the same name, which rose on a beautiful meadow opposite the city of Përmet, at the foot of the village of Bodar. The church is of interest because of its chronology, although there are no special architectural features distinguishing it.

In the sanctuary, both the wall paintings of *Platytera* in the apse of the bema and of the *Crucifixion* in the choir of the prothesis are preserved.

The work implemented includes:

- Entirely rebuilding the r.of,
- Completion of the wooden cling.ig,
- Entire reconstruction of the gallery, and especially of the three ruined arche. spaces,
- Completion of the iconosta.is,
- Repairing the wooden flo.r,
- Encircling a considerable surface of land that belongs to the monastery.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër between 1995 and 2000, with a value of **650,000 lekë (US\$ 6,500).**



## *NIVAN - GJIROKASTËR*

### CHURCH OF THE MOST HOLY THEOTOKOS

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The church of Theotokos, built in the 19<sup>th</sup> century, preserves architectural values that reveal the continuity of the typology of churches in that century as well as the novelties that appeared in building techniques of the time. The church is a three-aisled basilica, of huge dimensions, covered with a vaulting system. The church was entirely abandoned and exposed to atmospheric agents, and the serious damage that ensued would have led to its gradual destruction.

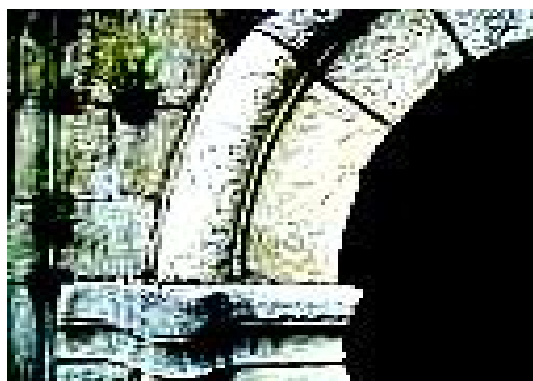
For this reason, some preservation measures were adopted, consisting of:

- Entirely rebuilding the roof and covering it with stone slabs,
- Mending the plaster,
- Installing doors and windows,
- Internal and external cleaning and arrangement.

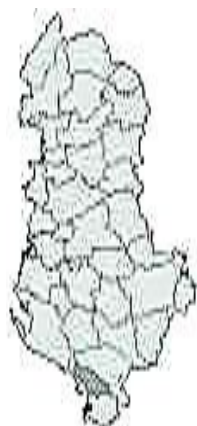
The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë in 1996 for a value of **730,000 lekë (US\$ 7,300)**.



*View of the church from the north-east.*



*A fragment from the decoration of the entrance vault.*



## *LOWER DHROVJAN - DELVINA*

### **CHURCH OF ST. NICHOLAS**

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*View of the church from the northeast.*



*A fragment from the wall painting of the church.*

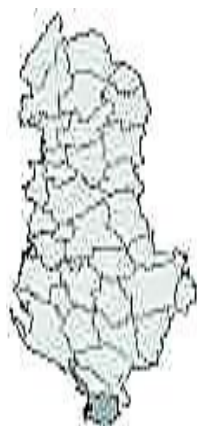
The church of St. Nicholas in the village of Lower Dhrovjan (Dhrovjan i Poshtëm) is one of the oldest churches remaining in this village, which was famous for its high economic and cultural development. The church, most probably built at the end of 17<sup>th</sup> century, is of the one-aisled type, with side apses, and is covered with barrel-vaulting, supported by transverse arches over pillars that project out from the masonry.

The church had been converted into a stable and underwent no maintenance, and it suffered severe damage endangering its survival. The work that was implemented aimed at rescuing this important monument from destruction, and consisted of:

- Rebuilding the roof and covering it with stone slabs.
- Rebuilding the southern gallery with stone columns and arcades.
- Interior and exterior arrangement and cleaning.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër between the years 1996 and 1997, with a value of **760,000 lekë (US\$ 7,600.)**





## *VOLLODER – SARANDA*

### **MONASTERY OF ST. GEORGE**

Situated by the side of the national road that connects the city of Saranda with the regions of the Seaside, the monastery is a monument with historical and architectural value. The buildings were almost ruined and the church was exposed to destructive factors. The roof was entirely missing, and the central cupola, some corners of the masonry and other elements had begun to fall into ruin.

At the same time, most of the paintings on the side walls and the wooden iconostasis had been saved, but in the central vault, the plaster, together with the works of art, had collapsed because of the moisture that had penetrated from the roof over time.

In the year 1996, the following interventions were implemented:

- Stitching the central cupola.
- Consolidating the corner of the masonry.
- Completely rebuilding the roof.
- Restoring and completing the floor with natural stone slabs.
- Installing doors and windows.

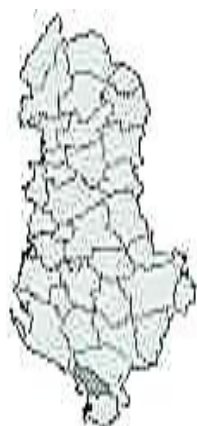
The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër with a value of **460,000 (US\$ 4,600)**



*View of the church from the southwest.*

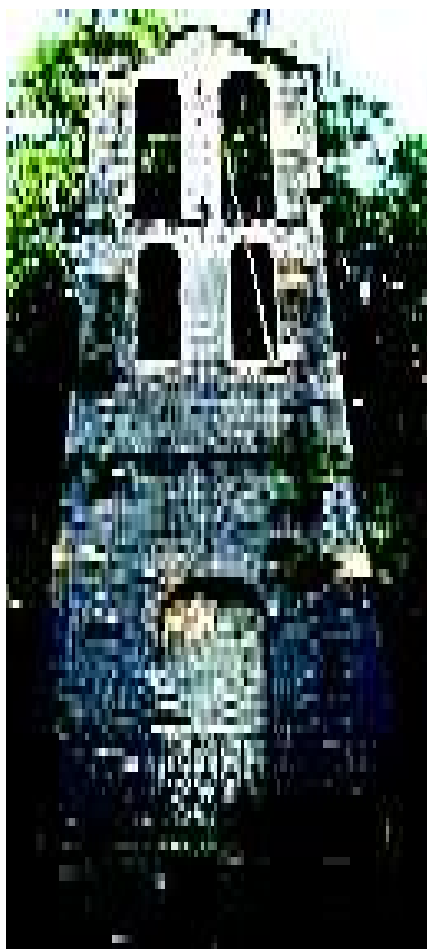


*View of the interior of the church.*



## *UPPER DHROVJAN – DELVINA*

### **CHURCH OF ST. NICHOLAS**



*View from the belfry tower of the church.*

The church of St. Nicholas is the largest church in this village. It was built at the culmination of the economic and cultural flourishing of the village, in the second half of the 18<sup>th</sup> century and the beginning of the 19<sup>th</sup> century. It stands in the middle of the village, in a square arranged with stone steps and support walls. The church is distinguished not only for its dimensions but also for its skilful architectural-decorative elaboration. The interior is ornamented with a decorative ceiling and a carved wooden iconostasis, which is considered to be one of the masterpieces of the applied arts.

Attempts to restore the old roof with black stone slabs failed. This failure resulted from the size of the roof, its low inclination and, in particular, the absence of professional master builders for this kind of work. Consequently, there was continuous leakage, which not only endangered the survival of the roof and the artistic values of the interior, but also did not create a pleasant liturgical environment.

For this reason, throughout 1998 the following work was implemented:

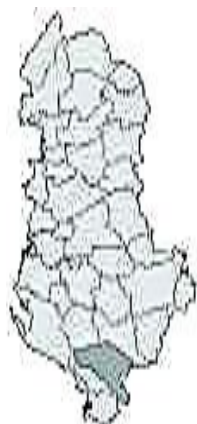
- Removing the old roof.

- Building a hidden reinforced concrete tie-beam.
- Rebuilding the roof and covering it with yellow Byzantine (archaeological) tiles, attached with mortar and on a hydro-isolating membrane.
- Restoring the interior plastering.
- Doing the cleaning necessary for the church to function and arrangement of the surrounding environment.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër with a value of **1,100,000 lekë (US\$ 11,000)**.

*View of the church from the northeast.*





*STEGOPUL-GJIROKASTËR*  
**MONASTERY CHURCH OF THE  
PROPHET ELIJAH**

---

The monastery rises at the entrance to the Gorge of Pogon in rough terrain, but not very far from the village of Stegopul. Of the monastery buildings, only the church is preserved, while the other buildings are in a deteriorated or ruined condition.

*View of the church from the south.* The church was built in 1624 and painted in the year 1653 by Constantine, son of the eminent painter Michael from Linotopi, together with



another painter called Nicholas. The church is made up of a naos and narthex. The naos belongs to the cross-in-square type with side choirs (athonite type). It has an extended shape in its plan, as a result of the inequality of the arms of the cross, with very narrow aisles. In the central part, a cupola rises over a high drum. The narthex is barrel-vaulted.

The arrangement of the interior is not reflected in the exterior views. The great height of the apses and their smooth union with the walls of the church makes the whole building to be conceived as a single volume. It consists of a curved line covered with a broad gable roof that intersects the volume of the drum only in the central part. The exterior of the church is plastered. The apses and the drum are enlivened by blind arcades, over which there are friezes with painted inscriptions.

The damage to the roof covering and its structure permitted the penetration of water from rainfall, damaging the structure of the vaults in the masonry and the wall paintings.

The work to rescue this monument concentrated mainly on the restoration of the roof:

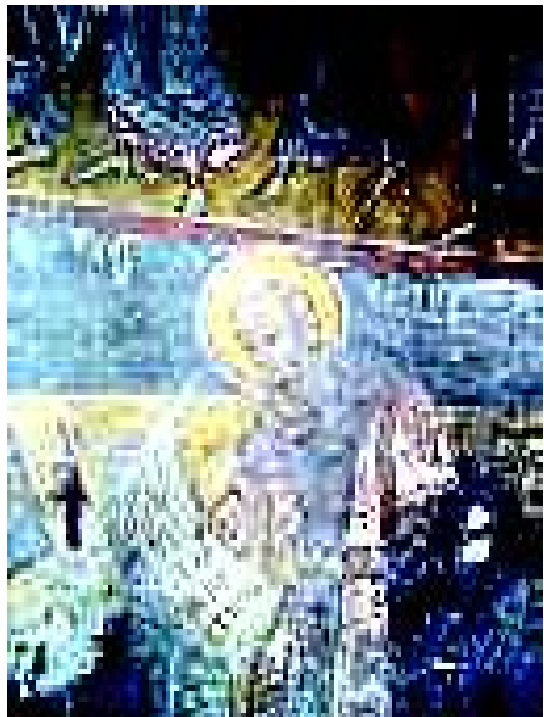
- Both the remaining covering of stone slabs and the existing decayed wooden frame were removed,
- The roof was rebuilt,
- The roof was re-covered with stone slabs over a waterproofing layer of bituminous paint,
- The masonry in the upper part of the narthex was consolidated.

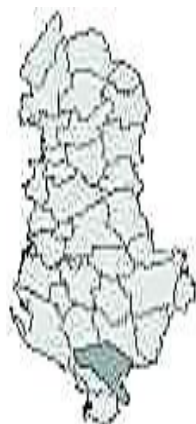
The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë during 1998, at a cost of **550,000 lekë (US\$ 5,500)**.



*View of the church from the north-east.*

*A fragment from the wall painting of the church.*





## *ERINDI – GJIROKASTËR*

### **CHURCH OF ST. NICHOLAS**

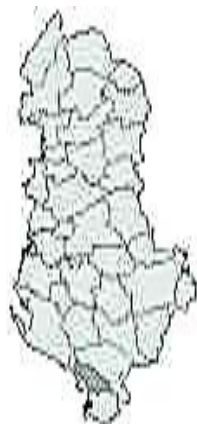
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The church was built in the year 1859 and is a three-aisled basilica in type, covered with a vaulting system. It is distinguished for rich architectural elaboration and a high building technique. During the Communist regime, the church was converted into a munitions warehouse, creating many new subdivisions in the church interior. The lack of maintenance would soon have caused its complete deterioration.

The work that was implemented succeeded in keeping the church from being destroyed, it regained its initial functions. This work consisted of:

- Removal of the interior subdivisions,
- Consolidation of the masonry and the system of the interior ceiling,
- Rebuilding the roof with stone slabs,
- Re-plastering.
- Installing doors and windows,
- Rebuilding the belfry tower.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë between 1998 and 1999, for **1,750,000 lekë (US\$ 17,500)**.



*PECA - DELVINA*

**CHURCH OF**

**“THE ENTRY OF THEOTOKOS”**

---

The church was built and painted in the year 1770 by John the priest and his sons from Iannina, with the contribution of the inhabitants of the village. It is a one-aisled basilica, covered with a barrel vaulting that was supported by transverse arches resting on the pillars of the masonry. The abandonment of the church had resulted in the collapse of the roof and the vaults of the interior ceiling as well as the ruin of the masonry. These damages had altered the original morphological features of the church and endangered the wall paintings that covered the masonry.

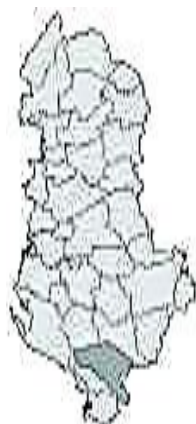
In order to rescue the rest of the church, the following work was implemented:

- Repairing the ruined masonry.
- Building a new roof, leaving visible the preserved parts and traces of the origin vaulting.
- Revetment of the wall painting.
- Installation of doors and windows.

The work was implemented in 1999 by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokaštër, with a value of **1,640,000 lekë (US\$ 16,400.)**



*View of the church from the south.*



*MINGUL - GJIROKASTËR*  
**CHURCH OF THE ARCHANGEL  
MICHAEL**

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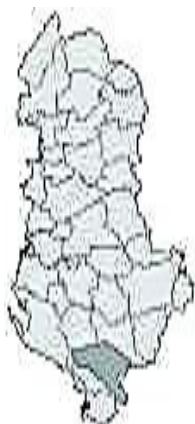
The church, which has historical and architectural value, was entirely exposed to atmospheric agents. Because of breaks in the beams, a large number of openings were created, which permitted rainfall to penetrate into the cupola and the vaults, causing damage to them and in particular to the wall paintings. The roof of the gallery was almost completely ruined. The elevated wall of the belfry tower was detached from the western masonry of the church and was in danger of collapse.

In the year 1999, rescue work was implemented on this monument, specifically:

- The roof was rebuilt with a cover of black stone slabs, this being characteristic of the area.
- The masonry of the gallery was restored and covered with a new wooden roof.
- The church was cleaned and arranged inside in order to permit it to function.
- The earth on the side of the apse and along the northern masonry, which caused humidity and damage to the wall paintings, was removed.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë in the year 1999, for a value of **450,000 lekë (US\$ 4,500)**.





*LABOVA E MADHE E ZHAPËS -*  
*GJIROKASTËR*  
**CHURCH OF “THE ENTRY OF OUR LORD  
INTO THE TEMPLE”**

---

Unfortunately, the grand church in the birthplace of the great philanthropists, the brothers Zhapa, could not escape from the ruin. Only a small part on the east was saved, while the rest, including the gallery on the south, was destroyed. On the western side, a new building was added and used as a store. In the yard, the monumental grave of the Zhapa family disappeared, and a new building, used as a coffeehouse, was constructed.

Under these circumstances, survey work was conducted and the ruins were dug up in order to determine the plan of the old church. A project was prepared for conservation of the parts that remained and for reconstruction of the church. The existence of the new buildings has so far impeded the realization of the project.

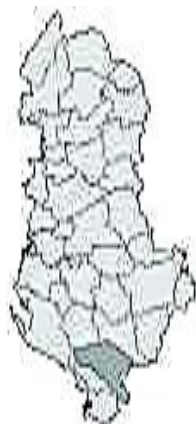
The excavation and survey work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë throughout the year 2001 and reached the sum of **450,000 lekë (US\$ 4,500.)**



*Ruins of the Church of “The Entry  
of Our Lord in the Temple”.*



*Residences of the Zhapa family*



*HOSHTEVA-GJIROKASTËR*  
**CHURCH OF THE APOSTLES PETER  
AND PAUL**

---

Hoshteva is the last village in the region of Zagoria. The village rises in rough mountainous terrain, with limited possibilities of communication with motor vehicles. However, it preserves a church with outstanding architectural and artistic values.

*View of the church from the north-east.*

The church is a basilica in type, of the variant that is covered with a vaulting system. On the northern side, an open gallery is developed on the



front, with an arcade of stone columns, while the northeast corner holds the belfry tower, octagonal in plan.

The interior of the church is covered with wall paintings of a high artistic quality, which have been preserved in good condition.

In this church, the Archbishop Anastasios performed the Holy Liturgy in 1999, on the day of the celebration of the Apostles.

The rescue work in the church consisted of:

- Renovation of the covering of the roof with black stone slabs.
- Restoration of the gallery: masonry, columns and roof.
- Cleaning the interior.
- Restoration of the masonry of the belfry tower, as well as covering it.
- Repair and in-fill of the encircling walls of the courtyard.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër in the year 2000, at a cost of **560,000 lekë (US\$ 5,600)**



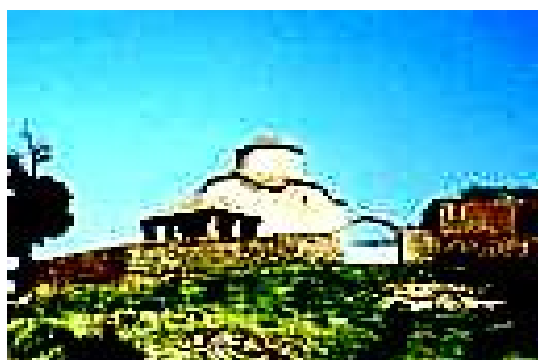
*View of the interior of the church.*



## VRINA - SARANDA

### MONASTERY CHURCH OF THE PROPHET ELIJAH

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*General view of the monastery  
after restoration.*



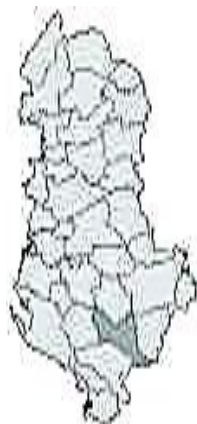
*View of the church from the northwest.*

The church of the Prophet Elijah rises on the top of a low hill opposite the ancient site of Butrint. The church is of the one-aisled type, of the variant that has a central core covered with a dome over a high drum. With regard to typology, it may be attributed to the 17<sup>th</sup> century. It bears a resemblance to the monastery church of St. George near the village of Xara and the monastery church of St. Nicholas in the village Dhivër of Theologos.

The church was completely abandoned and exposed to human and natural dangers. The restoration interventions consisted of:

- Reconstruction of the roof and its ceiling with stone slabs.
- Rebuilding the gallery on the western side in accordance with the traces that had been preserved.
- Repair and completion of the church floor with stone slabs.
- Internal plastering, since the wall paintings were missing.
- Enclosure of the territory of the monastery and planting it with olive trees.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër in 2001 for a value of **1,630,000 lekë (US\$ 16,300)**.



## *BUHAL - PËRMETI*

### **CHURCH OF THE PROPHET ELIJAH**

---

The church of the Prophet Elijah has several special historical values. It bears clear building traces that belong to the 12<sup>th</sup> century, and it contains wall paintings of great artistic value. The abandonment of the church had led to the destruction of the roof, which inevitably would have led to the destruction both of the entire building and of the wall paintings.

The emergency work implemented in this monument was:

- Consolidation of the masonry with a hidden reinforced concrete tie-beam.
- Entire rebuilding of the roof.
- Interior arrangements and repair.

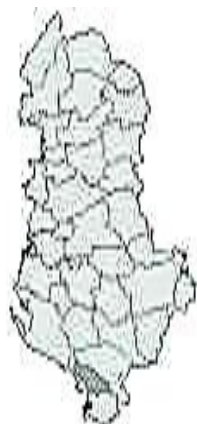
The work was done by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër in 2001 at a cost of **720,000 lekë (US\$ 7,200)**.



*View of the church from the north.*



*Old traces on the eastern wall of the church.*



## *KARDHIKAQ - DELVINA*

### **CHURCH OF ST. GEORGE**

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*View of the church from the southwest.*



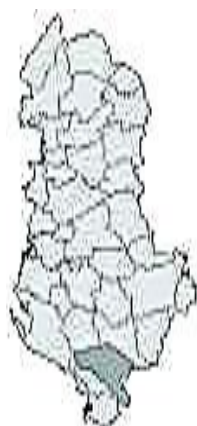
*Situation of the wall painting before restoration.*

The church had been used as a stable, since it was situated outside the village. The abandonment of the church had caused the destruction of the roof and the collapse of walls, thereby exposing the artistically valuable wall paintings to atmospheric agents.

The work that was implemented aimed at returning the church to its functions and assuring the preservation of the wall painting. This work consisted of:

- Repair and completion of damaged masonry.
- Consolidation of the masonry with a reinforced concrete tie-beam.
- Rebuilding the roof.
- Restoration and completion of the floor.
- Interior and exterior plastering.
- Rebuilding of the belfry tower.
- Installation of doors and windows.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër in 2001, for the cost of **2,400,000 lekë (US\$ 24,000.)**



## *TËRBUQI – GJIROKASTËR* **CHURCH OF ST. DEMETRIUS**

After a fire in 1990, while the church was being used as a warehouse of the Agricultural Enterprise, only a few elements were saved. However, these few remaining elements, columns and arches of the southern gallery, testify to the church's rich architectural and ornamental treatment.

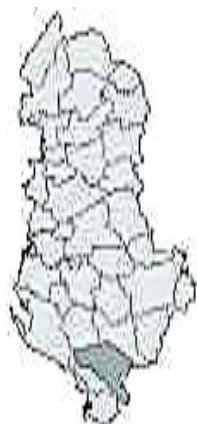
The work that was implemented aimed at the rehabilitation of the church while preserving the original traces and at returning it to its initial function. The work consisted of:

- Consolidation of the masonry.
- Rebuilding the ceilings.
- Flooring.
- Completion and restoration of the gallery.
- Rebuilding the belfry tower.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë in 2001, for **2,800,000 lekë (US\$ 28,000)**.



*View of the church from the south-east.*



## *GORANXI-GJIROKASTËR*

### CHURCH OF ST. ATHANASIUS

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*View of the church from the south.*



*A fragment from the wall painting of the church.*

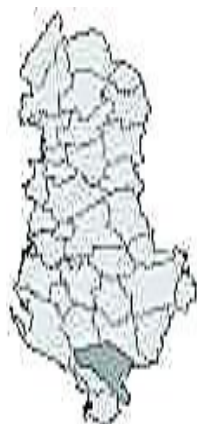
The church of St. Athanasius had been within a military unit and was used as a munitions depot, thereby taking away its initial appearance completely. On the south side, an addition made of brick and concrete slabs had been built, and the apse of the church had been totally destroyed. After the military unit left, the church was completely abandoned. It had suffered severe damages both to the roofing and to the wall paintings, which were of special artistic and historical value.

The restoration work consisted of:

- Removal of the layers that had been added later.
- Consolidation of the vault of the inner cover.
- Building a hidden reinforced concrete tie-beam.
- Rebuilding the roof covered with stone slabs.
- Rebuilding the apse.
- Repair of the floor.
- Installation of doors and windows.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastrë in 2002 and had a value of **480,000 lekë (US\$ 4,800)**.





## *SHEPER - GJIROKASTËR*

### **CHURCH OF ST. PARASCEVY**

The church was built in the centre of the village, and together with other buildings of a social nature, it made up the compositional centre of the village. According to an inscription carved over the north gate, the church was built in the month of June 1841.

With its dimensions and its architectural-decorative elaboration, the church is an imposing structure, displaying architectural and structural values that reveal the continuity and richness of the tradition of church building throughout the 19<sup>th</sup> century. The naos is of the three-aisled basilica type, covered with a vaulting system. The church is the only religious building in the village, which, although having at present a small number of families, used to be one of the biggest villages, with great culture and with an exceptional church tradition. Thus, the destruction of the church would have brought an incalculable loss both to the supply of material culture and to the spiritual life of the village.

During the Communist regime, the church was converted into the warehouse of the local cooperative. Because of the long abandonment and the absence of maintenance, it had suffered so



*View of the church before restoration.*



*View of the church after restoration.*



*View of the interior of the church before restoration.*



*View of the church from the northeast, after restoration.*

much damage that a catastrophic situation resulted.

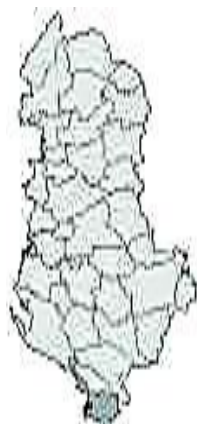
The roof was entirely destroyed, leaving all construction, masonry, arches and spherical calottes exposed to atmospheric agents. In addition, the rusting or decaying of the metal braces had led to a disequilibrium of the structural system and to the free action of the horizontal thrusts, resulting in the creation of inclinations of the masonry and the columns, as well as numerous fissures in the arches and spherical calottes.

With regard to the typology, the collapse of the gallery on the southern side had caused damage. The plastering had also come down, and the doors and windows were destroyed.

To rescue this important monument from additional damage, the following emergency interventions were undertaken:

- Shoring of the arches and spherical calottes that contained the most fissures.
- Shoring of the circular column on the southeast, which was the one most inclined.
- Easing the load on the damaged superstructure by removing the ceiling stones and the in-fill underneath.
- Rebuilding the roof and covering it.
- Consolidation of the masonry of the narthex by rebuilding the parts that had collapsed and performing hydro-isolation of the end of the masonry with stone slabs, after removal of the roof.
- Installation of doors and windows.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër in 2002 and 2003, at a cost of **1,300,000 lekë (US\$ 13,000)**.



*ÇUKA - SARANDA*  
**MONASTERY CHURCH  
OF ST. GEORGE**

---

The Monastery of St. George, otherwise known as the monastery of Dema, commands the height of a hill that rises in a narrow strip of land dividing the Ionian Sea from the Lake of Butrint. The monastery is encircled by a high wall and has fortified features. Several half-ruined buildings and the church, whose narthex is uncovered, have remained from the monastery complex.

The monastery church is one of the instances containing the greatest post-Byzantine architectural values, both as to its typology and its structural solution. The church is one-aisled in type, with a central core covered by a dome on a high drum. The typology suggests that it belongs to the 17<sup>th</sup> century.

The efforts made by the restoration department of the Institute of Monuments for restoration of the roofing with stone slabs were unsuccessful. The slabs used were unsuitable, and unqualified master builders implemented the work. This overloaded the structure and led to a loss of aesthetic value. For this reason, restoration work was conducted, consisting of:

- Re-covering the roof of the naos.
- Consolidation of the masonry of the



*View of the church from the southwest, before restoration.*

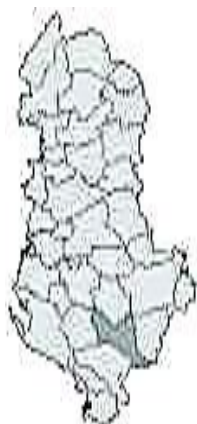
narthex with a hidden reinforced concrete tie-beam.

- Rebuilding the roof of the narthex.
- Restoration and completion of the floor of the naos with stone slabs.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokaštër in 2002 for **635,000 lekë (US\$ 6,350)**.

*View of the church from the south-west, after restoration.*





*OGDUNAJ – PËRMETI*  
**CHURCH OF THE DORMITION OF  
THEOTOKOS**

---

Ogdunaj, a small village made up of no more than 25 families in the area of Bënjë, preserves a church of architectural value that was built in 1744. It is a church of the three-aisled basilica type, covered with a vaulting system. A park containing centuries-old cypress trees surrounds the church.

The church had been left to the mercy of fate. Its roof was completely destroyed and because of this, the domes and vaults had begun to fall into total ruin. At the same time, the narthex or chamber for the women, which belongs to a later phase of building, had been completely destroyed.

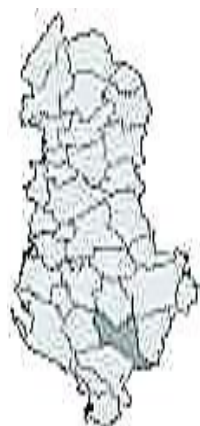
During the interventions between the years 1995 and 1996 the following work was implemented:

- The system of the interior roofing was completely cleaned from the ruins of the roof and infill underneath.
- The vaults of the roofing were consolidated from the damage they had incurred.
- The roof was rebuilt with a wooden construction that rested on the side walls and inner arcades. It was covered with black stone slabs,

this being a feature of the area.

- The entire floor was paved with natural stone slabs.
- The interior plastering was restored.
- Doors and windows were installed.
- The post office building was separated with a stone wall on the western side where it adjoins the addition to the narthex, and thus the church was made functional.
- The surrounding environment was also cleaned and arranged.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokaštër between 1995 and 1996 for a value of **650,000 lekë (US\$ 6,500)**.



### *BENJA – PËRMETI*

## **CHURCH OF “THE ENTRY OF THEOTOKOS IN THE TEMPLE”**

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This is a miracle-working church, and its calendar feast on the 21<sup>st</sup> of November has turned into a true pilgrimage of believers from the whole country, especially from the areas of Përmet, Kolonja and Korça, as well as inhabitants from the village who are in Tirana and elsewhere. There are also excursions in all periods of the year.

The monument had suffered a considerable number of fissures in its southern masonry, where the portico gallery is also situated. This damage is perhaps the result of landslides caused by the immediate steepness of the bank of the stream over which it was built.

Throughout the year 2002, the following rescue interventions were implemented:

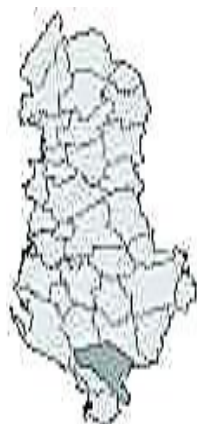
- The purchase and subsequent destruction of a coffeehouse built in the years of Communist persecution. This building had entirely occupied the churchyard and the entrance on the east, completely hiding the grandness of the apse.
- With the material obtained from destroying the coffeehouse, the encircling walls of the church were rebuilt and functional terraced levels were created.
- The entire roof was repaired, while a com-

pletely new roof was built over the parts of the gallery and the seating area that had been created as an extension to it.

- The road of 4 km was considerably rehabilitated. This road connects the church of Benja with the national road Përmeti - Tre Urat (Three Bridges.)

The above work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër and reached the value of **700,000 lekë (US\$ 7,000).**





## *GORANXI-GJIROKASTËR* **MONASTERY OF THE DORMITION OF THEOTOKOS**

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The monastery is situated about 4 km above the village of Goranxi in the region of Dropull, at a height of 650 m (2000 feet) above sea level. The monastery is more widely known as the monastery of Ravenja, and its church is dedicated to “The Dormition of the Most Holy Theotokos.” The church and some of the buildings around it survived from the monastery, in a deteriorated condition.

The church, which dates from the year 1600, displays specific features in exterior architectural

*View of the monastery church from  
the northeast.*



and decorative detailing, quite interesting for the study of post-Byzantine architecture. It is composed of a naos and a narthex and exonarthex that are attached to the naos on the western side. The naos belongs to the cross-in-square type with side choirs (athonite type). The narthex and exonarthex are covered with a vaulting system and spherical calottes. The belfry tower rises above the western pediment of the narthex.

A feature of the exterior architectural detailing is the decoration of the apses and drum with a range of elegant stone arches, which create a range of sharp arches by intersecting one another. The arcade is enlivened even more by carvings in high relief of anthropomorphic and zoomorphic figures. This is a special decoration that is not found in any other monument of the region in the entire post-Byzantine period, which has led scholars to speak of western influences in this church.

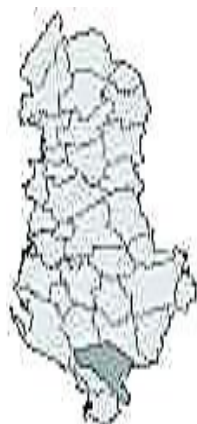
Although in bad condition, the guesthouses of the monastery also give evidence of rich architecture. There has been serious damage to the covering of the church.

In order to overcome this situation, the principal intervention was to build a road to the monastery, 4 km in length and costing 2,700,000 lekë. The road made it possible to visit the monastery able and at the same time facilitated the transportation of materials for restoration work.

Following this, the work concentrated on:

- Restoring the roof of the church.
- Shoring of the structure of the roof of the guesthouses and elimination of leakage.
- Restoring the entrance gate of the monastery.
- Installing church windows.

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër during 2002 and 2003 for **3,250,000 lekë (US\$ 32,500)**.



*DHUVJAN-GJIROKASTËR*  
**MONASTERY OF THE DORMITION  
OF THEOTOKOS**

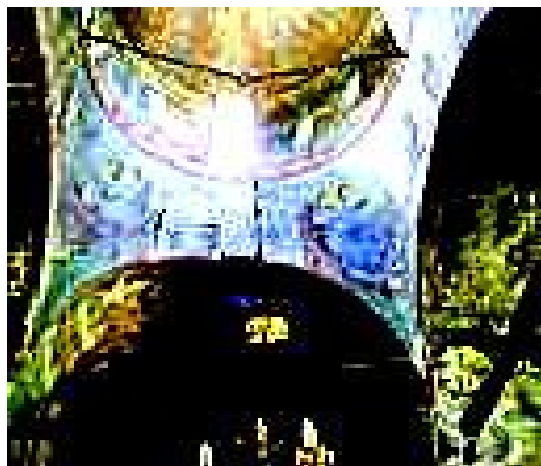
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Dhuvjan is situated in the middle of the Valley of Drino, 2.5 km from the motorway that goes from Kakavia to Gjirokastrë. The monastery rises at the far end of the village and is one of the most interesting monasteries of the region of Dropull.

The monastery is often also called “of Saints Julita

*View of the monastery church.*





*View of the interior of the monastery church.*

and Cyriacus,” because the sanctified remains of St. Julita were preserved there for a long time.

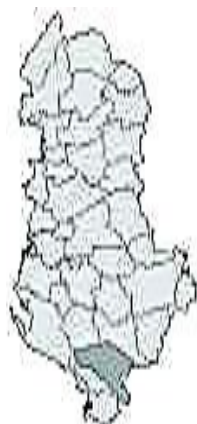
The monastery is composed of the church and the guesthouses that encircle it on all sides, giving it a very condensed composition.

The church is preserved relatively well, while the guesthouses are ruined or half ruined. Their destruction occurred in recent years, as a result of the lack of maintenance and total abandonment. But the documentation and the few preserved elements give evidence of a rich and special architecture.

The monastery church, built in 1588, belongs to the composite variant of the cross-in-square type. The narthex is attached on the western side and is covered with a vaulting system, while the exonarthex, covered with a wooden roof, belongs to a later phase. The belfry tower rises at the northwest corner of the church, in the shape of a massive stone wall. The interior of the church is completely covered with wall paintings.

An important measure for rehabilitating the monastery and making it possible to be visited was the building of a road leading to the monastery. In addition, work was done to uncover the contours of the existing buildings and to clean the courtyard area

The work was implemented by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër during 2003, at a cost of **4,550,000 lekë (US\$ 45,500)**.



## *DERVIÇAN – GJIROKASTËR* **MONASTERY OF THE ARCHANGELS**

---

The monastery rises on the high plateau of Mali i Gjerë (Wide Mountain) above the village of Dervičan, like all the other monasteries of Dropull. It is a new building, compared to the other monastic buildings of this valley. However, it is of value, because it testifies to the progress of development and the typological variety of the monastic buildings of post-Byzantine architecture.

*View of the monastery church from the south.*





*View of the monastery church from the northeast.*



*View of the interior of the monastery church.*

The monastery complex consists of the church and the guesthouses that surround it, primarily on the eastern and western sides. Of these buildings, the church is preserved relatively well, while the guesthouses are in a ruined condition.

In its interior spatial arrangement, the monastery church conforms to the criteria of the cross-in-square type, with side choirs. But this structure is not reflected in the exterior view, where the cupola is not elevated above the drum, thus permitting a view of the basilica buildings.

The two-storey narthex contains the belfry tower, which rises above the pediment of the western wall.

The building technique is of good quality, and the complex is enlivened by decorative elements carved in stone.

As a result of earth movement on the northern part, there were fissures in the arches of the western arcade, in the part of the arcade in front of the bema, in the vault of the prothesis and elsewhere.

The work that was done consisted of:

- Building a road to the monastery 2 km in length.
- Shoring the damaged arcades.
- Cleaning the courtyard from wild vegetation and the remains of the ruins.
- Removal of the roof and cleaning the structure of the inner covering.
- Temporary consolidation from above of the structure of the inner covering.
- Rebuilding the structure of the wood of the roof.
- Re-covering the roof with stone slabs.

The work was done by the Archbishopric Technical Office of Gjirokastër between 2001 and 2003, at a cost of **2,350,000 lekë (US\$ 23,500)**.



## *KARAVASTA - LUSHNJE*

### **CHURCH OF ST. ATHANASIUS**

The church of St. Athanasius was built in the year 1778 and painted in 1797 by the painters of the Katro (Çetiri) family from Grabova, George and John.

The church is composed of the naos and closed galleries, which were built in a later phase and enclose it on three sides. The naos is of the three-aisled basilica in type, with a flat ceiling. Two arcades divide the naves from one another, with the central nave being higher than the two lateral aisles. Each has its own separate wooden ceiling. A carved wooden iconostasis divides the sanctuary that contains the central apse, projecting out from the bema. The belfry tower is elevated over the pediment of the west wall of the naos.

Of the galleries that surround the naos, the western part is the widest. An alcove now stands apart in the place where the baptismal font used to be.

In the exterior, there is a hierarchy of volumes: the central nave, which is gable-roofed, dominates the lower shed roofs of the aisle naves, which in turn dominate the even lower volumes of the galleries.

The exterior of the church has been plastered.



*View of the church from the south,  
before restoration.*

Thus, the stone masonry of the naos and the brick of the galleries are hidden. The apse has been left without plaster; it was built with stone block cladding and is ornamented with a shallow blind arcade.

A long time elapsed from the abandonment of the church, and consequently serious damage occurred. For this reason, rescue measures were adopted, of which the most important ones were the entire rebuilding of the roofs of the naos and the galleries, as well as displacement and removal of the earth around the church to avoid damage from humidity.

The work was implemented in 1999 by the Tirana Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by G. Samimi, eng., in collaboration with the ELIRA construction company, directed by S. Kola, eng.

**The work reached a value of 5,482,840 lekë (US\$ 54,830).**

*View of the church from the south,  
after restoration interventions.*







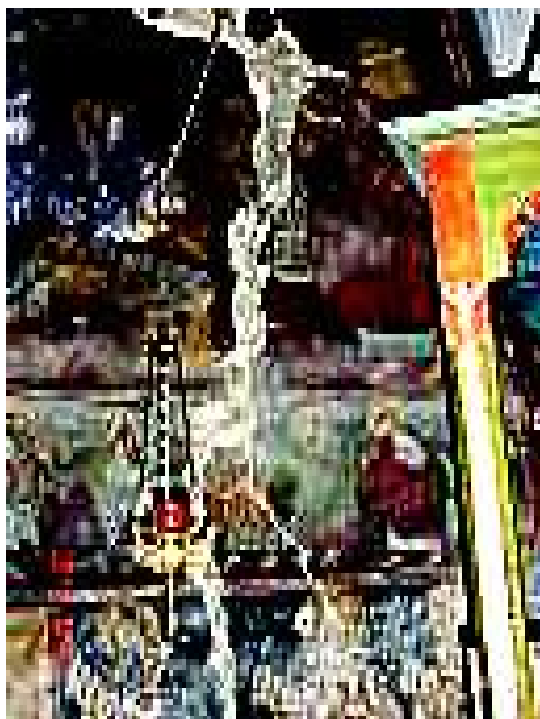
## *UPPER KRUTJE – LUSHNJA* **CHURCH OF ST. NICHOLAS**

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The church of St. Nicholas in Upper Krutje (Krutje e Sipërme) belongs to the variant of the churches of Myzeqe that are composed of the naos and closed galleries on three sides. Its naos is a basilica divided into three naves by a wooden colonnade and covered with a wooden ornamental ceiling. The entire interior is covered with wall

*Southeast view of the church.*





*Damaged roof and fissures in the masonry.*

paintings that were done in 1811 by Nicholas Çetiri of the eminent family of painters from Grabova. An important element of the interior decoration is the iconostasis, which is made of carved wood and dyed in a golden colour. The belfry tower, which was built in 1924, rises over the western entrance.

The church of St. Nicholas is the only church in a region composed of three villages which have about 900 Christian families and a permanent clergyman. The church functions constantly, with heavy attendance for the weekly liturgy, baptisms, weddings, deaths, requiems (liturgies for the dead) and other events. The churchyard contains the village graves, which are completely arranged.

The church building had reached a condition that could be considered dangerous for further use:

- There were a considerable number of fissures in the masonry. Most problematic were those in the apse, which posed the danger of complete detachment of this part from the rest of the building.
- As a result of the damage to the support structure of the roof, there was a marked deviation from the vertical in the masonry in the north and south.
- Separation of the wall faces from one another, that is, swelling of the masonry, could also be observed.
- The damaged roof and its covering had permitted rainfall to penetrate into the church interior, thereby seriously damaging the ornamental ceilings and wall paintings and also endangering the structural integrity of the building.

In order to remove the imminent danger, several measures were adopted: the masonry of the apse and the southern wall of the naos were shored. But these measures were quite tempo-

rary and not at all sufficient to avoid the danger presented.

For this reason, throughout the year 2002, other rescue measures were adopted, consisting of:

- The anchoring or connection of the northern masonry to the southern masonry with a steel cable, in order to prevent additional detachment of the building.
- The anchoring of the apse to the body of the naos, first strengthening the masonry of the building and the foundations underneath.
- The mending of the roof: replacing the deteriorated structural elements and restoring the roof completely.
- The shoring of the ornamental ceilings.
- The renovation of the shoring of the southern wall, and
- The cleaning and systemization of the western gallery and the consolidation of its wooden structures.

The intervention was implemented during the years 2003 by the Construction Company “JOGF”, directed by J. Basha, eng.

**The above work reached the sum of 1,754,900 lekë (US\$ 14,600).**



*Views of the church after restoration interventions.*

*View of the interior of the church.*





## *BISHQETHEM – LUSHNJA*

### **CHURCH OF ST. MARY**

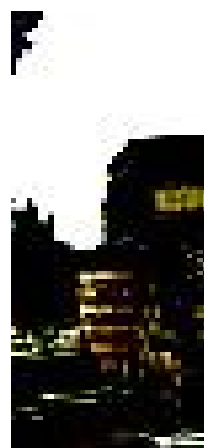
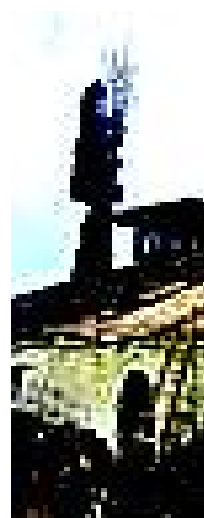
The church was built in the year 1798 and painted by John, a painter of the Çetiri family from Grabova. In typology, the church belongs to the variant of churches of Myzeqe. It is three-aisled covered with a flat ceiling. The naos has low covered galleries around it on three sides.

The last maintenance work in this church was done in 1987. Abandonment for a long time had resulted in serious damage both to the roof and to the support structures.

The rescue interventions consisted of:

- Mending the wooden structure of the roof by replacing the decayed or damaged beams.

*Views of the church from the north-west, after rescue interventions.*





*Southwest corner of the building before and after rescue interventions.*

*Views of the church before restoration.*

Southwestern corner of the building before and after restoration.

Views of the church before rescue interventions.

- Replacing the roof slates.
- Replacing all the tile roofing, using the existing whole tiles to a great extent and replacing the broken ones.
- Reconstruction of the belfry tower.
- Consolidation of the southwest corner of the gallery.

The work was implemented in 2003 by the Tirana Branch of the Institute of Monuments of Culture, directed by G. Samimi, eng., and cost the sum of **1,000,000 lekë (US\$ 10,000)**.

*Northern view of the church after the rescue interventions*



**MONUMENTS DESIGNED AND RESTORED WITH THE FUNDS  
OF THE ORTHODOX AUTOCEPHALOUS CHURCH OF ALBANIA  
(O.A.C.A)**

| NO                                | MONUMENT                                                       | PROJECT                                                       | IMPLEMENTED BY                                                                                                                                | REMARKS                                                                             | FUND (in lek)                         |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>COMPLETED RESTORATION WORK</b> |                                                                |                                                               |                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                     |                                       |
| 1                                 | Church of St. Nicholas, Grabova, Gramsh                        | O.A.C.A's O.T.S                                               | Company of Gramsh, A. Ago, M. Arapi- conservation of the ceiling, 1997-2001                                                                   |                                                                                     | 22.600.000                            |
| 2                                 | Monastery Church of St. John Vladimir, in Elbasan              | IMC R. Gega, arch                                             | JOGI Company, Fier and Tirana B.M 2004-2005                                                                                                   |                                                                                     | 9.343.000                             |
| 3                                 | Church of St. Mary, Leusa, Përmet                              | P. Thomo, L. Bozo- geology M. Arapi- painting                 | Berat B. M. AD-STAR (Përmeti) M. Arapi- conservation of the painting, A. Ago- conservation of the iconostasis and the ceiling 1999-2000       |                                                                                     | 45.600.000                            |
| 4                                 | Church of the Prophet Elijah, Lekël, Tepelena                  | O.A.C.A's O.T.S                                               | Company of Tepelena 1999-2000                                                                                                                 | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 17.000.000                            |
| 5                                 | Church of All Saints, Himara                                   |                                                               | ETAN company (Greece), SPEED company (Tirana), A. Ago, M. Arapi- conservation of iconostasis and ceiling 1993-1994 phase I 2000-2002 phase II |                                                                                     | 32.560.000 lekë<br>17.000.000 drahmes |
| 6                                 | Monastery of St. Demetrios, Qeparo, Himara                     | IMC                                                           | SPEED company, Tirana, 1996-2000                                                                                                              |                                                                                     | 27.800.000                            |
| 7                                 | Church of St. Spiridon, Vuno                                   |                                                               | Vlora B. M. 1998-1999                                                                                                                         | The church was set on fire before termination of work                               | 13.000.000                            |
| 8                                 | Church of St. Mary, Vrahogoranci, Gjiro-kastër (architecture)  | B. Strazimiri                                                 | B. Strazimiri-Tirana Berat B.M. 2001-2002                                                                                                     |                                                                                     | 15.000.000                            |
| 9                                 | Church of St. Mary, Vrahogoranci, Gjiro-kastër (wall painting) | M. Arapi                                                      | M. Arapi 2004                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                     | 2.000.000                             |
| 10                                | Church of the Archangels, Bodrisht, Gjiro-kastër               | P. Thomo                                                      | AD-STAR company (Përmet) 1999-2000                                                                                                            | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 13.650.000                            |
| 11                                | Church of the Dormition, Zervat, Gjiro-kastër                  | P. Thomo (architecture) Prof. Dr. H. Nallbani (wall painting) | AD-STAR Construction Company, Përmet                                                                                                          |                                                                                     | 40.000.000                            |
| 12                                | Church of St. Spiridon, Berat (quarter Gorica)                 | M. Baballëku & D.M.Berat                                      | M. Baballëku (Berat) 1996-2000                                                                                                                |                                                                                     | 29.300.000                            |

|                                    |                                                       |                                                                                              |                                                                                                                 |                                                                                     |                    |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| 13                                 | Monastery of Ardenica, Lushnja                        | IMC                                                                                          | Tirana B.M., GEN-RED, ELIRA Construction Companies (Fieri) 1996-1999                                            |                                                                                     | 20.000.000         |
| 14                                 | Monastery of St. Kozma, Kolkondas, Fieri              | IMC                                                                                          | GEN-RED, (restoration of church) ELIRA-Fier (road construction, enclosure, drainage) Const. Companies 1996-2000 | IMC restoration of the wall painting of the church of St. Mary                      | 71.600.000         |
| 15                                 | Church of St. George, Libofsha, Fier                  | IMC                                                                                          | Tirana B.M. 1996-1998                                                                                           |                                                                                     | 7.500.000          |
| 16                                 | Church of St. Nicholas, Vanaj, Fier                   | IMC                                                                                          | Tirana B.M. 1998-1999                                                                                           |                                                                                     | 7.200.000          |
| 17                                 | Monastery of Zvërnec, Vlora                           | O.A.C.A's O.T.S                                                                              | ARIS Company, Vlora B.M., ELIRA Company 1997-1999                                                               |                                                                                     | 38.540.000         |
| 18                                 | Monastery church of Zvërnec, Vlora                    | O.A.C.A's O.T.S Consultant P. Thomo, H. Nallbani-project of conservation of the works of art | B.M. Berati AD-STAR company (Përmot) H. Nallbani-wall painting M. Arapi, A. Ago-iconostasis 2003                |                                                                                     | 15.930.764         |
| 19                                 | Surrounding wall and Chapel in the Basilica of Ballsh | IMC and O.A.C.A's O.T.S G. Pani, arch                                                        | IRA Company, Ballsh 2000-2005                                                                                   |                                                                                     | 15.526.000         |
|                                    | <b>SUM</b>                                            |                                                                                              |                                                                                                                 |                                                                                     | <b>512.149.764</b> |
| <b>RESTORATION AND RESCUE WORK</b> |                                                       |                                                                                              |                                                                                                                 |                                                                                     |                    |
| 1                                  | Church of St. Mary, Voskopojë                         | O.A.C.A's O.T.S                                                                              | Korça B.M. 1999                                                                                                 |                                                                                     | 2.100.000          |
| 2                                  | Church of the Archangels, Voskopojë                   | O.A.C.A's O.T.S                                                                              | Korça B.M. 1999                                                                                                 |                                                                                     | 3.200.000          |
| 3                                  | Church of the Archangels, Gjirokastër                 | S. Mamaluko, arch (Greece)                                                                   | ETAN Company (Greece) 1992-1993                                                                                 |                                                                                     | 6.800.000          |
| 4                                  | Church of the Transfiguration, Gjirokastër            | Gjirokastër T.O.A.                                                                           | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 1993-1995                                                                                    |                                                                                     | 3.200.000          |
| 5                                  | Church of St. Athanasius, Bularat, Gjirokastër        | Gjirokastër T.O.A.                                                                           | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 1994,2002                                                                                    | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 2.300.000          |
| 6                                  | Church of Apostle Andrew, Rahulle-Gjirokastër         | Gjirokastër T.O.A.                                                                           | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 1995                                                                                         | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 2.100.000          |
| 7                                  | Church of St. Nicholas, Bodar-Përmet                  | Gjirokastër T.O.A.                                                                           | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 1995, 2000                                                                                   | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 650.000            |
| 8                                  | Church of St. Mary, Nivan-Gjirokastër                 | Gjirokastër T.O.A.                                                                           | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 1996                                                                                         | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 730.000            |



|    |                                                                                 |                    |                              |                                                                                     |           |
|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| 9  | Church of St. Nicholas, Dhrovjan i Poshtëm-Delvina                              | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 1996-1997 | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 760.000   |
| 10 | Monastery of St. George, Volloder-Saranda                                       | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 1996      | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 460.000   |
| 11 | Church of St. Nicholas, Dhrovjan i Sipërm                                       | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 1998      |                                                                                     | 1.100.000 |
| 12 | Monastery church of the Prophet Elijah, Stegopull, Gjirokaštër                  | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 1998      |                                                                                     | 560.000   |
| 13 | Church of St. Nicholas, Erind-Gjirokaštër                                       | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 1998-1999 | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 1.750.000 |
| 14 | Church of St. Mary, Peca, Delvina                                               | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 1999      | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 1.640.000 |
| 15 | Church of the Archangel Michael, Mingul-Gjirokaštër                             | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 1999      |                                                                                     | 450.000   |
| 16 | Church of the Representation of Our Lord, Labova e Madhe e Zhapës – Gjirokaštër | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 2000      | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 780.000   |
| 17 | Church of Apostles Peter and Paul, Hoshteva, Gjirokaštër                        | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 2000      |                                                                                     | 560.000   |
| 18 | Monastery church of Prophet Elijah, Vrina-Saranda                               | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 2001      | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 1.630.000 |
| 19 | Church of Prophet Elijah, Bual, Përmet                                          | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 2001      |                                                                                     | 720.000   |
| 20 | Church of St. George, Kardhikaq-Delvina                                         | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 2001      | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 2.400.000 |
| 21 | Church of St. Demetrios, Tërbuq-Gjirokaštër                                     | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 2001      | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 2.800.000 |
| 22 | Church of St. Athanasius, Goranxi-Gjirokaštër                                   | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. | Gjirokaštër T.O.A. 2002      | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 480.000   |

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|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 23 | Church of St. Parascevy, Sheper-Gjirokastër                         | Gjirokastër T.O.A. | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 2002-2003          | A church of historical and typological value, not included in the list of monuments | 1.300.000                                 |
| 24 | Monastery church of St. George, Çuka-Saranda                        | Gjirokastër T.O.A. | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 2002               |                                                                                     | 635.000                                   |
| 25 | Church of the Dormition, Ogdunaj, Përmeti                           | Gjirokastër T.O.A. | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 2002-2003          |                                                                                     | 650.000                                   |
| 26 | Church of the Entry of the Theotokos into the Temple, Benja-Përmeti | Gjirokastër T.O.A. | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 2002               |                                                                                     | 700.000                                   |
| 27 | Monastery of the Dormition of the Theotokos, Goranxi-Gjirokastër    | Gjirokastër T.O.A. | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 2002-2003          |                                                                                     | 3.250.000                                 |
| 28 | Monastery of the Dormition of the Theotokos, Dhuvjan-Gjirokastër    | Gjirokastër T.O.A. | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 2003               |                                                                                     | 4.550.000                                 |
| 29 | Monastery of the Archangels, Dervican-Gjirokastër                   | Gjirokastër T.O.A. | Gjirokastër T.O.A. 2001-2003          |                                                                                     | 2.350.000                                 |
| 30 | Church of St. Athanasius, Karavasta, Lushnja                        | IMC                | Tirana B.M, ELIRA company (Fier) 1999 |                                                                                     | 5.500.000                                 |
| 31 | Church of St. Nicholas, Krutje e Sipërme-Lushnja                    | R.D.F.S.L.         | JOGI construction company, Lushnja    |                                                                                     | 1.754.900                                 |
| 32 | Church of St. Mary, Bishqethëm-Lushnja                              | Tirana B.M.        | Tirana B.M.                           |                                                                                     | 1.000.000                                 |
|    | <b>SUM</b>                                                          |                    |                                       |                                                                                     | <b>58.643.093</b>                         |
|    | <b>TOTAL</b>                                                        |                    |                                       |                                                                                     | <b>560.752.109 Lekë<br/>5.607.493 USD</b> |

#### ***ABBREVIATIONS:***

**IMC:** Institute of Monuments of Culture

**B.M:** Branch of Monuments

**O.A.C.A's O.T.S:** Office of Technical Service of the Orthodox Autocephalous Church of Albania

**R.D.F.S.L:** Restoration Department of the Foundation "Spirit of Love"

**T.O.A:** Technical Office of the Archbishopric



